



Class Notes

Joseph

Genesis 37:2-50:26

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One family's dysfunction leads to division and hurt that spreads over many years and hundreds of miles, but the consequences of human failure aren't the end of the story. Experience the dramatic conclusion to the Genesis saga, and see how God's goodness overcomes human jealousy and betrayal.

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Module 1: Introduction to the Joseph Story

SESSIONS 1-4

Survey the shape of Genesis 37-50, and gain Bible study tools to help you unpack this dramatic story.

Session 1: Joseph and the Messianic Mosaic

Key Takeaways

- The Yoseph story is about God transforming betrayal into a vehicle for blessing and rescue.
- The biblical authors shaped the Yoseph story to enrich the developing portrait of the promised messiah.

Yaaqov's Sons in the Biblical Imagination

The stories found in Genesis 37-50 bring the narrative of the Genesis scroll to its climax, as Yaaqov's family is nearly destroyed by the jealous rivalry of his sons. The older brothers' envy of the youngest brother, Yoseph, sets in motion a chain of events that ultimately results in the salvation of the family from a terrible famine.

Below is a basic overview of the story.

Act 1—Genesis 37:2-41:57

Genesis 37a

- The beloved **Yoseph** dreams about being **elevated as ruler**

Genesis 37b

- a - Yoseph is kidnapped by jealous brothers
- b - **Reuven's failed plan** vs. **Yehudah's** successful plan = Yoseph enslaved in Egypt
- a' - Jealous **sons deceive father**

Genesis 38

- **Yehudah's** seed **rescued from ruin through the deception of his disguised** daughter Tamar

Genesis 39-41

- Slave **Yoseph is elevated as ruler** over Egypt

Act 2 — Genesis 42:1-45:25a

Genesis 42

- Because of famine, brothers go down to Egypt and are tested by a **disguised and deceptive** Yoseph who keeps one brother as a slave

Genesis 43-44

- Famine; **Deceptive** Yoseph again tests his brothers with beloved Binyamin
- **Reuven's failed plan** vs. **Yehudah's** successful intercession, offers himself as slave in Egypt

Genesis 45a

- Yoseph reveals his **disguise and deceptive test, rescues the seed of Yaaqov's seed from ruin**

Act 3 — Genesis 45:25b-50:26

45b-46a

- Yaaqov's family goes down to **ruler Yoseph** in Egypt, led by **Yehudah**

46b-47

- Yoseph rescues his family and the nations during the famine

48-50

- Yaaqov **blesses Yoseph**, **elevates Yehudah**, and **demotes Reuven**
- Promise of exodus up out of Egypt

Genesis 37:2-41:57 (Vertical). Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This ancient story of the sons of Yaaqov is not simply of historical interest for the biblical authors. Like the rest of the Genesis scroll, it serves as a template through which the biblical authors saw their entire world. These narratives of the past anticipate the rest of the story, which will focus on the descendants of these same rival sons.

Later Recollections: The Story of Yaaqov's Sons

- Numbers 13-14: Spies from the 12 tribes are sent to investigate the promised land. Joshua (from Ephrayim of Yoseph) and Caleb (from Yehudah) are the only spies among all the 12 tribes who trust Yahweh; the others die in exile while these two inherit the land.
- 1 Kings 11:26-40: The 10 northern tribes of Israel are led by Jeroboam son of Yoseph to rebel against Solomon son of Yehudah, and so the tribes divide into two kingdoms. Solomon is jealous and tries to kill Jeroboam, who flees into exile in Egypt (!).

- Ezekiel 37:15-22: Ezekiel develops the portrait of Yoseph's reconciliation with his brothers in Genesis 45-50, and he anticipates the final reconciliation of the brothers. He highlights the tribes of Yoseph and Yehudah as two separate groups that will be one, and their reunion will signal the inheritance of a renewed Eden.
- Zechariah 10:6-10: Zechariah sees Israel's past exile in Egypt as an image of Israel's present exile, and the division of the brothers as an image of Israel's scattering that will be reversed by yet another exodus and reconciliation of the family.
- 1 Chronicles 5:1-2: In this recollection of the family line of Yisrael, the Chronicler (who lives long after the Babylonian exile) reflects back on the reversal of birth order recounted in Genesis 37-50. But he also sees how that reversal anticipates the entire history of rivalry between the tribes of Yehudah and Yoseph narrated in the Former Prophets (Joshua-Kings).

1 Chronicles 5:1-2 NASB*

¹ And the sons of Reuven the **firstborn** of Yisrael
(for he was the **firstborn**,
but because he defiled his father's bed,
his **firstborn-right** was given to the sons of Yoseph the son of Israel;
and so he is not enrolled in the genealogy according to the firstborn-right.

² However, Yehudah proved more mighty among his brothers,
and from him came the leader,
yet the **firstborn-right** belonged to Yoseph)

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

- Acts 7:9-29: In Stephen's final speech before he is murdered, he recounts the story of the Torah and Prophets, focusing specially on two rulers in Israel who were rejected by their brothers: Yoseph and Moses. He sees a deep parallel between both figures, who were chosen by God to rule and deliver, but who were rejected and persecuted by their own family members. Stephen argues that this pattern has repeated itself in the rejection of Jesus Messiah by the leaders of Israel in his own day.

The Point

Later biblical authors see the story of Yoseph, Yehudah, and the division and reconciliation of the family as a forward preview of the entire history of Israel leading up to the messianic age.

These past stories were designed to display a pattern that kept repeating itself through Israel's history, leading up to the time of Jesus and the apostles.

For the biblical authors, the key to understanding their present and future was found in these narrative about their past. The past anticipates the future, and the present maps onto what has come before and what will come later.

Reflection Question

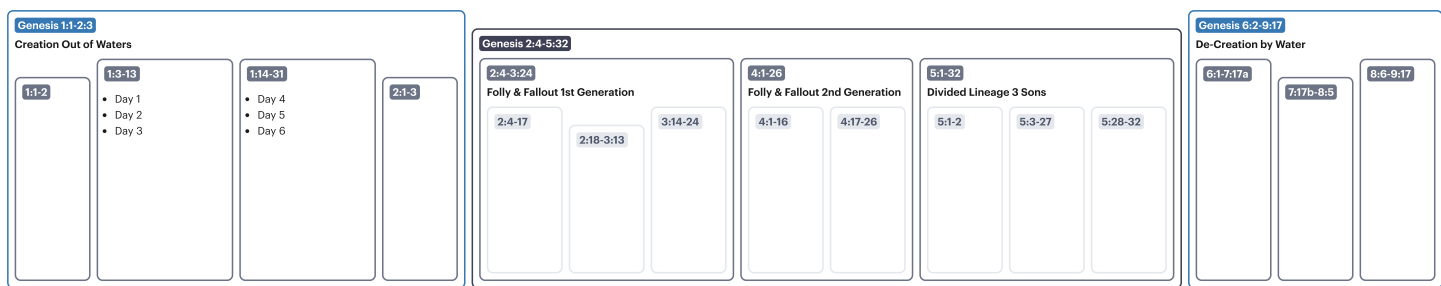
According to Jesus in Luke 24:44-47, what is the Hebrew Bible about? How should this guide the way we read the Joseph story?

Session 2: The Thematic Melody of the Hebrew Bible

Key Takeaways

- Like a symphony, the Hebrew Bible introduces readers to a pattern of key themes in its opening chapters, setting a template for the rest of the collection.
- The biblical authors structure Yoseph’s story around the pattern of themes from Genesis 1-11 by repeating the sequence of events and by repeating key vocabulary to signal this connection.

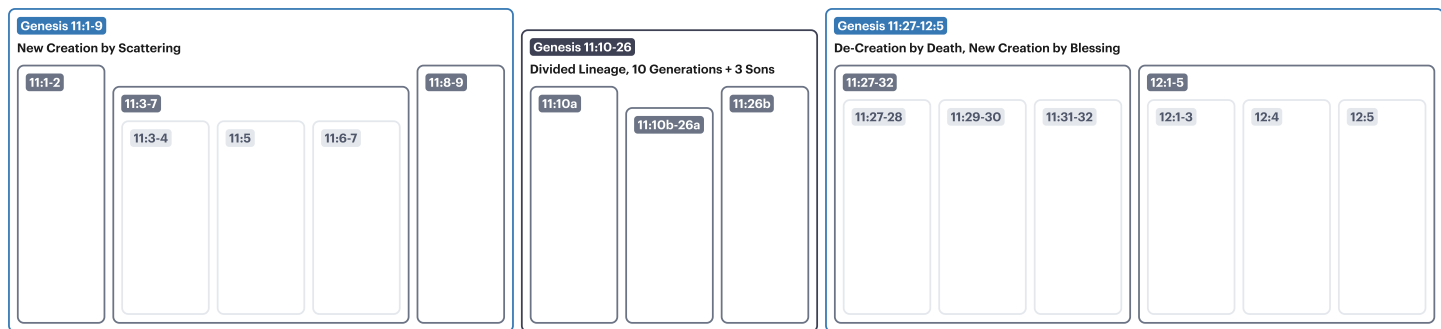
The Literary Design of Genesis and the Thematic Melody of the Hebrew Bible



Genesis 1:1-9:17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).



Genesis 6:1-11:9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).



Genesis 11:1-12:5. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

These thematic cycles set up a narrative pattern, a thematic melody, that re-cycles with each generation, developing and advancing the melody. The basic melody goes like this.

1. Creation and blessing

- God brings order/life/blessing out of chaos/waters/death/curse.
- Key words
 - Life, blessing, create, establish, seed, sprout, grow, fruit, fruitful, multiply
 - Seven, fullness, oath (all spelled שבע)
- Key images: dry land, refuge, safety, order

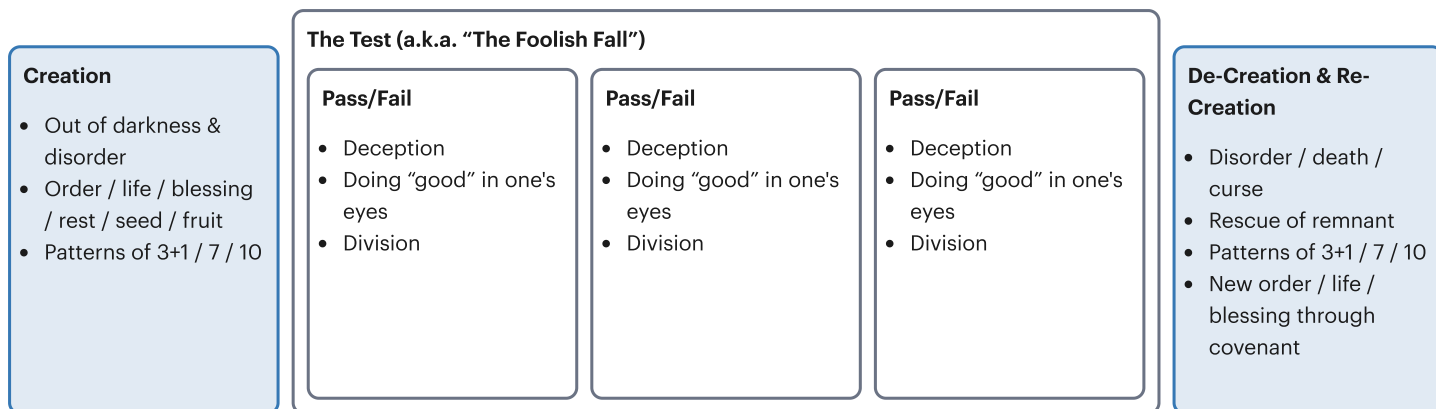
2. Folly, test, and failure (a.k.a. “the foolish fall”)

- God invites a chosen human partner to share in the order/life/blessing, which places a decision/test of their trustworthiness on the table.
- God’s chosen partner fails/succeeds the test, usually involving deception/division/violence.
- The same person/next generation faces their own opportunity and test and fails/succeeds, usually involving an intensified expression of deception/division/violence.
- The escalating sequence of tests and failures leads to a separation between the key characters so that one person or family splits off from the rest and is chosen by God for a new future.
- Key words found in Genesis 2-3, 4-5, 6:1-4.

3. De-creation and re-creation

- De-creation: God brings about an inversion of #1 above, usually an escalation of chaos/death/curse.
- Out of that de-creation, God chooses/preserves a remnant/seed and begins a new movement of re-creation through them, often marked by covenants and wordplays on the Hebrew root שבע, “seven/fullness/oath” or “covenant” (ברית).
- Key words found in Genesis 6:5-9:17.

4. Repeat



Genesis 1:1-11:26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

In what ways do you see Yoseph’s story replaying events from the early chapters of Genesis?

Session 3: The Shape of Biblical Literature

Key Takeaways

- The Bible is ancient Jewish meditation literature expertly crafted according to a set of design conventions that are unfamiliar to most modern readers.
- The biblical authors build connections and add layers of meaning by crafting this literature in sets (most commonly, sets of three) so that we can compare and contrast the different sections of each set and link to others.
- The intricate design of biblical literature invites us to slow down and meditate on its meaning, allowing it to shape us over a lifetime.

The Literary Design of Genesis 1-50

Movement 1—Genesis 1:1-11:26

From Adam to Noah to His 70 Descendants

1:1-5:32

Humanity = The exalted image of Elohim; Exile and death of the chosen

6:1-9:17

God brings a flood of justice, but saves a righteous remnant

9:18-11:26

Brothers divide after the flood

Movement 2—Genesis 11:27-25:18

From Abraham to Isaac

11:27-19:38

God chooses the younger son for blessing and covenant

20:1-22:19

God requires and gives back the life of the chosen son

22:20-25:18

Death, blessing, and the separation of the brothers

Movement 3—Genesis 25:19-37:1

From Isaac to Jacob

25:19-28:9

God chooses the younger son for blessing and covenant

28:10-31:52

God requires and gives back the life of the chosen son

32:1-37:1

Near-death, blessing, and the separation of the brothers

Movement 4—Genesis 37:2-50:26

From Jacob to His 12 Sons and 70 Descendants

37:2-41:57

Yoseph = The exalted image of Pharaoh; Exile and death of the chosen

42:1-45:25a

God brings a flood of famine, but saves a remnant

45:25b-50:26

Brothers are reconciled after the famine

Genesis 1-50. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

While every part of the Genesis scroll is patterned after earlier parts, there is a network of vocabulary and themes that are shared between these four larger movements that indicate a large-scale symmetrical arrangement.

The Key Design Conventions in Biblical Literature

What is the unique literary style of communication used by the biblical authors?

The key is found in the first literary unit of the Hebrew Bible (Gen. 1:1-2:3).

But before we go there, we need to remind ourselves of some of the basic categories of symmetry and design that we find in Hebrew poetry. These provide us with the basic axioms of biblical literature in general.

The work of the “Texture Seminar” scholars is foundational here.

- David Andrew Teeter, in his essay, “[Biblical Symmetry and Its Modern Detractors](#),” a paper delivered at the 2019 International Organization for the Study of the Old Testament.
- David Andrew Teeter and William Tooman, “[Standards of \(In\)coherence in Ancient Jewish Literature](#),” in Hebrew Bible and Ancient Israel, vol. 9 (2020), pp. 94-125.

But first, an aside on “analogical cognition.”

- Human cognition is built on a learned process of grouping, comparing, and contrasting all the sensory input that comes our way.
- This is like that, that is like this // This is not like that, that is not like this
- One of the most basic ways to present a meaningful comparison or contrast is to place two or three things next to each other and meditate on their similarities or differences.

For example, my wife has grouped three plants together on an old radio that we use as a decorative shelf by our dinner table.



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The unique features of each plant become more prominent only once we compare and contrast them to each other.

- All three are green.
- 1 and 2 have tan pots; 3 has a cream pot.
- 1 and 3 are big; 2 is small.
- 1 and 3 are elevated; 2 is not.
- 2 and 3 have thicker, rounded leaves; 1 does not.
- 1 and 3 have light and dark green leaves; 2 has mainly dark leaves.

The arrangement’s aesthetic effect depends on the viewer’s ability to compare and contrast the relationships between the various plants. The more we meditate on these relationships, the deeper the insight we gain into each.

The point: The arrangement of the plants is intentional, symmetrical, and invites the viewer to discover deeper layers of insight into all three plants by comparing and contrasting them with one another. Biblical

literature is built on this basic of principle.

Genesis 1:1-2:3 is entirely organized by this principle on every level of scale, from the smallest level of the line and arrangement of sentences into paragraphs, up to the largest levels of literary units, sections, parts, and movements that make up the scroll.

This design structure has arranged Genesis 1:1-2 into three parts, the center panel having two lines. Repeated words link every part together into a network of pairs and symmetries that lead the reader into meditation on their relationships.

1. Lines 1 and 2 mention “the land” but with different nuances of meaning.
 - Line 1 “land” is used in the phrase “skies and land.” // Line 2 “land” refers to the potential of land that is underneath the chaos waters.
2. Line 2 consists of two lines that pair together a variety of negative, pre-creation images.
 - “wild and waste” = a desert wasteland
 - “darkness” = the absence of light
 - “the deep” = the abysmal chaos waters
3. Lines 2 and 3 both mention “the waters,” but with different words.
 - Line 2: “the deep” = the uncontrolled, waters of chaos
 - Line 3: “the waters” = the neutral waters under the influence of the Spirit of Elohim
4. Lines 1 and 3 both mention Elohim in two related ways, as creator and as order-bringing Spirit.

The Function of Repetition and Symmetrical-Poetic Expression

This “speaking in pairs” creates opportunities to use multiple words and images to communicate one core idea from many angles. This type of poetic style is a wonderful way to express complex thoughts through pairing words or images in order to communicate more by means of the juxtaposition.

The biblical authors developed vocabulary for this technique called *mashal*.

Hebrew *mashal* (משל): comparison, analogy, proverb.

“The parallel lines of biblical poetry are like a pair of binoculars. Some centuries ago, the lenses of a field glass were set in cylinders that could be slid in and out, but they remained in a single tube. The lookout on a ship looked through it with one eye. Today’s field glass is a binocular: we look through two cylinders, with both eyes, so that we have the advantage of seeing depth. Our eyes, with or without binoculars, see ‘in stereo.’ The effect results from the fact that one eye has a slightly different angle than the other, and so produces a minimally different image. These two pictures are easily superimposed and assembled into one image inside our brain. Biblical parallelism does something comparable: this poetic device creates two subtly different images with two lines that are to be associated through parallel expression. It allows us an opportunity to consider both pictures separately, and then let them sink in together ... The point of similarity between two parallel lines is their very difference! Only those who look closely and have patience will discover and savor the role played by dissimilarity, its surprises, and its richness of meaning.”

Fokkelman, J.P. (2001). [*Reading Biblical Poetry*](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 78-79.

Reflection Question

How does tracing the literary design of the Bible help us better meditate on its meaning?

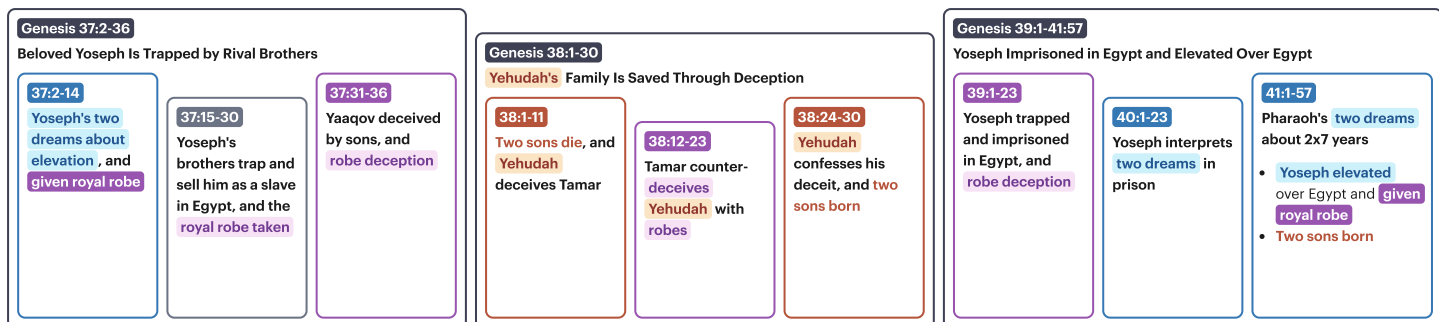
Session 4: A Tale of Two Seeds

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew word *toledot* translates to “generations,” and it serves as an important structural marker throughout Genesis as the story traces chosen and non-chosen family lines.
- Working out the implications of Genesis 3:15, the rest of the book prepares readers of the Hebrew Bible to be on the lookout for the chosen seed of the woman who will ultimately triumph over the snake.
- The Bible repeatedly subverts a cultural propensity toward ethnic exclusivity with the inclusion of members of the non-chosen family line in God’s plan to bring blessing to the whole world.

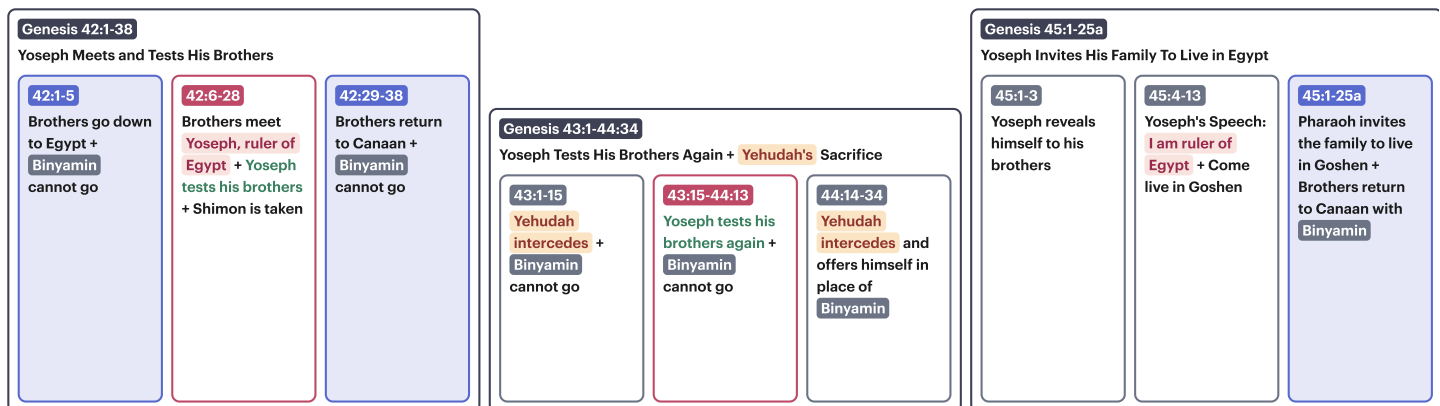
The Literary Design of the Yoseph Story: Genesis 37:2-50:26

Part 1: Genesis 37:2-41:57



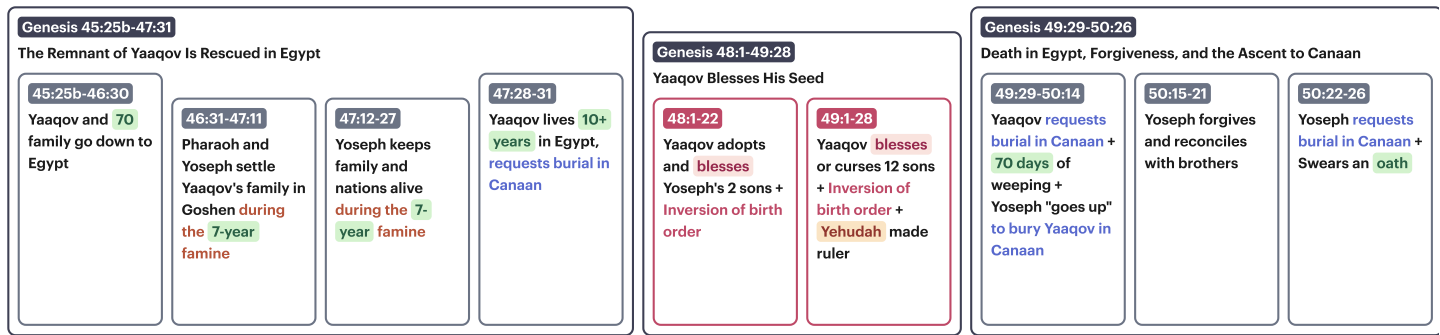
Genesis 37:2-41:57. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Part 2: Genesis 42:1-45:25a



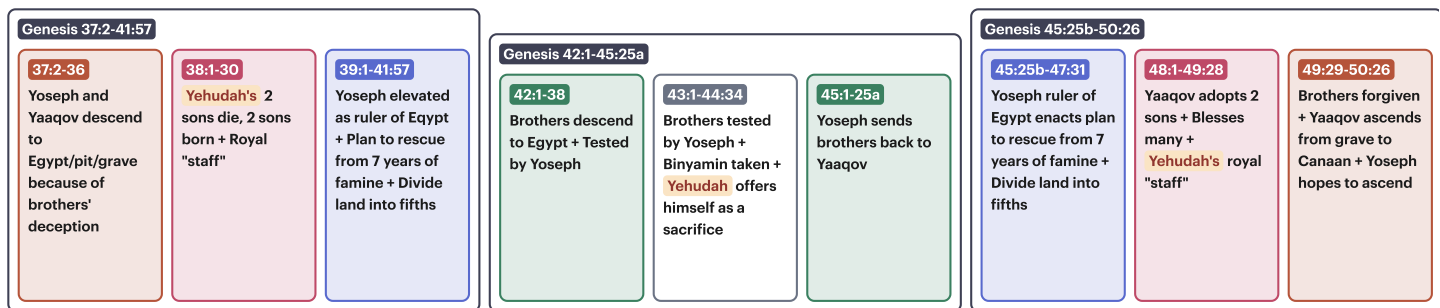
Genesis 42:1-45:25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Part 3: Genesis 45:25b-50:26



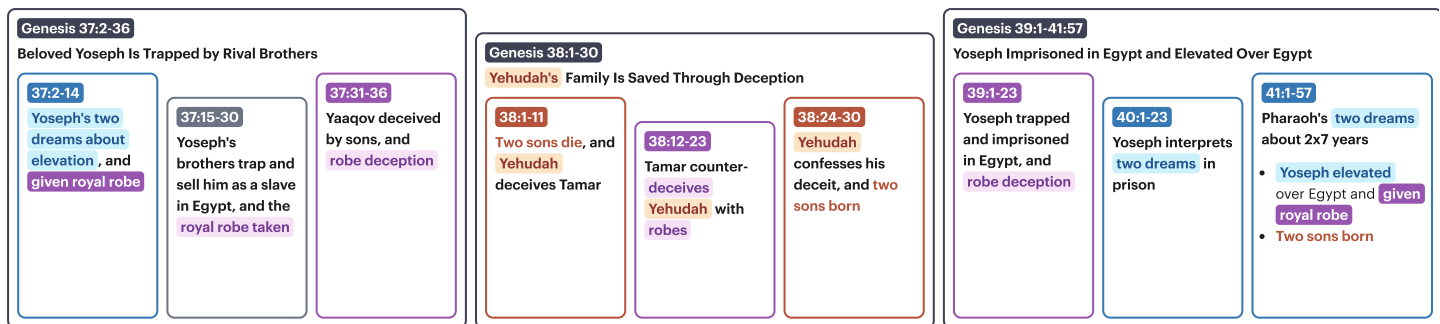
Genesis 45:25-50:26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

When we zoom out to take in Genesis 37-50 as a whole, a new set of relationships present themselves.



Genesis 37:2-50:26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Part 1: Yoseph's Descent and Ascent



Genesis 37:2-41:57. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This opening act of the Yoseph and Yehudah story is designed in a symmetrical way to show how the events set in motion by the brothers in chapter 37 are reversed and come full circle in chapter 41. The key plot conflict revolves around Yoseph's dreams of becoming ruler of the world and of his family (Gen. 37:2-14), and by the final scene of this act, those dreams start becoming reality (Gen. 41:1-57).

- Dreams: Yoseph's two dreams (ch. 37) // the two dreams of Pharaoh's servants (ch. 40) // the two dreams of Pharaoh that result in Yoseph's elevation as ruler (ch. 41)
- Robes: Yoseph is given a special robe that symbolizes his father's favoritism and also his dream of royal rule (ch. 37). That robe is taken away by his brothers and used to deceive Yaaqov (Gen. 37:31-36). // In the central story, Tamar the daughter also uses deceptive clothing to trick her father-in-law into having sex with her, in order to save his family's future (ch. 38). // Potiphar's wife also uses Yoseph's robe to

trick her husband (ch. 39). // Yoseph's royal robe is restored when he is elevated in Egypt in the restoration of his dreams (ch. 41).

- Deception: Yoseph is tricked and taken advantage of two times in this section, by his brothers (Gen. 37:15-30) and by Potiphar's wife (Gen. 39:1-23), both resulting in a series of descents: into a pit, then into Egypt, then into a prison which is later called a pit. // Yaaqov is deceived by his sons, who rob him of his favored son who is now believed to be dead (Gen. 37:33-35). // These two deceptions are mirrored by Tamar's deception that results in new life for Yehudah's family and reverses the deaths of the past.
- Death of the son: In chapter 37, Yaaqov loses the firstborn son of his beloved wife Rachel. // In chapter 38, Yehudah loses his two firstborn sons, only to have two new sons born to him through Tamar's deception. // In chapter 41, Yoseph, who is in Egypt because of his brothers' deception, gets married and has two sons.

The Puzzle of Genesis 38

The sordid story of Yehudah and Tamar in Genesis 38 may at first seem to be a digression from the main plotline of the Yoseph narrative. But this is only a surface-level impression. The core themes are deeply connected to the flow of Genesis 37-41 (royal rule, deception, robes, death of the son, future of the family), and the focus on Yehudah himself is anything but random. Yehudah is key to Yoseph's sale into slavery in chapter 17. And together with chapter 38, these stories form the counterpoint to the central role Yehudah will play in Act 2 (Gen. 42-45), specifically his humility and self-giving love when he offers his own life in the place of his brother Binyamin (Gen. 44:14-34).

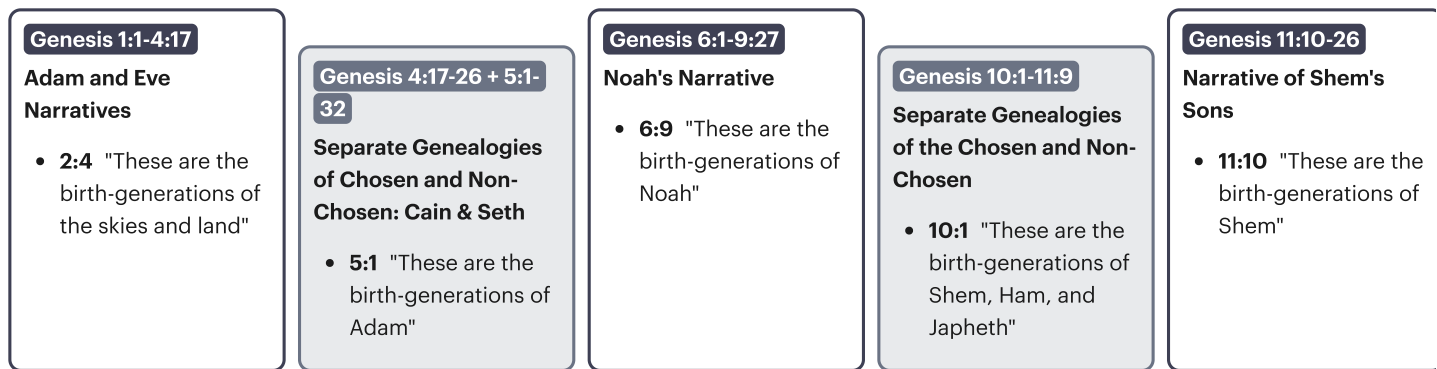
Section 1: Yoseph's Dreams and Hostile Brothers

Genesis 37:2a NASB

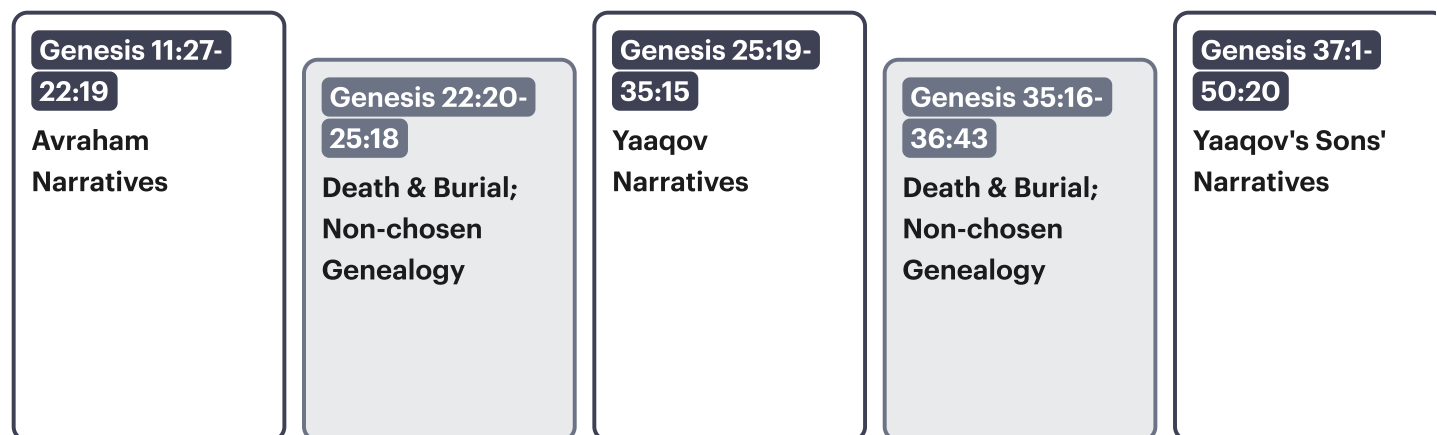
And these are the birth-generations of Yaaqov.

"Birth-generations" = Hebrew *toledot* / תולדות, which is a noun built from the root "to birth," meaning "the things that issued from" or "the things that were birthed from"

With this introductory phrase, the final literary movement of Genesis begins and ties this particular block of narratives into the wider themes of the entire scroll. This heading "These are the birth-generations of ..." appears 12 times in the Genesis scroll, six in Genesis 1:1-11:26, and six times in Genesis 11:27-50:26. In 10 of those 12 cases, the phrase has the same function, as it introduces the new descendants of each generation, one of whom will be singled out by God's blessing and election.

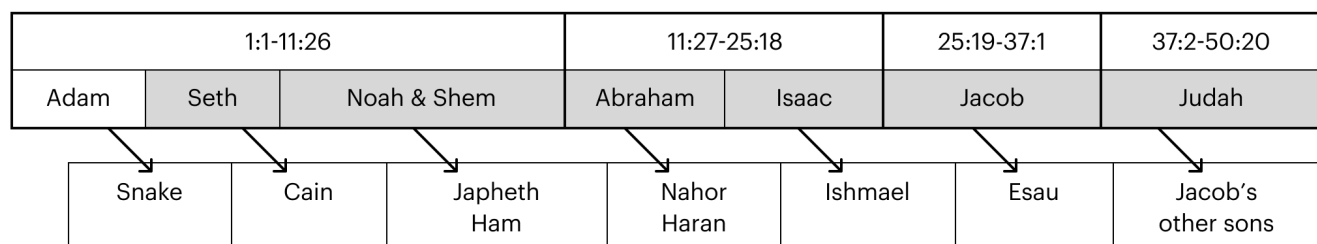


Genesis 1:1-11:26 (*Birth Generations*). Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).



Genesis 11:27-50:20. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

This pattern actually highlights an important compositional design throughout the entire Genesis scroll. The main narrative traces the lineage of the promised seed to a set of siblings. Then, after the story of their separation, the non-chosen line is ushered off the stage with a genealogy that extends far past the narrative time perspective. After this, the narrative backtracks and focuses on the chosen line, picking up their story.



Genealogies in Genesis. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

"These transitional headings ... progressively direct the reader's focus from the progenitor to progeny and narrow the reader's focus from all the world to Israel, through whom all the families of the earth will be blessed."

DeRouchie, Jason (2013). "[*The Blessing-Commission, the Promised Offspring, and the Toledot Structure of Genesis*](#)". JETS, Volume 56.2. 225.

"The Genesis story moves from (1) the skies and the land ([1:1-2:3](#)) to (2) humanity ([2:4-4:26](#)) to (3) Noah ([5:1-6:8](#)) to (4) Shem ([11:10-26](#)) to (5) Terah ([11:27-25:11](#)) to (6) Yitzhak ([25:19-35:29](#)) and finally to (7) Ya'akov ([37:2-50:26](#)) ... The seven divisions move from larger to smaller unit until the readers arrive at the central vehicle through which God will accomplish redemption—the nation of Israel represented by its twelve patriarchs. The toledot structure ensures that the narrative does not wander aimlessly but focuses attention on the line of promise commissioned to carry out God's purposes in the world."

Emadi, Samuel (2018). [*Yoseph, Covenant, and Typology*](#). Tyndale Bulletin, Volume 69.1. 50.

This compositional design shows the narrator's focus on tracing the lineage of the chosen family. This obsession with a particular family line is rooted in the early Genesis narratives about humanity's calling to rule creation. Once that calling is forfeited, the promise narrows in on the seed of the woman ([Gen. 3:15-16](#)) who will undo what was lost in Eden. The design of Genesis shows that tracing the line of this promised seed is of ultimate importance to the author. And in the Yoseph story, that promise leads us to two prominent sons: Yoseph and Yehudah.

Reflection Question

How do the birth-generation cycles of Genesis inform the way we ought to think of our own stories within the scope of God's plan?



Module 2: Joseph's Dreams and Hostile Brothers

SESSIONS 5-9

Meet Joseph the dreamer and follow the literary links that trace his descent from lofty visions of honor to the depths of despair in a pit.

Session 5: Joseph's Dream

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov's favoritism toward Rachel over Leah resurfaces in his preference for Yoseph. In both scenarios, this favoritism leads to strife and division.
- The meaning of the Hebrew word *passim*, often translated as "many colors," is unclear.
- The biblical authors link Yoseph's story to a pattern of brothers separating in Genesis including Cain and Abel, Abraham and Lot, and Yaaqov and Esau.
- Eden imagery fills Yoseph's dreams, echoing and expanding the promise of a royal seed of the woman.

Genesis 37: Macro Design

A - Genesis 37:2-14

a - 37:2-4

- Yoseph is a shepherd of the flock with his brothers
- **Yoseph is given the royal garment**
- Yisrael loved Yoseph more than his sons, and **they could not speak (דבר) peace (שלום) to him**

b - 37:5-11

- **Dialogue** between brothers and Yoseph: two dreams about ruling his brothers

a' - 37:12-14

- Yoseph sent to shepherd the flock with his brothers
- He is sent to "see **the peace (שלום) of your brothers**" and **return a word (דבר)** to Yaaqov

B - Genesis 37:15-30

a - 37:15-17

- A man finds Yoseph wandering in the field, looking for his brothers
- **"Where are they ...?"**

b - 37:18-24

- Yoseph approaches: **Reuven's plan** to throw him into the pit
- "Don't spill his blood ... or send a hand against him. ... Throw him into this pit!"
- **Yoseph is stripped of his royal garment**

b' - 37: 25-28

- Yoseph in the pit: **Yehudah's plan** to sell him as a slave
- "What's the gain in murdering our brother? Let's sell him, and don't our hands touch him."

a' - 37:29-30

- Reuven cannot find Yoseph in the pit
- "The boy is no more, and I, **where am I to go?**"

A' - Genesis 37:31-36

From Jacob to His 12 Sons and 70 Descendants

a - 37:31-32a

- **Brothers dip stolen royal garment** in blood of a **slaughtered** (שחט) goat from the flock
- Yaaqov is shown Yoseph's robe

b - 37:32b-33

- **Dialogue** between brothers and Yaaqov
- "This is the garment of my son, an animal has eaten him!"

a' - 37:34-36

- **Yaaqov tears his own robes** while Yoseph is taken to Egypt, to the captain of **the butchers** (טבח)

Genesis 37. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This opening chapter has a large-scale, three-part design (Gen. 37:2-14, 37:15-30, 37:31-36), and each part is framed by its own small-scale repetitions that create a network of symmetrical analogies.

Genesis 37:2-14: Yaaqov, Yoseph, and the Brothers

Yoseph is more beloved than his brothers, and his brothers cannot speak peace to him (v. 2-4). // Yoseph is sent by his father with a spoken word of peace (v. 12-14).

These outer parts surround a dialogue between Yoseph and his brothers about his dreams which exacerbate the hostility created by Yaaqov's favoritism.

Genesis 37:15-30: Yoseph and the Brothers

Yoseph is sent to his brothers, and he cannot find them ("Where are they?" v. 15-17). // Reuven comes to the pit but cannot find Yoseph ("Where am I to go?" v. 29-30).

When the brothers plan to kill Yoseph, two brothers enact an alternate plan. Reuven's plan to rescue Yoseph involves throwing him into a pit (v. 18-24), while Yehudah's plan involves selling him as a slave (v. 25-28).

Genesis 37:31-36: The Brothers and Yaaqov

The brothers take the robe of their brother Yoseph and dip it in the blood of a slaughtered (שחט) animal (v. 31-32a). // Yaaqov tears his own robes while Yoseph is taken to Egypt and sold to the captain of the butchers (טבח). In this analogy, Yoseph is compared to the slaughtered goat!

Paragraph 1: A Favored Son and a Hated Brother

² Yoseph was a son of seventeen years.

He was **shepherding** (רעה) the flock with **his brothers**.

And he was a young man,
with the **sons** of Bilhah ,
and with the **sons** of Zilpah ,
the wives of **his father**,

and Yoseph brought a **bad** (רעה) **report** (דבתם) about them to **their father**.

³ Now, **Yisra'el** **loved Yoseph more than all of his sons** ,

because he was for him a **son** of old age ,
and he made for him a robe of many colors.

⁴ And **his brothers** saw
that **their father** **loved him** ,
more than all of **his brothers** ,
and they hated him ,

and they were not able **to speak to him** (דברו) in peace.

Brothers' Hatred

A 5 And Yoseph dreamed a dream ,
and he told his brothers,
and they continued to hate him even more.

Yoseph's 1st Dream

6 And he said to them,
"Please listen to the dream that I dreamed !
7 And look, we were gathering sheaves in the midst of the field,
and look, my sheaf got up and then it stood,
B and look, your sheaves came around,
and they bowed down to my sheaf."
8 And his brothers said to him,
"Are you actually going to reign as a king over us?!
Or, will you actually rule us?!"

Brothers' Hatred

A' And they continued to hate him even more,
A' because of his dreams ,
and because of his words (דבריו).

Yoseph's 2nd Dream

9 And Yoseph dreamed again, another dream
and he recounted it to his brothers,
and he said,
"Look, I dreamed a dream again ,
and look, the sun and the moon and eleven stars were bowing down to me.
B' 10 And he recounted to his father and to his brothers,
and his father rebuked him,
and he said to him,
"What is this dream that you have dreamed ?
Will we really, I and your mother and your brothers,
come to bow down to you on the ground?!"

Brothers' Jealousy

A" 11 And his brothers were jealous of him ,

but **his father** kept **the word** (הדבר).

¹² And **his brothers** went **to shepherd** the flock of their father in **Sh'khem**,

¹³ and Yisra'el said to Yoseph,
"Aren't **your brothers** **shepherding** in **Sh'khem** ?

Go, **let me** send you to them."

And he said to him,

"Look, it's me."

¹⁴ And he said to him,

"Go, please.

Look after the peace of **your brothers**, and the peace of the flock,
and return to me **a word** (דבר)."

And **he sent him** from the valley of Hebron,
and he came to **Sh'khem**.

Genesis 37:2-14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

A Father's Favoritism and Rival Brothers

The story begins by highlighting Yoseph, son of Rachel, among Yaaqov's other sons and wives. This recalls the favoritism Yaaqov showed for Yoseph's mother, which was stated in exactly the same language.

Genesis 29:16-18 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ Now Laban had two daughters; the name of the older was Leah, and the name of the younger was Rakhel. ¹⁷ And Leah's eyes were weak, but Rakhel was beautiful of form and face. ¹⁸ Now **Yaaqov loved Rakhel**, so he said, "I will serve you seven years for your younger daughter Rakhel."

Genesis 29:30-31 Instructor's Translation

³⁰ So Yaaqov went in to Rakhel also, and indeed **he loved Rakhel more than Leah**, and he served with Laban for another seven years. ³¹ Now the Lord saw that **Leah was hated**, and he opened her womb, but Rakhel was barren.

And this favoritism that Yaaqov displayed toward his wives, a favoritism that introduced division and jealousy between the sisters, was itself a replay of how Yaaqov's parents treated him and his brother.

Genesis 25:28 Instructor's Translation

Now **Isaac loved Esau**, because he had a taste for game, but **Rebekah loved Yaaqov**.

This favoritism was what divided Yaaqov and Esau and ultimately caused their separation and alienation from one another. And these stories of human favor are themselves a distorted mirror that echoes the many moments of divine favor given to a chosen one that also causes division between siblings.

- Humanity is chosen to rule over the animals ([Gen. 1](#)).
- Abel's sacrifice is favored over that of Cain, the firstborn ([Gen. 4](#)).
- Shem is elevated and blessed over his brothers Japheth and Ham ([Gen. 9:24-27](#)).
- Abram is chosen over his brothers Nahor and Haran ([Gen. 11:26-32](#)).
- Sarah and Isaac chosen over Hagar and Ishmael ([Gen. 16-17, 21](#)).

In each case, the divine/fatherly favor creates a division among siblings, which then generates jealousy and hostility between family members. The author wants us to bring all those stories to bear upon this final story about the favored Yoseph and his brothers.

A Son's Dreamy Royal Robe

The terms used to describe Yoseph's robe combine a common word and a unique word.

The English translations say:

- Varicolored tunic (NASB)
- Ornate robe (NIV)
- Robe of many colors (ESV)
- Robe with long sleeves (NRSV)
- Coat of many colors (KJV)

The Hebrew word is *ketonet passim*, כֶּתֶנֶת פָּסִים.

The Old Greek (Septuagint) uses *khitona poikilon*, χιτώνα ποικίλον.

This phrase is only used one other time in the Hebrew Bible, to describe the coat of Tamar, the daughter of David who is raped by her brother ([2 Sam. 13:18-19](#)). That story is a deliberate hyperlink back to the story of Yoseph, who was abused by his brothers, and neither story focuses on the shape or appearance of the garment.

The translation "many colors" in the KJV was derived not from the meaning of the Hebrew word *passim*, but from the choice made by the Septuagint translators to use *poikilos*, which means "diverse, multi-part."

Yoseph's Dreams of Royal Rule

Yoseph's royal dreams connect to a major theme that has quietly been running throughout the Genesis scroll about humanity's calling to rule creation as the image of Elohim. This theme first appears in the image of Elohim poem found in day six of the first creation story ([Gen. 1:26-28](#)). Here, humanity's earthly rule corresponds to that of the heavenly rulers appointed in day four ([see Gen. 1:14](#)).

Day 4: The heavenly lights rule (משל) the day and night	Gen. 1:14–18 Then God said, “Let there be lights in the expanse of the heavens to separate the day from the night, and let them be for signs. ... God made the two great lights, the greater light to rule (משל) the day, and the lesser light to rule (משל) the night; he made the stars also. ... God placed them in the expanse of the heavens to give light on the earth, and to rule (משל) the day and the night, and to separate the light from the darkness; and God saw that it was good.
Day 6 The earthly humans to rule (רדה) over the land creatures	Gen. 1:26–28 Then God said, “Let us make human in our image, according to our likeness; and let them rule (רדה) over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the sky and over the cattle and over all the earth, and over every creeping thing that creeps on the earth.” ... God blessed them; and God said to them, “Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the earth, and subdue it; and rule (רדה) over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the sky and over every living thing that moves on the earth.”
<i>Comparing Day 4 and Day 6 of Creation. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Humanity’s calling is to rule over the land creatures, but as [Psalm 8](#) and [Daniel 7](#) make clear, this was part of a larger plan to exalt humanity as a cosmic ruler over Heaven and Earth together.

After humanity’s exile from Eden and the promise of a snake-crushing seed of the woman ([Gen. 3:15](#), [3:21-24](#)), the lineage is followed throughout Genesis, with promises of future kings peppering the story.

Genesis 17:5-6 NASB*

⁵ No longer shall your name be called Abram, But your name shall be Abraham; for I will make you the father of a multitude of nations. ⁶ I have made you exceedingly fruitful, and **I will make nations of you,** and **kings will come forth from you.**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 17:15-16 NASB

¹⁵ Then God said to Abraham, “As for Sarai your wife, you shall not call her name Sarai, but Sarah shall be her name. ¹⁶ I will bless her, and indeed I will give you a son by her. Then I will bless her, and **she shall be a mother of nations; kings of peoples will come from her.”**

Genesis 35:10-11 NASB*

¹⁰ God said to him, “Your name is Yaaqov; you shall no longer be called Yaaqov, but Yisrael shall be your name.” Thus he called him Yisrael. ¹¹ God also said to him, “I am God Almighty; be fruitful and multiply; a nation and **a company of nations shall come from you,** and **kings shall come forth from you.”**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

And so, as we begin the Yoseph story, we wonder if this ancient promise of a royal seed will be fulfilled through this favored son. It turns out that this theme will get a bit more complicated, as both Yoseph and Yehudah will participate in this promise.

Reflection Question

What literary clues, linked to earlier stories in Genesis, do the biblical authors use to set the stage for the coming conflict in Yoseph's story?

Session 6: A Man in the Field

Key Takeaways

- The narrative hinges on Yoseph's encounter with the man in the field. If Yoseph had not met this man, he and his entire family would have died in the famine.
- For the biblical authors, every moment of human existence is woven into God's plan for creation.
- The Midianites and Ishmaelites become entangled in the brothers' plot to get rid of Yoseph. It's as if all of Abraham's non-chosen children conspire to oppose the chosen son.

Overview of Genesis 37:15-30

A – Genesis 37:15-17

- Yoseph goes to seek brothers, cannot find, meets a man in the field
- **Where** are the brothers?

B – Genesis 37:18-25a

- Brothers see Yoseph coming
- **Reuven** intercedes to save Yoseph: "Don't spill blood ... or let our hand be against him."
- Yoseph thrown down into pit

B' – Genesis 37:25b-28

- Brothers see traders coming
- **Yehudah** intercedes to spare Yoseph: "What's the gain of murder? ... Don't let our hand be against him."
- Yoseph taken up from pit, taken down to Egypt

A' – 37:29-30

- Reuven seeks brother, cannot find
- " **Where** will I go?"

Genesis 37:15-30. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This central paragraph of chapter 37 is designed as a three-part symmetry, with matching outer panels (37:15-17 and 37:29-30) and matching inner panels (37:18-25a and 37:25b-28). The matching parts create

important comparisons and contrasts that will be further developed in the following narratives.

15 And a man **found** him,
and look, he was wandering about in a field,

and the man asked, saying ,
“What are you looking for?”

16 And he said,
“I am looking for **my brothers**.
Tell me, please,
where are they shepherding?”

17 **And the man said** ,
“They journeyed on from here.
Indeed, I heard them saying,
‘Let’s go to Dothan.’”

And Yoseph **went** after **his brothers**,
and he **found** them in **Dothan** .

18 And they saw him from afar,
and before he came near to them,
they made a deceitful plan to kill him.

19 And they said, each to **his brother**,
“Look, **this master** of **the dreams**, he comes!

20 And now, come, **let’s murder him**,
and let’s **throw him into one of the pits**,
and we will say,

‘A terrible **animal ate him!**’
and we will see what comes of **his dreams!**”

21 And **Reuven** heard,
and he delivered him from their hand,

and he said ,
“**Don’t strike his life!**”

22 And **Reuven** said to them,
“**Don’t spill blood!**

Throw him into this pit that's in the wilderness.

But don't send out a hand against him."

It was in order to deliver him from their hand,
to return him to his father.

23 And it came about when Yoseph came to his brothers,
that they stripped Yoseph of his robe,
the robe of many colors that was on him,

24 and they took him and they threw him into the pit,
and the pit was empty, with no water in it.

25a And they sat down to eat bread.

25b And they lifted their eyes and they saw,
and look, a caravan of Yishma'elites coming from Gil'ad,
and their camels were carrying spice-gum, balm, and myrrh,
they were coming to go down to Egypt .

26 And Yehudah said to his brothers,
"What profit is there if we murder our brother,
and cover up his blood?

27 Come , and let's sell him to the Yishma'elites ,
and don't let our hand be upon him ,
because, he is our brother and our flesh ."

And his brothers listened.

a 28 And Midianite men, traders, passed by,

b and they drew up and brought Yoseph up from the pit,

b' and they sold Yoseph to the Yishma'elites for twenty silver pieces,

a' and they brought Yoseph to Egypt .

29 And Reuven returned to the pit,
and look, Yoseph was not (יֵאֵ) in the pit,

and he tore his clothes.

30 **And he returned to his brothers,**
and he said,
“The child, he is **no more (אֵינְנוּ)** !
And as for me, **where am I to go?!**”

Genesis 37:15-30. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

The Mysterious Man in the Field

This scene of Yoseph encountering a random man in the field is not random at all, but a key part of the narrative message at work in the larger story of Yoseph. If it were not for this man, Yoseph would not have found his brothers, and he would not have been kidnapped, sold as a slave, and taken to Egypt. Without going to Egypt, Yoseph would not have been discovered by Pharaoh and elevated as ruler of Egypt able to save his family from the famine.

If Yoseph had not met this man, he and his entire family would have died in the famine.

It cannot be a coincidence, then, that Yoseph encounters a “man” (אִישׁ) who directs him toward his brothers’ true location. We are meant to see a similarity here with Abraham’s encounter with the “men” (אֲנָשִׁים) who walk by his tent (Gen. 18:1-5), and with the “man” (אִישׁ) who comes to Yaaqov at the Yabbok and picks a fight with him (Gen. 32:23-32). We are surely meant to see this man as yet another disguised divine messenger (that is what the men Abraham encountered are called in Gen. 19:1-3) who guides Yoseph toward his destiny. God intentionally leads the beloved Yoseph into danger as part of his paradoxical plan to exalt him.

The “Man” in Genesis 37:15-17

Gen. 37:15 And **a man (אִישׁ)** found him, and behold **he was wandering (תעה)** in the field, and **the man (אִישׁ)** **asked him (שאל)**, saying, “**What (מה)** do you seek?”

The “Men” in Genesis 18, 21 and 32

Gen. 18:2 And Avraham lifted his eyes, and behold, **three men (אִישׁ)** standing over him

Gen. 21:14 ... and [Hagar] went and **wandered (תעה)** in the wilderness

Gen. 21:17 ... and the angel of God called to Hagar from heaven and said to her, “**What (מה)** to you, Hagar?”

Gen. 32:24 And Yaaqov was left alone, and **a man (אִישׁ)** struggled with him

Men in Genesis 18-37. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

The “Man” in Genesis 37:15-17

The “Men” in Genesis 18, 21 and 32

Gen. 32:28 And [the man] said, “ **What (מה)** is your name?”

Gen. 32:30-31 And Ya'akov **asked (שאל)** and said, “Tell me your name?” And he said, “For **what (למה)** do you **ask (שאל)** for my name?”

Men in Genesis 18-37. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph is likely alluding to this very scene when he speaks with his brothers in Egypt.

Genesis 45:7-8 Instructor's Translation

⁷ Elohim sent me before you,
to preserve for you a remnant in the earth,
and to keep you alive by a great deliverance.

⁸Now, therefore, it was not you all who sent me here, but Elohim;
and he has made me a father to Pharaoh
and lord of all his household
and ruler over all the land of Egypt.

Murderous Brothers and Rescue Plans

The jealous anger of Yoseph’s brothers recalls a motif that has repeated in every generation of characters. When God elevates his chosen one, the non-chosen people consistently respond with anger and jealousy that leads to violent conflict and deception. Less often, the non-chosen people respond with humility and a recognition of God’s blessing.

The Chosen	The Non-Chosen’s Negative Response	
Humanity	Land animals, including the snake	Genesis 1, 3
Abel	Cain: anger and violence	Genesis 4
Noah	Generation of the flood: violence in the land	Genesis 6
Abraham	Lot: conflict over land possession	Genesis 13

The Chosen and Non-Chosen’s Responses. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

The Chosen	The Non-Chosen's Negative Response	
Isaac & Sarah	Ishmael & Hagar: Sarah is jealous and abusive	Genesis 16, 21
Isaac	Abimelech: jealous and angry	Genesis 26
Jacob	Esau: Jacob is deceptive, Esau is violently angry	Genesis 25, 27
<i>The Chosen and Non-Chosen's Responses. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>		

These narratives paint an accumulative portrait of a humanity that does not understand, or feels threatened by, God's purpose to raise up one human family among the many to be the vehicle of divine rule and blessing for all the others.

This is precisely what the brothers resist: the elevation of their youngest brother to the place of rule over the family.

Reuven and Yehudah as Rivals

Notice how the literary design of this paragraph contrasts the unsuccessful plan of Reuven, the firstborn of Leah, with the successful plan of Yehudah, the fourth-born of Leah. This is a key part of the design of the larger Yoseph story to elevate Yehudah as the real leader among the brothers. This scene is matched by the later scene when Reuven and Yehudah propose plans to Yaaqov for returning to Egypt to get more food (in [Gen. 43](#)), and Yehudah's plan succeeds.

Genesis 37	Genesis 43	Genesis 49
Reuven's plan to rescue Yoseph fails	Reuven's plan to offer his sons fails	Reuven is cursed for his selfishness
Yehudah's plan to sell Yoseph succeeds	Yehudah's plan to offer himself succeeds	Yehudah appointed as the royal leader of his brothers
Yoseph sold into slavery	Yoseph becomes ruler of Egypt	Yoseph is blessed more than his brothers
<i>Genesis 37 Leading to Genesis 49. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>		

The Sons of Abraham Conspire Against the Chosen Son

The narrative clearly highlights how all the brothers are in the plot to resist Yaaqov's elevation of Yoseph and to prevent his dreams from coming true.

But there are other, more distant relative brothers who also become entangled in the plot. The presence of the Yishmaelites widens the circle of culpability, so that the entire family of Abraham plays a role in the loss of the beloved son.

Genesis 37:25b Instructor's Translation

And behold, a caravan of **Yishmaelites** (ישמעאלים) came from Gilead

Genesis 37:28 Instructor's Translation

And **Midianite** (מדינים) men, traders, passed by, and [the brothers] drew up and raised up Yoseph out of the pit, and they sold (מכר) Yoseph to the **Yishmaelites** (ישמעאלים) ... and they brought Yoseph there.

Genesis 37:36 Instructor's Translation

And the **Medanim** (מדנים) sold him to Egypt, to Potiphar the captain of the guard ...

Genesis 39:1 Instructor's Translation

And Potiphar ... an Egyptian man purchased him from the hand of the **Yishmaelites** (ישמעאלים) who took him down to Egypt.

The narrative clearly leads the reader to associate all of these titles as references to a single group of caravan traders. However, each of these three titles in Genesis 37 is linked with the wider family of Abraham listed in Genesis 25.

Genesis 25:1-6 Instructor's Translation

¹ Now Avraham took **another wife**, whose name was **Keturah**.

² **She bore to him** Zimran and Jokshan and **Medan** and **Midian** and Ishbak and Shuah. ...

⁵ Now Avraham gave all that he had to Yitzhak; ⁶ but to the sons of his concubines, Avraham gave gifts while he was still living, and sent them away from his son Yitzhak eastward, to the land of the east.

Genesis 25:12-13, 18 Instructor's Translation

¹² Now these are the generations of Yishmael, Avraham's son, whom **Hagar** the Egyptian, **Sarah's slave**, **bore to Avraham**;

¹³ and these are the names of the sons of **Yishmael**, by their names, in the order of their birth: Nebaioth, the firstborn of Yishmael, and Kedar and Adbeel and Mibsam ...

¹⁸ They settled from Havilah to Shur which is east of Egypt as one goes toward Assyria; he settled in defiance of all his relatives.

These different tribes descending from Abraham have distinct origins. Medan and Midian come from Keturah, while Yishmael comes from Hagar. However, the title Yishmaelites in Genesis 37:25 is used to refer to a

broader category of tribal merchants from the east, which can include various sub-clans as Medan and Midian.

This same association of these tribes appears in Judges 8:22-24 and in Isaiah 60:5b-7.

Judges 8:12, 21-24

¹² When Zebah and Zalmunna fled, he pursued them and captured the two kings of **Midian**, Zebah and Zalmunna, and routed the whole army. ...

^{21b} So Gideon arose and killed Zebah and Zalmunna, and took the crescent ornaments which were on their camels' necks. ²² Then the men of Israel said to Gideon, "Rule over us, both you and your son, also your son's son, for you have delivered us from the hand of **Midian**."

²³ But Gideon said to them, "I will not rule over you, nor shall my son rule over you; the LORD shall rule over you." ²⁴ Yet Gideon said to them, "I would request of you, that each of you give me an earring from his spoil." (For they had gold earrings, because they were **Yishmaelites**.)

Isaiah 60:5b-7

^{5b} The wealth of the nations will come to you.

⁶ A multitude of camels will cover you, the young camels of **Midian** and **Ephah**; all those from **Sheba** will come.

They will bring gold and frankincense, and will bear good news of the praises of the LORD.

⁷ All the flocks of **Kedar** will be gathered together to you, the rams of **Nebaioth** will minister to you; they will go up with acceptance on my altar, and I shall glorify my glorious house.

Genesis 25:2-4 – Sons of Keturah

² Keturah bore to [Avraham] Zimran and Jokshan and **Medan** and **Midian** and Ishbak and Shuah. ³ Jokshan became the father of **Sheba** and Dedan. ... ⁴ The sons of Midian were **Ephah** and Epher

Genesis 25:13 – Sons of Yishmael

The names of the sons of **Yishmael**, by their names, in the order of their birth: **Nebaioth**, the firstborn of Yishmael, and **Kedar** and Adbeel and Mibsam

Judges and Isaiah in Genesis 25. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Conclusion

Genesis 37 portrays all the sons of Yaaqov as replaying their fathers' failures, an intensified act of betrayal against the beloved son of God's promise. The appearance of the Yishmaelites and Midianites includes the wider family of Abraham in the betrayal, so that the entire line of Abraham's blessed lineage is caught up (intentionally or unintentionally) in the betrayal that will fracture the family, only to bring it together in the ultimate reunification under Yoseph's reign.

Reflection Question

What can we take away from how the biblical authors incorporate Yoseph's encounter with a man in the field?

Session 7: Down Into the Pit

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors liken Yoseph's descent into the pit to an animal sent to slaughter. Details like the goat killed for its blood and Potiphar, captain of the butchers, give shape to this image.
- Through repetition of key vocabulary, the biblical authors link Yoseph's betrayal with the binding of Isaac.
- Human evil leads to the death of the beloved one, but God provides a *takhat* (a substitute, one who stands in the place of another).

Paragraph 3: Genesis 37:31-36

³¹ And they took **the robe** of Yoseph,
and they **slaughtered** a **hairy goat**,
and they dipped **the robe** in the blood,
³² and they sent **the robe** of many colors,
and they brought it to **their father**.

And they said,
"We found this!
Recognize it, please!
Is it **the robe** of **your son**, or not?"
³³ And he **recognized it**,
and he said,
"**The robe** of **my son**!
A terrible **animal** ate him!
Yoseph has certainly been torn apart!"

³⁴ And Ya'akov tore **his clothes**,
and he placed **sackcloth** on his thighs,
and **he grieved over his son** for many days.
³⁵ And all his sons and all his daughters got up to **comfort** him,
and he refused to be **comforted**,
and he said,

“Surely, I will go down to **my son**, **grieving**, to She’ol!”
 And **his father wept for him**,
 36 but as for the **Medanim**, they sold him to Egypt,
 to Potiphar, official of Phar’oh,
 captain of the **butchers**.

Genesis 37:31-36. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

The Deceptive Animal (Garment)

Adam and Eve are deceived by a spiritual being who takes up the animal disguise of a snake, and so they end up clothed with the skin of an animal and exiled from Eden ([Gen. 3](#)).

Yaaqov put on the skin of a slaughtered goat in order to deceive his father and gain the blessing, only to find himself exiled from Canaan ([Gen. 27](#)).

Yoseph loses his royal robe, his brothers smear it with the blood of a slaughtered goat to deceive their father, and Yoseph finds himself exiled from Canaan ([Gen. 37](#)).

A Beloved Son and a Slaughtered Goat

Notice how the cloak, bloodied by a slaughtered goat, becomes a twisted image of Yoseph’s status as the beloved son who was supposed to be elevated to a place of rule and honor among the brothers.

The capture and sale of Yoseph is replete with language from the Aqedah in [Genesis 22](#), which is full of ironic inversions and twists.

Yaaqov, Yoseph, and a Goat in Genesis 37	Avraham, Yitskhaq, and a Ram in Genesis 22
Gen. 37:3 Yoseph is Yaaqov’s “son of old age” (בן זקנים), whom he loves (אהב) more than his brothers.	Gen. 21:2, 7; 22:2 Yitskhaq is Avraham’s “son of old age” (בן לזקניו), whom he loves (אהב)
Gen. 37:13 Yaaqov calls for Yoseph, “and he said, ‘Here I am’ (הנני)”	Gen. 22:1 God calls for Avraham, “and he said, ‘Here I am’ (הנני)” Gen. 22:7 Yitskhaq calls for Avraham, “and he said, ‘Here I am’ (הנני)” Gen. 22:11 The Angel of Yahweh calls for Avraham, “and he said, ‘Here I am’ (הנני)”
Rams and Goats in Genesis. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Yaaqov, Yoseph, and a Goat in Genesis 37	Avraham, Yitskhaq, and a Ram in Genesis 22
Gen. 37:18 "And they [the brothers] saw (ראה) him [Yoseph] from afar (מרחק) "	Gen. 22:4 "And Avraham saw (ראה) the place from afar (מרחק) "
Gen. 37:20 "Let's say an evil beast ate him (אכל) ..." Gen. 37:24-25 "And they took him (לקח) ... and they sat down to eat (אכל) bread ..."	Gen. 22:6 "And Avraham took (לקח) ... the knife/eater (מאכלת) "
Gen. 37:22 Reuven to brothers: " Don't send out a hand against him (ויד אל תשלחו בו)" Gen. 37:27 Yehudah to brothers: " And our hand, don't let it be against him (וידני אל תהי בו)"	Gen. 22:10 "And Avraham sent out his hand (וישלח ... את ידו) and he took the knife ..." Gen. 22:12 Angel to Avraham: " Don't send out your hand against the lad (אל תשלח ידך אל הנער)"
Gen. 37:25 The brothers "lifted their eyes and looked, and behold, Yishmaelites"	Gen. 22:4 "And Avraham lifted his eyes and looked at the place from afar." Gen. 22:13 "And Avraham lifted his eyes and looked, and behold, a ram afar, caught in the thicket."
Gen. 37:31-32 The brothers take a goat and slay it (שחט) as a substitute for their brother, and bring its blood to their father.	Gen. 22:10, 13 Avraham is about to slay (שחט) his son, but is able to offer a ram "as a substitute for his son"
Rams and Goats in Genesis. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

The affinities of the Yoseph story with the binding of Isaac in Genesis 22 are striking, though the relationship is one of inversion in some important respects.

- Abraham intends to slay Isaac, who is spared in the nick of time. // Yaaqov intends to send and receive his son back soon but finds that he has been "slain."
- Abraham offers the sacrificial ram in place of his son. // For Yaaqov, the goat and its blood take the place of the son, because he has (so Yaaqov thinks) been mauled to death. The slain goat symbolizes the loss of the beloved son.
- Abraham intends to lose his son and receives him back. // Yaaqov intends to receive back his son and loses him.

But alongside these inversions, there are also profound continuities.

- For Yaaqov's beloved son, his death is only symbolized; in reality he has been "spared" from literal death. The goat dies and the son lives to be later restored to his father.
- The son who undergoes symbolic death is the firstborn of his father's preferred wife (just as Isaac is to Sarah).
- Yoseph's words to Yaaqov "here I am" ([Gen. 37:13](#)) echo Abraham's response to God ([Gen. 22:1, 11](#)), as well as Esau's response to Isaac in [Genesis 27:1](#).

"In a sense, the two stories of Abraham and Isaac and that of Isaac and Jacob flow together in the story of Jacob and Joseph."

Levenson, Jon D. (1995). [The Death and Resurrection of the Beloved Son](#). Yale University Press. 149.

Yoseph Assaulted, Slaughtered, Exiled, Enslaved, and Thrown in the Grave

[Genesis 37](#) creates a network of images and vocabulary to describe Yoseph's fate, some of them real and others imagined. But their association in this opening story connects them in an important way, and we find them repeated and connected even more as the story develops.

- Yoseph is thrown into a pit ([בֹּרַח](#)) ([Gen. 37:20, 22, 24, 28, 29](#)).
- Yoseph is abused by his brothers ([Gen. 37:23](#)).
- Yoseph is substituted for a slaughtered animal ([Gen. 37:31-32](#)).
- Yoseph is sold into slavery ([Gen. 37:28-29](#)).
- Yaaqov assumes that Yoseph is "torn up," "eaten," and "in the grave" ([Gen. 37:33, 35](#)).

This network of associations provides the most robust portrait of human evil and violence that we've encountered thus far in Genesis. These images will be drawn upon throughout the Hebrew Bible, especially to describe David's dangerous trials in the Psalms ([Ps. 69](#)).

Psalm 69:1-2, 4, 8-9, 14-15 Instructor's Translation

¹ Save me, O God,
for the waters have threatened my life.

² I have sunk in deep mire, and there is no foothold;
I have come into deep waters, and a flood overflows me. ...

⁴ Those who hate me without a cause are more than the hairs of my head;
those who would destroy me are powerful, being wrongfully my enemies;
what I did not steal, I then have to restore. ...

⁸ I have become estranged from my brothers,
and a foreigner to my mother's sons.

⁹ For zeal for your house has consumed me,
and the reproaches of those who reproach you have fallen on me. ...

¹⁴ Deliver me from the mire and do not let me sink;
may I be delivered from my foes and from the deep waters.

¹⁵ May the flood of water not overflow me,
nor the deep swallow me up,
nor the pit shut its mouth on me.

Reflection Question

How do the biblical authors subtly foreshadow the hopeful deliverance coming at the end of the Yoseph story as the brothers cast Yoseph into the pit?

Session 8: Judah and Tamar

Key Takeaways

- Literary links at the beginning of Genesis 38 and 39 invite the reader to make a deliberate comparison between Yoseph, who “was taken down” (*yarad*) from his brothers into Egypt, and Yehudah, who also “went down” (*yarad*) from his brothers.
- Yehudah's story in Genesis 38 provides, in riddle form, an outline of the rest of the Genesis scroll.
- Yehudah and his sons replay the failure of Adam and Eve.

The Seed of Yehudah Is Saved by Tamar

A - Genesis 38:1-11

- a - **38:1-2** Yehudah marries a **Canaanite wife**
- b - **38:3-5** She **births three sons for Yehudah**
- a' - **38:6-11** **Yehudah's two sons die**; **he deceives Tamar**, the **Canaanite wife** of his sons

B - Genesis 38:12-23

- a - **38:12-13** Yehudah and Hirah go up to shear the flock of goats
- b - **38:14-19** **Tamar's Counter-Deception**: Disguised as a sex-worker, she rescues the seed of Yehudah and takes his seal, cord, and staff as a **pledge**
- a' - **38:20-23** Yehudah sends Hirah to get the **pledge** with a goat, but cannot find Tamar

A' - 38:24-30

- a - **38:24-26** **Young**, pregnant Tamar is made to **come out**; she displays the **pledge**, **older** Yehudah confesses his **deception**
- b - **38:27** Tamar is pregnant with **twins**
- a' - **38:28-30** **Tamar gives birth to Yehudah's twin, rival sons**; the **younger** **comes out** trying to usurp the **older**

Genesis 38. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

This story about the death and restoration of Yehudah's family line begins with a key phrase that links it to the surrounding Yoseph story, which is also going to be about the death and restoration of Yaaqov's family line.

Genesis 37:36

- “Meanwhile, the Midianites sold him in Egypt to Potiphar, Pharaoh's officer, the captain of the butchers”.

Genesis 38:1

- “And it came about at that time, that Judah went down (יָרַד) from his brothers and visited a certain Adullamite, whose name was Hirah.”

Genesis 39:1

- a - “Now Yoseph had been made to go down (יָרַד) to Egypt;
- b - and Potiphar, an Egyptian officer of Pharaoh, the captain of the butchers, bought him from the Yishmaelites ,
- a' - who had taken him down (יָרַד) there.”

Genesis 37:36-39:1. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

These literary links invite us to make a deliberate comparison between Yoseph, who goes down from his brothers into Egypt, and Yehudah, who also goes down from his brothers in Genesis 38. We are meant to apply what we learn about Yehudah's "going down" to our understanding of the wider story of Yoseph and his brothers.

The Story Within the Story



Rakozay (2019). Example of Mis en Abyme. [Stack Exchange](#)

Genesis 38 is what literary theorists call a “*mise en abyme*.” This French term refers to the artistic technique of placing a miniature version of the larger work somewhere inside of the work itself. In literature, an author can accomplish this by placing a smaller story within a larger one, and that smaller story condenses and summarizes the themes and motifs of the surrounding narrative. In Genesis 38, the story of Yaaqov, Yoseph, Yehudah, and the brothers is mirrored in the drama of Yehudah, Shelah, and Tamar. Because the plot conflict

of Genesis 38 mirrors that of Genesis 37, the reader reenters the Yoseph story anticipating that Genesis 39-45 will progress along similar lines as Genesis 38.

Let's look at some verbal links between Genesis 38 and the surrounding chapters.

Genesis 38	Genesis 37, 39-45
Gen. 38:1 "And Yehudah went down from (יֵרֵד) his brothers" (odd phrase, meant to link Yehudah's descent to Yoseph's)	Gen. 37:25 The Ishmaelites take Yoseph "to go down (יֵרֵד) to Egypt" Gen. 39:1 "Yoseph was taken down (יֵרֵד) to Egypt."
Gen. 38:17 "I will send (שִׁלַּח) you a young goat (גִּדִּי עִזִּים)"	Gen. 37:31-32 "And they slaughtered a goat (שָׁעִיר עִזִּים) ... and they sent (שִׁלַּח) to their father"
Gen. 38:25 "Examine please (הִכָּר נָא), to whom belongs the seal and cords and staff?"	Gen. 37:32 "And they brought the coat of variegated colors to Yaaqov and said, 'We found this, examine please (הִכָּר נָא).'"
Gen. 38:12 "And Yehudah was comforted (נָחַם)"	Gen. 37:35 "And Yaaqov refused to be comforted (נָחַם)"
<i>Genesis 38's Place in Final Movement. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Yehudah the deceiving father is deceived by his daughter-in-law Tamar, involving a goat. // Yaaqov the deceiving father is deceived by his sons, involving a goat.

Yehudah loses his two sons (Er and Onan) and refuses to give up the youngest (Shelah). // Yaaqov loses two of his sons (Yoseph and Shimon) and refuses to give up the youngest (Binyamin).

The younger, deceived Tamar uses counter-deception to save the family. // The younger, deceived Yoseph uses counter-deception to save the family.

"Judah with Tamar after Judah with his brothers is an exemplary narrative instance of the deceiver deceived. Since Judah was the one who proposed selling Joseph into slavery instead of killing him (Gen. 37:26-27), he can easily be thought of as the leader of the brothers in the deception practiced on their father. Now he becomes their surrogate in being subject to a bizarre but peculiarly fitting principle of retribution, taken in by a piece of his own attire, as his father was."

Alter, Robert (2011). [The Art of Biblical Narrative](#). Basic Books. 10.

Parallel Stories: Comparison and Contrast

The story of Yehudah and Tamar is placed in between Genesis 37 and 39 as a condensed summary of the entire Yoseph story in Genesis 37-50 (see Kruschwitz, "The Type-Scene Connection between Genesis 38 and

the Yoseph Story”). The key-word hyperlinks between Genesis 37 and 38 listed above invite us to compare the thematic similarities between Yaaqov’s loss of his beloved Yoseph and his attempts to protect Binyamin with Yehudah’s loss of his sons followed by his efforts to protect his beloved son Shelah.

Yehudah and Tamar	The Yoseph Story
Two of Yehudah’s sons die, incite fear in Yehudah that his third son will die because of Tamar.	Yaaqov has two sons from his beloved wife Rachel who dies, and he ends up losing both sons in the story only to regain them. Yoseph’s two dreams along with Yaaqov’s favoritism incite the brothers to sell Yoseph into slavery.
Yehudah loses the life of his firstborn son, so he wants to protect the life of his last-born son, so he acts deceptively.	Yaaqov loses Rachel’s firstborn through the brother’s deception, so he wants to protect the life of Rachel’s last-born son.
Yehudah deceives Tamar after the death of his two sons, by lying to her and not giving her to Shelah as a wife. This deception causes a separation between father and daughter-in-law.	The brothers deceive their father Yaaqov by lying to him about the true fate of their brother Yoseph, and deceiving him through “recognizing” (נכר) a faked garment.
Tamar performs a counter-deception: • She dons a disguise • She takes a “pledge” (ערבון) from Yehudah • She schemes a way to make Yehudah confess his wrongdoing	Yoseph performs a counter-deception: • He will don a disguise • He will take his brother Yehudah as a “pledge” (ערבון) • He schemes a way to make the brothers and Yehudah confess their wrongdoing
Tamar’s identity is revealed at the climax of the test, as Yehudah “recognizes” (נכר) his staff.	Yoseph’s identity is revealed at the climax of the test, as the brother “recognize” (נכר) him.
Yehudah finally confesses his wrongdoing.	Yehudah finally confesses the brothers’ wrongdoing.
Tamar gives birth to two sons whose birth order is reversed.	Yoseph’s wife gives birth to two sons whose birth order is reversed.
<i>Comparing Judah’s Story and Joseph’s Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

“The story of Judah and Tamar establishes a type-scene that is immediately realized in the encompassing Joseph story. ... It functions as a preparing and clarifying lens ... through which the audience more fully understands the Joseph novella.”

Kruschwitz, Jonathan (2012). “[The Type-Scene Connections between Genesis 38 and the Joseph Story](#).”. Journal for the Study of the Old Testament, Volume 36 Issue 4.

The story of Yehudah and Tamar provides a condensed summary of the entire Yoseph story, while also showing how key themes in Yoseph’s drama are to be thematically connected to the broader story of Genesis that is carried forward in Yehudah, not Yoseph.

- [Genesis 38](#) provides a deeper analysis of the brothers’ deception in [Genesis 37](#) through the character of Yehudah, who is a lead deceiver in Genesis 37 as well.
- Genesis 38 anticipates how the conflict of the Yoseph story will be resolved, as Tamar’s counter-deception previews Yoseph’s counter-deception in [Genesis 42-45](#).
- Genesis 38 creates a distinct moment of focus on Yehudah, whose prominent role in the Yoseph story was already introduced in Genesis 37, so throughout [Genesis 39-50](#), the reader expects both Yoseph and Yehudah to play significant roles in the story.
- Genesis 38 is all about how the seed of Yehudah was saved from extinction because of the counter-deception of a Canaanite woman, resulting in the surprising, reversed birth of two sons of Yehudah. This maps onto the story of how the entire seed of Yaaqov is saved from the famine because of the counter-deception of Yoseph, resulting also in a surprising reversal of birth-order for Yoseph’s two sons ([Gen. 48](#)).
- Throughout Genesis 39-50, Yehudah will play a prominent role in the story, becoming the one among all the brothers to save Binyamin and Yaaqov from death. Yoseph himself plays the other prominent role, saving the family from death through his own deception of the brothers.

Yehudah and Tamar’s Roles Are Inverted in Genesis 39

In [Genesis 38](#), Yehudah is a deceptive coward who will give up his integrity and his wallet to save his son’s life and have lots of sex. He is easy prey for Tamar’s counter-deception. In contrast, Yoseph in [Genesis 39](#) is an honest man of integrity who resists the sexual invitation of Potiphar’s wife.

Potiphar’s wife invites Yoseph to have sex and then uses a deceptive garment to lie to her husband. She is an inversion of Tamar, who uses deceptive garments to get Yehudah to sleep with her, because he lied to her about his son Shelah.

Genesis 38:1-11: Literary Design

Yehudah Takes a Canaanite Wife for Himself

- a ¹ And it came about at that time,
a’ and **Yehudah went down** from his brothers
b and **he turned aside** unto a man, an Adullamite,
c and his name was Hirah,

b' 2 and **Yehudah saw there** a daughter of a man, a Canaanite,
 c' and his name was Shua;
 d **and he took her**
 d' **and he went in to her.**

a 3 **And she conceived and bore a son**
 b **and he called his name Er**.
 a 4 **And she conceived again and bore a son**
 b **and she called his name Onan**.
 a 5 **And again she bore another son**
 b **and she called his name Shelah**;
 c and it was at Chezib that she bore him.

Yehudah Takes a Canaanite Wife for His Son(s)

A 6 **And Yehudah took a wife** for **Er his firstborn**,
 and her name was Tamar.
 7 And **Er, Yehudah's firstborn**,
 B **was evil in the eyes of Yahweh**,
and Yahweh put him to death.
 1 8 And Yehudah said to **Onan**,
 C 2 **"Go in to the wife of your brother,**
 3 **and perform the brother-in-law-duty to her,**
 4 **and raise up seed for your brother."**
 1 9 And **Onan** knew that the **seed** would not be his;
 A' 2 and when **he went in to the wife of his brother**,
 C' 3 **he caused ruin on the ground**
 4 **in order not to give seed to his brother.**
 10 **And it was evil in the eyes of the Lord, what he did**
and he put to death also him.
 B' 11 **And Yehudah said** to Tamar his daughter-in-law,
"Sit as a **widow in your father's house**
 until my son **Shelah** grows up";
because he said,
 A' **"He too may die like his brothers."**
 And Tamar went and **sat in her father's house**.

Genesis 38:1-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Genesis 38:1-11 consists of three opening panels that are arranged in a ABA symmetry that sets up a comparative analogy between Yehudah and his sons.

- Yehudah's failure by taking a Canaanite wife (A) is repeated and intensified by his sons' evil actions (A') in not just taking another Canaanite wife (Er), but then wronging one's brother by not raising up seed

(Onan).

- Yehudah's act of taking a Canaanite wife is judged a failure by the comparison with Esau (Gen. 26:34-35 and Gen. 27:46), in contrast to Abraham and Isaac who take wives from within the family and guide their sons to do the same (Gen. 24 and 27).
- The father/son analogy also illuminates why Yehudah's actions are not judged by the narrator in A, and the puzzle of why Er "was evil in the eyes of Yahweh." This comparison between father and son is illuminating: Yehudah's sin in taking a wife from outside the family in A results in the birth of an illegitimate firstborn in A'. The moral evaluation of Yehudah's actions in A are not given until A', when the fruit of Yehudah's union with Bat-Shua is judged to be "evil in the eyes of Yahweh."

There is also series of contrast strategies at work between A and A'.

- In A, Yehudah takes a Canaanite wife who is a flat and silent character, and his marriage to her is a moral failure that leads to the death of two sons. // In A', Yehudah takes another Canaanite wife for his son, but she is a vocal and active character whose initiative leads to the birth of two sons.
- Bat-Shua has three sons and dies, in contrast to Tamar, who has no sons but her two husbands die.

Raising Up a Brother's Seed

The narrative of Genesis 38 assumes a cultural practice that will be developed much later in the covenant laws of the Torah called the "Levirate law," where a man was obligated to marry his brother's widow so that the deceased brother's family line would not die out within the clan.

The law is found in Deuteronomy 25:5-10, and there are parallel narratives that assume the same practice in Numbers 27 and 36, as well as the narrative in Ruth 4.

Deuteronomy 25:5-10 Instructor's Translation

⁵ When brothers dwell together as one,
and one of them dies and has no son,
the wife of the deceased will not be married outside to a foreign man;
her brother-in-law will go in to her,
and he will take her to himself as wife,
and he will perform the duty of a brother-in-law to her.

⁶ And it will come about that the firstborn whom she bears,
shall assume the name of his dead brother,
so that his name will not be wiped away from Israel.

⁷ And if the man does not desire to take his brother-in-law's wife,
then his brother-in-law's wife will go up to the gate, to the elders,
and she will say,
"My brother-in-law refuses to raise up a name for his brother in Israel;
he is not willing to perform a brother-in-law's duty for me."

⁸ And the elders of his city will call for him,
and they will speak to him,
and if he stands-still and says,
"I do not desire to take her,"

⁹ then the wife of his brother will come near to him in the eyes of the elders,
and she will pull his sandal off his foot,
and she will spit in his face,
and she will declare,
'So it is done to the man who will not build up the house of his brother.'"

¹⁰ And in Israel his name will be called,
"the house of the one whose sandal is removed."

This law and the narratives related to it are built of core themes explored in [Genesis 2-4](#).

- When death strikes a family, for whatever reason, and a human returns to the dust ([Gen. 2-3](#)) ...
- ... then the brother is obligated to become his brother's keeper, by raising up his seed and name. This is the opposite of what Cain did in murdering his brother and erasing his name and seed from the land.

In [Genesis 38](#), the portrait of Yehudah is even more negative than the selfish brother in [Deuteronomy 25](#). Yehudah is the father of the deceased sons, and he has more fear of losing his youngest son than he has compassion and care for the future of his own family lineage.

By means of a forward-facing hyperlink, Yehudah is being criticized for his lack of care for the future of his own family line, and he is compared to the "one whose sandal is removed." And so this opens an opportunity for Tamar, the wife of the deceased son, to take the initiative and counteract her father-in-law's failure.

Reflection Question

At first glance, the story of Yehudah and Tamar seems to be an odd intrusion into the Yoseph narrative. What are some of the ways that the biblical authors link [Genesis 38](#) to the rest of the Yoseph story and Genesis as a whole?

Session 9: Deceiving the Deceiver

Key Takeaways

- As a disguised deceiver, Tamar turns the Eden deception on its head as she deceives her deceiver in order to preserve life.
- In the social world of the biblical characters, widows and sex workers are some of the most vulnerable members of society. Tamar further exposes herself to risk and stigma in order to overcome Yehudah's failure to care for her.
- The stories of Tamar, Lot's daughters, and Ruth form a three-part birth narrative for David's lineage.

The Design and Message of Genesis 38:12-23

¹² And the days were many
and **the daughter of Shua**, the wife of Yehudah, died;
and Yehudah was comforted,
and he went up to his shearers of **his flock** at Timnah,
he and **his friend Hirah the Adullamite**.
¹³ And it was reported to Tamar,
"Behold, your father-in-law is going up to Timnah to shear **his flock**."

¹⁴ **And she removed her widow's garments**
A **and she covered with a veil,**
and she wrapped herself,
and she sat at the door of "Two eyes",
which is **by the road** to Timnah;
A **because she saw that** Shelah had grown up,
and she had not been given to him as a **wife**.
¹⁵ And **Yehudah saw her,**
B and he reckoned her to be a **prostitute**,
because **she had covered her face**.
¹⁶ And **he turned aside to her by the road,**
A' and he said,
"Come now, please, **let me go in to you**,"
because he did not know that she was **his daughter-in-law**.
And **she** said, "**What will you give me**, that **you may come in to me**?"
A

17 And **he** said, "I will send you a young goat from the flock."
 And **she** said, "If you will give a **pledge** until you send."
 B 18 And **he** said, "What **pledge** shall I give you?"
 And **she** said, "Your seal and your cord, and your staff that is in your hand."
 And **he gave to her**
 A' and **he went in to her**,
 and **she** conceived by **him**.
 19 **And she arose and she went**,
 A' **and she removed her veil**
and she put on her widow's garments.

20 And **Yehudah sent the young goat**
by the hand of **his friend the Adullamite**,
 A to take the **pledge**
from the hand of the woman,
 and **he did not find her**.
 21 And he asked the men of her place, saying,
 B "Where is the **sacred woman** who was at Two-Eyes by the road?"
 And they said,
 "There has been no **sacred woman** here."
 22 And he returned to Yehudah, and he said,
 B' "**I did not find her**;
 and also, the men of the place said,
 'There has been no **sacred woman** here.' "
 23 And Yehudah said,
 A' "Let her keep them, lest we become an object of public contempt.
 Look, **I sent this young goat**, but **you did not find her**."

Genesis 38:12-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Genesis 38:12-23 contains five scenes arranged in a reverse symmetry (ABCB'A'). The central panel provides the pivot of this section. It focuses on Tamar's deception of Yehudah as she finds a way to overcome his deception of her.

The Symmetrical Design of Genesis 38:12-23

A – Genesis 38:12-13

- **Yehudah loses his wife to death**
- He goes with his buddy Hirah the Adullamite to celebrate **the shearing of his flock**

B – Genesis 38:14-16a

- **Tamar disguises herself as a prostitute**

- Yehudah wants to have sex with her

C – Genesis 38:16b-18a

- The dialogue & Tamar's deception
- In exchange for the **"sheep of his flock"** Tamar demands his seal, cord, and rod

B' – Genesis 38:18b-19

- Yehudah gives her the pledge and has sex with her
- **Tamar takes off her disguise**

A' – Genesis 38:20-23

- **Yehudah cannot find the sacred woman**
- He sends his buddy Hirah the Adullamite to give **the sheep of his flock**

Genesis 38:12-23. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

A and A': This match intensifies the gullibility and shame of Yehudah.

- He and Hirah go from a sheep-shearing festival (where the wine flows) in A to becoming bumbling idiots whose sexual escapades land them in a heap of trouble in A'.
- Yehudah goes from a festival with lots of sheep in A to losing one of his sheep in A', which is a mirror of Tamar, whose loss of a husband is reversed by her gaining of a child.

B and B': The reversal of Tamar's clothing (putting on the disguise/taking off the disguise) is symbolic of her plan: She is on a mission to reverse her status as the neglected widow in Yehudah's family.

C: The central focus of this unit is a pivot moment where Tamar goes from victim to victor by the mechanism of the "sheep of the flock," which of course links to the outer panels in A and A'.

- Tamar becomes the possessor of Yehudah's "rod," likely a sexual innuendo for his genitals, but also a link forward to Genesis 49:8-10 where Yehudah's "rod" becomes a symbol of the future royal seed.

A Disguised Deceiver

The central panel of the story is an inverted retelling of Genesis 3 with hints of the flood narrative.

Genesis 38	Genesis 3 & 6
Gen. 38:2 “And Yehudah saw there the daughter of a man ... and he took her.”	Gen. 3:6-7 “And the woman saw that the tree was good for eating ... and she took from its fruit and she ate ...”
Gen. 38:6 “And Yehudah took a wife for Er, his firstborn, and her name was Palm Tree/Tamar .”	
Gen. 38:7 “And Er his firstborn did what was bad in the eyes of Yahweh ” Gen. 38:10 “And it was bad in the eyes of Yahweh , what he did.”	Gen. 3:6-7 The tree of knowing good and bad was “ good in the eyes ” of the woman
Gen. 38:11 “Yehudah said to his daughter in law, ‘Dwell in the house of your father as a widow ...’ For he said, ‘ Lest he also die like his brothers.’”	Gen. 3:22 “The human has become like one of us, knowing good and evil, and now lest he send out his hand and take”
Gen. 38:14 Tamar “covered her face and disguised herself and sat by ‘ Opening of the Eyes ’ (פתח עינים) ... for she saw that Shelah had gotten older ... and she was not given to him as a wife .”	Gen. 3:6a “and the woman saw that ...” Gen. 3:6b “and she gave to her husband ...” Gen. 3:7 “and the eyes (עינים) of the two of them were opened (פקח) ...”
Gen. 38:21 “And [Yehudah] asked the men of the place, “ Where is the sacred prostitute that was by the Eyes (עינים)?”	
<i>Genesis 3 and 6 Present in Genesis 38. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

There is an inverted deception pattern: Yehudah, who was the deceiver in Genesis 37 and the deceiver of Tamar, is now deceived by her in response to his deception.

Just as the rebel spiritual being disguised itself as a snake to deceive the woman (Gen. 3), so here Tamar disguises herself to deceive her father-in-law. But notice the twist—Tamar’s deception is aimed at saving the life of the future seed, whereas the snake’s aim was to destroy the life of the future seed.

Yehudah replays the “see” and “take” fall pattern with regard to women (// sons of God in Gen. 6; Hagar in Gen. 16; Esau in Gen. 26, 27). But it’s his sons who end up dying as a result of their own “fall” narratives (“die” // Gen. 3). Tamar deceives Yehudah as he goes out to shear his sheep (Gen. 38:12). // Rachel deceives her father by stealing his idols when he goes out to shear his sheep (Gen. 31:19).

Tamar plays the role of the deceiver at Petakh-Enaim = “Opening of the Eyes” (Gen. 3:7) by covering her face and sleeping with her father-in-law (the daughters of Lot in Gen. 19).

Tamar's "covering her face" to deceive her father-in-law in 38:14-15 recalls Rebekah and Yaaqov's plan of covering Yaaqov's smooth skin with hair to deceive Isaac in Genesis 27.

Paragraph 3: Genesis 38:24-30

Yehudah Hears

- a 24 And it came about, three months later
that **it was reported to Yehudah** ,
b "Your daughter-in-law Tamar has been a **prostitute** ,
b' and behold, **she has conceived** by **prostitution** ."
a' And **Yehudah** said,
"**Make her come out** and let her be burned!"

Tamar Acts and Speaks

- a 25 As **she** was **being brought out**, she sent to her father-in-law, **saying** ,
b "**I have conceived by the man** to whom **these things** belong."
a' And **she said** ,
b' "Please **recognize** and see,
whose **seal and cords and staff** are these?"

Yehudah Sees

- a 26 And **Yehudah** **recognized** and he **said** ,
b "**She** is more righteous than **me**,
b' on account of the fact that **I** did not give **her** to Shelah my son."
a' And **he did not know** her again.

27 And it came about
at the time she was giving birth,
behold , there were twins in her womb.

- a 28 And it came about
as she was giving birth,
that he offered a **hand**,
b and the midwife took and bound **on his hand** a **scarlet** ,
c **saying** , "This one **came out** first."

- a' 29 And it came about
b' as he drew back **his hand**,

c' **behold**, his brother **came out**.
 d and **she said**, "What a **breach** you have **breached** for yourself!"
 And **he called his name "Breach/Perez"**

c' 30 And afterward his brother **came out**,
 b' who had **the scarlet on his hand**
 d' and **he called his name "Zerah/Sunrise."**

Genesis 38:24-30. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This short unit brings Yehudah and Tamar's conflict to a climax. There are three scenes that alternate in an ABA' pattern that highlights the reversal of Yehudah's judgment on Tamar from condemnation to vindication.

- In Genesis 38:24, Yehudah hears the report and condemns Tamar to death.
- In Genesis 38:26, Yehudah sees the items and vindicates Tamar for acting on behalf of his future lineage.

Tamar's status moves from death to righteousness between A and A', all because of her deceptive scheme to subvert Yehudah's deception of her in Genesis 38:11.

Genesis 38:12-23	Genesis 38:24-26
Gen. 38:12-13 "and the days were many ... and it was reported to Tamar that ..."	Gen. 38:24 "three months later, and it was reported to Yehudah that ..."
Gen. 38:15 "and he considered her to be a prostitute " Gen. 38:18 "and she conceived by him"	Gen. 38:24 "your daughter-in-law Tamar has been a prostitute ... she has conceived by prostitution ."
Gen. 38:13 "your father in law has gone up ..."	Gen. 38:25 "she sent to her father in law ..."
Gen. 38:18 "your seal and cord and staff in your hand"	Gen. 38:25 "whose seal and cords and staff are these?"
Gen. 38:14 "and she was not given to [Shelah] as a wife"	Gen. 38:26 "for I had not given her to Shelah my son"
Gen. 38:16 "and he did not know that she was his daughter-in-law"	Gen. 38:26 "and he did not know her again"
Repeated Language in Genesis 38. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

These two central panels of Genesis 38 contain a whole series of inversions that are essential to the plot, as Tamar’s status is reversed by means of her counter-deception.

Rival Sons, Rival Dads

The birth of Yehudah’s sons as rival twins is a clear allusion back to the rival births of Yaaqov and Esau in [Genesis 25](#). This invites us to compare and contrast the stories and meditate on their similarities and differences.

The Birth of Perez and Zerah in Genesis 38:27-30	The Birth of Yaaqov and Esau in Genesis 25:24-26
And it came about for her to give birth (לדתה), and behold (והנה) there were twins in her belly (תאומים בבטנה)! As she gave birth, one put out his hand (יד), and the midwife took and tied a red thread (שני) on his hand (יד), saying “ This one came out first (ראשונה).” When he drew back his hand (ידו), his brother (אחיו) came out (יצא)! And she said, “What a breach you have breached for yourself!” And his name (שמו) was called (קרא) “Perez.” And after (ואחר), his brother (אחיו) upon whose hand (ידו) was the red thread (שני) came out (יצא). And his name (שמו) was called (קרא) “Zerah.”	And the days to give birth (ללדת) were filled up, and behold (והנה) twins in her belly (תאומים בבטנה)! The first (ראשון) came out (יצא) red (אדמוני) ... and they called his name (קרא שמו) “Esau.” Afterwards (ואחרי כן) his brother (אחיו) came out (יצא), with his hand (ידו) grabbing Esau’s heel (עקב), and they called his name (קרא שמו) “Yaaqov.”
The Births of Perez and Zerah, and Jacob and Esau. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Genesis 38: Yehudah & Tamar, Perez & Zerah	Genesis 25: Isaac & Rebekah, Esau & Yaaqov
Tamar is pregnant with twins	Rebecca pregnant with twins
Tamar uses deceptive garments in order to save the line of Yehudah	In Genesis 27, Rebekah sees that Isaac has put the promised line in jeopardy because of his appetite for food, so she uses deceptive garments to trick Isaac into blessing Yaaqov
One son (Zerah) sticks out his hand first and is tied with red, but is usurped by his brother Perez at birth	Esau comes out first all red, but is usurped as firstborn by his brother in the next story
Jacob and Esau Reflected in Perez and Zerah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Genesis 38: Yehudah & Tamar, Perez & Zerah

Genesis 25: Isaac & Rebekah, Esau & Yaaqov

The second-born (Perez) ends up claiming the status of the firstborn, and is named “Perez” because he has “broken out” (פרץ, **38:29**)

Yaaqov is described as “breaking out” (פרץ) when he overcomes his older uncle Laban (**Gen. 30:30, 43**)

Jacob and Esau Reflected in Perez and Zerah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

“The same motif of the ascendancy of the youngest son observed in the connection with Judah and Joseph repeats itself among their descendants. In the case of Judah’s sons, this motif occurs in the birth account of the twins, when Perez usurps Zerah as the first son to emerge from the womb. In the case of Joseph’s sons, this motif occurs later when Jacob reverses the expected order of the firstborn’s blessing and gives it to Ephraim rather than to his older brother Manasseh. This ... corresponds to the importance of these two tribes later in Israelite history when they become the central core of the Southern and Northern kingdoms. While the northern kingdom represented by Joseph remains relatively prosperous and mighty in comparison with its weaker neighbor in the south for at least two centuries, it is the southern kingdom of Judah that endures the exile. Eventually in the post-exilic period, the name Judah becomes synonymous with the Jewish people as a whole and with the Davidic dynasty ... unparalleled by any royal lineage in the north.”

Menn, Esther (1997). [*Yehudah and Tamar \(Genesis 38\) in Ancient Jewish Exegesis*](#). Brill. 81.

A Birth Narrative for the Royal Seed of David?

In contrast to the “barren wife” pattern in Genesis (Sarah, Rebekah, Rachel, Leah), Tamar’s problem is not infertility, but the absence of an appropriate male partner because of death and moral failure. This creates an affinity between Tamar and (1) Lot’s daughters ([Gen. 19:30-38](#)) and (2) Ruth.

- Like Lot’s daughters, the daughter must sleep with her father (in-law) to keep the family name alive. All three daughters use secrecy and deception to get their father drunk (like Noah in [Gen. 9](#)) so that he will impregnate them. Lot’s daughters give birth to Moab and Ammon, and of course, through Ruth, the line of Moab becomes part of the line of David. The birth narrative in [Genesis 19:30-38](#) introduces sons who play no role in the next narrative, but only later in the Torah and Prophets.
- Like Ruth, Tamar’s Israelite husband died and there is no longer an heir to marry, so a Levirate marriage must provide a solution. Ruth’s nighttime strategy attracts Boaz to marry her. Ruth is a Moabite, who becomes the ancestor of David. The birth narrative in [Ruth 4](#) is abrupt and introduces characters who are still far off in narrative time.

These three narratives of Tamar, Lot’s daughters, and Ruth form an interconnected whole that provide a kind of “birth narrative” for David. This is hugely significant, as 1 Samuel provides no birth narrative for David, but simply introduces David as a “son of Jesse,” already a young man in the reign of Saul ([1 Sam. 16-17](#)). The

absence of a birth narrative for David is conspicuous, as he is one of the most important characters in the Hebrew Bible. And yet, unlike Abraham, Yaakov, Yoseph, Moses, Samuel, Solomon, and so on, David has no birth narrative. These three narratives (Gen. 19:30-38; ch. 38; Ruth) provide a “hyperlinked” birth narrative for David.

All three narratives portray the origins of the line of David in an unflattering light, involving sex scandals, but also the strange work of divine providence in and through compromised people.

The book of Ruth is full of hyperlinks and design patterns that connect to Genesis 38, especially the concluding genealogy.

Yehudah and Tamar in Genesis 38	Boaz and Ruth in Ruth 4
Yehudah’s deception puts his own lineage at risk	Boaz’s faithfulness to the role of the kinsmen redeemer rescues the line of David from death
Tamar engages in a sexually charged deception to save the lineage of Yehudah	Ruth engages in a sexually charged deception to save her mother-in-law and ends up saving the lineage of Yehudah
Yehudah and his sons fail to “raise up seed for their brother” in Levirate marriage	Boaz commits to “raise up the name” of their brother in Levirate marriage
Tamar is likened to Rebekah, who also gives birth to twins	Ruth is likened to Tamar, Rachel, and Leah Ruth 4:11-12 “May the Lord make the woman who is coming into your home like Rachel and Leah , both of whom built the house of Israel; and may you achieve wealth in Ephrathah and become famous in Bethlehem. Moreover, may your house be like the house of Perez whom Tamar bore to Yehudah , through the offspring which the Lord will give you by this young woman.”
Comparing Genesis 38 and Ruth 4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Intertextual Links Between Genesis 38 and 2 Samuel 11-13

David’s affair is with Bat-Sheva’ (2 Sam. 11:3) // Judah sleeps with Bat-Shua’ (Gen. 38:2, 12) → Solomon’s mother Bat-Sheva’ is actually named Bat-Shua’ in 1 Chronicles 3:5!

The affair results in the death of David’s first two sons: Amnon, and eventually Absalom. // Judah’s two sons die.

The plot of both [Genesis 38](#) and [2 Samuel 13](#) revolves around illicit sex with a woman named “Palm Tree” = Tamar.

Both Tamars are vindicated at a sheep-shearing festival ([1 Sam. 13:23](#) // [Gen. 38:13](#)).

The names involved in both plot series are matched.

Genesis 38	2 Samuel 11-13
Judah יהודה	דוד David
Hirah חירָה	חירם Hiram
Adullamite עדלמי	עדלם Adullam (1 Sam. 22:1; 23:13)
Bat-Shua בת שׁוּעַ	בַּת שֶׁבַע Bat-Sheva (called Bat-Shua in 1 Chr. 3:5)
Er ער	נֶעֱר David’s stillborn son (2 Sam. 12:16)
Onan אונן	נֹאֶמֶן Amnon
Shelah שלה	שֹׁלֹמֹה Solomon
Tamar תמר	תמר Tamar

Comparing Genesis 38 and 2 Samuel 11-13. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Reflection Question

What positive message about the character of God can we glean from the three-part birth narrative for David’s lineage in the hyperlinked stories of Tamar, Lot’s daughters, and Ruth?



Module 3: Rise and Fall and Rise Again

SESSIONS 10-12

Even in the pit, Joseph finds favor, but he faces one more betrayal before his final exaltation at just the right time to help save many lives.

Session 10: Joseph and Potiphar's Wife

Key Takeaways

- Yoseph acts as both the forbidden tree and the human who must listen to God's voice and pass the test. Biblical authors use keywords to evoke earlier stories while being dynamic in how they form the analogies.
- Potiphar's wife, who seeks illicit sex for personal pleasure, is set in meaningful juxtaposition with Tamar, who engages in illicit sex to seek justice and preserve life in the previous chapter.
- Yoseph rightly discerns that sin against another human, an image of God, is sin against God himself.
- Repetition of "laugh," Isaac's name as a verb, in the account of Potiphar's wife's deception continues the pattern of linking Yoseph to the binding of Isaac.

Yoseph's Rise and Fall and Rise

Genesis 39:1-23

39:1-6

A – Yoseph Enslaved, but Elevated Over Potiphar's House

- 39:2 "Yahweh was with Yoseph, and he was successful"
- 39:4 "And he appointed him over his house and gave everything of his into his hand"

39:7-19

B – Potiphar's Wife Traps Yoseph and Deceives Her Husband

- 39:9 "There is no one greater in this house than me ... how could I sin against God?!"
- 39:12 "And he left his garment in her hand, and he fled outside"

39:20-23

A' – Yoseph Imprisoned, but Elevated Over the Prisoners

- 39:21 "Yahweh was with Yoseph"
- 39:22 "The captain of the prison gave all the prisoners into the hand of Yoseph"

Genesis 40:1-23

40:1-8

Pharaoh's Baker and Cup-Bearer Are Imprisoned Along With Yoseph

- **The two men each have a dream** and ask Yoseph to interpret
- **40:8** "Do not interpretations belong to Elohim?"

40:9-19

The Two Men Recount Their Dreams and Yoseph Interprets Their Meaning

40:20-23

The Interpretations Come to Pass, but the Cup-Bearer Doesn't Remember Yoseph

Genesis 41:1-54

41:1-16

A – Pharaoh Has **Two Dreams About 2x7 Cows and Sheaves of Grain and Yoseph Interprets**

- **41:9** "Today I will make my sin remembered ..."
- **41:14** "Pharaoh summoned Yoseph ... and **he changed his garments** and came to Pharaoh"
- **41:16** Yoseph to Pharaoh: **"Not me! Elohim will give Pharaoh a response"**

41:17-36

B – Yoseph Interprets Pharaoh's Two Dreams Regarding 2x7 Years of Abundance and Famine

- **41:29-30** "7 years of abundance are coming ... followed by 7 years of famine afterward"

41:37-54

A' – Pharaoh Elevates Yoseph to Become Ruler Over All of Egypt

- **41:38** "Can another man be found like this, **in whom is the Spirit of Elohim?"**
- **41:40** **"You will be over my house ... only in the throne will I be greater than you"**
- **41:41** **"Look, I set you over all of Egypt," and Pharaoh put his ring onto the hand of Yoseph"**

Genesis 39:1-41:57. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

These three chapters bring the story to its first plot climax, as Yoseph's dreams and enslavement come to a culminating point. The section has three large parts designed with symmetrical order, and each of those parts has a three-part symmetry.

- Part 1 (Gen. 39:1-23) is about Yoseph's elevation in Potiphar's house, how Yahweh was with him, and how Potiphar placed him as a second-self in command of the household. It's also about a further downfall due to the deception of Potiphar's wife, and another loss of a garment that marks his further descent into prison.

- Part 2 (Gen. 40:1-23) picks up the double-dream theme of Genesis 37, and Yoseph interprets the two dreams of Pharaoh's officials, which opens the door for him to interpret Pharaoh's dreams in the next part.
- Part 3 (Gen. 41:1-54) is about Yoseph's elevation in the house of Pharaoh because of Elohim's presence with him that enables him to interpret dreams. Yoseph is elevated to second-in-command under Pharaoh and given new garments that mark his ascent to royal rule.

Innocent Yoseph Is Deceived by Potiphar's Wife

Genesis 39:1-6

Joseph Elevated in Potiphar's House

- 39:2 "Yahweh was with Joseph and he was successful"
- 39:3 "everything Joseph was doing (כל אשר הוא עשה), Yahweh made successful"
- 39:4 Potiphar "appointed Joseph over his house, and gave everything into his hand"
- 39:5 "Yahweh blessed the house of the Egyptian on account of Joseph"

Genesis 39:7-19

39:7-10

Joseph Refuses Potiphar's Wife 2x + Joseph's Honest Speech

- 39:7 And she said, "Lay down with me!"
- 39:8, 10 "And he refused ... and he didn't listen to her"

39:11-12

Joseph's Refusal and Flight

- "She seized him by his garment, saying 'Lay down with me!!' "
- 39:12 And he abandoned his garment in her hand.

39:13-19

Potiphar's Wife Reports the "Incident" 2x + the Wife's Deceptive Speech

- 39:14 "He came in to lay down with me"
- 39:17 "He came to me, to play with me"

Genesis 39:20-23

Joseph Elevated in the Prison House

- 39:21 Yahweh extended loyal-love to Joseph, and gave him favor in the eyes of the captain.
- 39:22 The captain gave all the prisoners into the hand of Joseph.

- 39:22 “Everything they were doing (כל אשר עשה), he was doing (הוא היה עשה)”
- 39:23 “Yahweh was with Joseph ... Yahweh made him successful”

Genesis 39:1-23. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This chapter is designed as a massive three-part symmetry with matching outer parts (Gen. 39:1-6 and 39:20-23) and a large center that itself has three symmetrically arranged parts (Gen. 39:7-19).

- Part 1 (Gen. 39:1-6) narrates Yoseph’s success and elevation in the house of Potiphar because of Yahweh’s presence with him. As a result, Yoseph is exalted to a place of second-in-command over his master’s house.
- Part 2 (Gen. 39:7-19) recounts Yoseph’s downfall in Potiphar’s house, due to his deceptive wife. There are three scenes here, beginning with his first refusal of the wife’s advances (Gen. 39:7-10), and this is matched by her speech that twists the story to her own advantage (Gen. 39:13-19). In the center (Gen. 39:11-12) is Yoseph’s defining moment, where he overcomes his test and has to flee naked.
- Part 3 (Gen. 39:20-23) narrates Yoseph’s success and elevation in the prison. The prison captain sees Yoseph’s abilities due to Yahweh’s presence, and he places Yoseph over the prison just as Potiphar did.

A

- a ¹ Now Yoseph had been **taken down** to Egypt;
 b and **Potiphar** bought him:
 c an officer of Pharaoh,
 c' the captain of the butchers,
 c'' an **Egyptian** man (איש מצרי)
 b' from **the hand** of the Yishmaelites,
 a' who had **taken him down** there.

B

- ² And **Yahweh was with Yoseph**,
 and he became a **successful man** (איש מצליח).
 And he was in **the house** of **his master** the **Egyptian**.

A'

- a ³ And **his master** **saw** (ראה) that **Yahweh was with him**
 b and that **everything that he was doing** (כל אשר הוא עשה) **Yahweh made successful** (מצליח) in **his hand**.
 a' ⁴ And Yoseph found **favor in his eyes** (חן בעיניו)
 b' and he attended him,
 a and **he appointed him over his house**,
 b and **everything that was his** (כל יש לו),
 a' **he** gave into **his hand**.
 a ⁵ And it came about **from the time he appointed him in his house**
 b and over **everything that was his** (כל אשר יש לו),
 a' Yahweh **blessed the house** of the **Egyptian** on account of Yoseph;

- 1 and Yahweh's (ויהי) **blessing** was on **everything that was his** (כל אשר יש לו),
in **the house** and in the field.
- 2 ⁶ And **he abandoned** (עזב) **everything that was his** (כל אשר לו)
into **the hand** of Yoseph;
- 3 and he did not know anything with him,
except the bread which he ate.
- +1 And Yoseph (ויהי) was beautiful of **form** (תאר)
and beautiful of **sight** (מראה).

Genesis 39:1-6. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph's Two Refusals and Honest Speech

- 7 And it came about after these things
and the wife of his master **lifted her eyes toward Yoseph**
and she said, " **Lie with me** ."
- 8 **and he refused.**
-
- a And he said to **the wife of his master** ,
- b ⁹ "Behold, **my master** does not know, with me, what is **in the house**,
- c and **everything that is his** (כל אשר יש לו) **he has given into** **my hand** .
- b' There is no one greater **in the house** than me,
- c' and **he has not withheld anything from me** except you, because you are his wife.
- d' And how could I do this great evil and sin against God?"
-
- 10 **And it came about as she spoke** **to Yoseph day after day**,
he did not listen to her
to lie next to her,
to be with her.

The "Incident"

- 11 And it came about on this day
that **he went into the house** (הביתה) to do his work,
and no man from the men of **the house** was there **in the house**.
- 12 And she seized him by **his garment**,
saying, " **Lie with me** !"
- and **he abandoned** (עזב) **his garment** in **her hand**
and he fled,
and he went outside (החוצה) .

The "Incident" Recounted in the Wife's Two Deceptive Speeches

13 And it came about when (וַיְהִי כֹ) she saw
 a that **he abandoned (עָזַב)** **his garment** in **her hand**
and he fled outside ,
 b 14 then **she called out** to the men of **her house**
 and **she said to them** , saying
 c “See, **he has brought in (לְ) (הֵבִיא לְ) a Hebrew man to us to play with us;**
 c’ he came to (בֹּא אֵלַי) me to **lie with me** ,
 b’ and **I called out with a great voice** ,
 15 and it came about when (וַיְהִי כֹ) he heard that **I raised my voice and called out** ,
 a’ then **he abandoned (עָזַב)** **his garment** **next to me** ,
and he fled and he went outside .”

16 And she rested **his garment** **next to her** ,
 until **his master** came to **his house** .

17 And **she spoke to him** **with** **these words** , saying
 “He came to me (בֹּא אֵלַי), the **Hebrew slave** ,
whom you made come to us (לְ) (הֵבִיא לְ) , to play with me;
 18 and when **I raised my voice and I called out** ,
 then **he abandoned (עָזַב)** **his garment** **next to me** , **and fled outside** .”
 19 And it came about when (וַיְהִי כֹ) **his master** heard **the words** of **his wife** ,
 which **she spoke to him** , saying,
 “According to these **these spoken-words** **your slave** did it to me,”
 then his anger burned hot.

Genesis 39:7-19. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

20 And Yoseph’s master took him
and he gave (וָיָתַן) him **into the round-house** ,
 the place the king’s **prisoners** were;
 and he was there in **the round-house** .

21 And **Yahweh was with Yoseph**
 and he extended loyal-love to him,
 and gave him favor in the eyes (חָנַן בְּעֵינָיו) of **the captain (שָׂר)** of **the round-house** .

22 And **the captain (שָׂר)** of **the round-house** **gave (וָיָתַן)**
 into **the hand** of Yoseph all the **prisoners** who were in **the round-house** ,
 and **everything they were doing there** ,
he was doing (כָּל אֲשֶׁר עָשִׂים ... הוּא הִיךָ עֹשֶׂה) .
 23 And **the captain (שָׂר)** of **the round-house** did not see anything in **his hand**

in as much as **Yahweh was with him**,
and **whatever he was doing** (כל אשר הוא עשה), **Yahweh made it successful** (מצליח).

Genesis 39:20-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

More Deceptive Garments

Yoseph's garment is taken from him by Potiphar's lying wife and used to "prove" his guilt. // Yoseph's coat is taken from him by his lying brothers and used to "prove" his death. // Tamar's "deceptive garments" are used to trick Yehudah.

Genesis 27	Genesis 37	Genesis 38	Genesis 39
Yaaqov deceives his father Yitskhaq with the garment (בגד) of his older brother	Yaaqov's sons deceive their father with the robe (כתנת) of his youngest son	Tamar deceives Yehudah with garments (בגד) in order to produce a son	Potiphar's wife deceives her husband with the garments (בגד) of Yaakov's beloved son

Genesis 27 Reflected in Genesis 37-39. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph: The Exalted and Exiled Image of Elohim

This narrative is riddled with hyperlinks to [Genesis 1-3](#) that set Yoseph on analogy to the image of Elohim who is appointed to rule as second-in-command. But he is wrongly accused because of a deceiving woman and exiled even further down into an Egyptian pit of death.

Yoseph in Genesis 39	Humans in Genesis 1-3
Yoseph finds favor with Potiphar and is placed as second-in-command over all that belongs to him.	Elohim appoints man and woman as the divine image over all creation that ultimately belongs to Elohim.
Gen. 39:6a Potiphar doesn't "know" anything in his house except "the bread which he ate" (which in the narrative, turns out to be his wife, the forbidden food).	Adam and Eve do not yet have the "knowledge" of good and bad, but are to "eat" from any other trees in the garden.
Gen. 39:6b Yoseph was "beautiful of sight " (יפה מראה)	Gen. 3:5-6 "the woman saw (רא"ה) that the tree was ... desirable to the eyes ."

Comparing Joseph and Adam and Eve. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph in Genesis 39	Humans in Genesis 1-3
Gen. 39:9 “How (איך) could I do (עשה) this great evil (רעה) and sin against God (חטאתי לאלהים)?”	Gen. 3:13 “What is this thing that you have done (עשה)?”
Gen. 39:10 “As she spoke to Yoseph day after day, he would not listen (לא שמע) to her”	Gen. 3:17 “because you listened to the voice of your wife ...”
Gen. 39:13 “And when she saw ...”	Gen. 3:6 “and the woman saw that the tree was good ...”
Gen. 39:15 “And it came about when he heard (שמע) that I raised my voice (קול) he ran outside.”	Gen. 3:8 “And they heard (שמע) the sound (קול) of Yahweh walking ... and they hid themselves”
<i>Comparing Joseph and Adam and Eve. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Yoseph is a contrast to Adam because he won't listen to the voice of the woman (Adam in Gen. 3:17) by sleeping with her. In this story, Yoseph becomes the forbidden fruit who is desirable to the eyes of Potiphar's wife (Potiphar's wife = “bread” in Gen. 39:6). He is wrongly seized by the woman, who then deceives her husband, resulting in Yoseph's expulsion, which leads him back into “the pit,” this time a “house of prison” (בית הסהר). Yoseph becomes an exiled Adam, not for any wrongdoing of his own, but because of the sin of Potiphar's wife. In this way, the Genesis 3 story is a contrast narrative with Yoseph as an anti-Adam.

Yoseph as a New Noah

Genesis 39:16 says, “And she rested (ותנח) his garment beside her” compared to Genesis 8:4 that says, “And the ark rested (ותנח) ... upon the mountains of Ararat.” This is a small hint that, like Noah, God has not forgotten Yoseph at his low point but will “remember” and deliver him.

Geneis 39:21 says, “And Yahweh ... gave him favor (חן) in the eyes of the captain of the house of confinement” compared to Genesis 6:8 that says, “Noah found favor in the eyes of Yahweh.”

The flood pattern hints continue, preparing us to view the famine as a “flood” of disorder out of which God will deliver a remnant, the family of Yaaqov, through Yoseph, who is the Noah figure.

Yoseph as a New Isaac

Genesis 39	Genesis 22
Gen. 39:7 “And the wife of his master lifted her eyes toward Yoseph”	Gen. 22:4 On the third day Abraham raised his eyes and saw the place from a distance.
Gen. 39:8-9 “My master doesn’t know (ידע) what is in the house ... There is not one greater in this house than I, and he has not withheld from me anything (לא חשך ממני מאומה) except you”	Gen. 22:12 “Don’t do to the boy anything (מאומה) , for I know (ידעת) that you fear God, and you have not withheld from me (לא חשכת ממני) your only son.”
Gen. 39:14 “Look, he has brought to us a Hebrew man to play/laugh at us (לצחק בנו)”	Gen. 21:9 Sarah sees the Egyptian Yishmael “playing/laughing” (צחק) , and exiles him to favor Yitskhaq/Laughter, who is to be sacrificed in Gen. 22.
Gen. 39:14 “And she cried out (ותקרא) ...”	Gen. 22:11 “And the angel of Yahweh cried out (ויקרא) ”
Gen. 39:10 “As she spoke to Yoseph day after day, he would not listen (לא שמע) to her.” Gen. 39:15 “And it came about when he heard that I raised my voice (כשמעו ... קולי) ”	Gen. 22:18 “because you listened to my voice (שמעת בקולי) ”
<i>Comparing Genesis 39 and Genesis 22. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

The point of these analogies: Yoseph, the beloved son of Yaaqov's old age, has been handed over to suffering and hardship because of evil human purposes providentially countered by God. Yoseph's exaltation over his brothers was a divine promise, but it became a cause of teenage arrogance. And so Yoseph's status was taken from him, as Isaac was taken from Abraham, only for both of them to receive back what they lost. Potiphar's wife becomes an inverted "Sarah" figure (Egyptian woman vs. Israelite). This clear Aqedah pattern at work in the Yoseph story maps closely onto the same patterns in chapter 37, where the goat is substituted for Yoseph to put blood on his coat.

Reflection Question

What earlier stories in Genesis do the biblical authors link to in Genesis 39?

Session 11: Dreamers in Pharaoh's Prison

Key Takeaways

- The theme of dreams and visions in Genesis is foundational to later apocalyptic literature and emphasizes the important role of dreams in the world of the biblical authors.
- A three-day period often indicates that the theme of testing appears nearby in the narrative.
- The Yoseph story contains many instances of paired or parallel events or repetitions. These doublings often point to a single reality, and they invite readers to consider why this narrative is focused specifically on two brothers, Yoseph and Yehudah.

Yoseph Interprets Dreams in Prison

¹ And it came about after these things,
that they sinned, **the cup-bearer of the king of Egypt and the baker** ,
against their master, against the king of Egypt,
² and Phar'oh was angry with his two officials,
against **the captain of the cup-bearers** ,
and against **the captain of the bakers** ,
³ and he gave them into the prison,
the house of **the captain of the butchers** ,
into **the round-house** ,
the place where Yoseph was imprisoned.

⁴ And **the captain of the butchers** appointed Yoseph with them,
and he served them,
and they were there for days in the prison.

⁵ And **the two of them** **dreamed a dream** ,
each **his dream** in one night,
each according to the **interpretation** of his dream,
the cup-bearer and the baker of the king of Egypt ,
who were imprisoned there in the round-house.

⁶ And Yoseph went to them in the morning,
and he saw them, and look, they were distraught,

⁷ and he asked the officials of Phar'oh,
who were with him in the prison of the house of his master, saying,
"Why are your faces bad today?"

⁸ And they said to him,
"We **dreamed a dream**,
and there is no one to **interpret** it."
And Yoseph said to them,
"Don't **interpretations** belong to Elohim?
Please, recount it for me."

Genesis 40:1-8. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

⁹ And **the captain of the cup-bearers** recounted his dream to Yoseph,
and he said to him,
"In my dream, look:
a vine was before me,
¹⁰ and on the vine were **three tendrils**,
and as it was blooming its blossom rose up,
its clusters ripened with grapes.
¹¹ And the **cup of Phar'oh** was in my hand,
and I took the grapes,
and I crushed them into the **cup of Phar'oh**,
and I gave the **cup** into the hand **of Phar'oh**."

¹² And Yoseph said to him,
" **This is its interpretation** :
The **three tendrils are three days** .
¹³ Within **three days** **Phar'oh will lift up your head** ,
and he will return you to your post,
and you will give the **cup of Phar'oh** into his hand,
according to the custom of the beginning, when you were his cup-bearer.

¹⁴ However, if you can **remember me** with you,
when the good thing happens for you,
and please act with loyal-love towards me,
and **make remembrance of me** to Phar'oh,
and bring me out from **this house**,
¹⁵ because I was stolen from the land of the Hebrews,
and even here I have done nothing,
that they should have put me in **this pit**."

16 And **the captain of the bakers** saw that the interpretation was good, and he said to Yoseph,
“So then, as for me, in my dream, look:
Three baskets of white-bread were upon my head,
17 and on the most-high basket were some from all of the food of Phar’oh,
the work of a baker,
and the birds ate them from the basket upon my head.”

18 And Yoseph answered and said,
“ **This is its interpretation** :
The **three baskets are three days** .
19 Within **three days** **Phar’oh will lift up your head** from upon you,
and he will hang you upon a tree,
and the birds will eat your flesh from upon you.”

Genesis 40:9-19. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

20 And it came about on the third day,
it was the birthday of Phar’oh,
and he made a feast for all **his servants** ,

and he lifted up the head of **the captain of the cup-bearers**
and the head up off **the captain of the bakers**
in the midst of **his servants** .

21 And he returned **the captain of the cup-bearers** over his cup-work,
and he gave the cup into the palm of Phar’oh
22 and **the captain of the bakers** he hanged,
just as **Yoseph** had interpreted for them.

23 But **the captain of the cup-bearers** **did not remember** **Yoseph** ,
and he forgot him.

Genesis 40:20-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Two Dreams of “Exaltation”

As Yoseph sits in the lowest of low places (in a dungeon in Egypt), he hears the two dreams of other exalted figures who have also been brought down low into the prison-pit. The similarity between Yoseph and these two fellow prisoners invites the reader to compare the importance of these dreams. If these officials have two dreams that result in a restoration of some kind, we begin to hope that Yoseph’s two dreams of exaltation might also come true.

Dreams of Bread and Wine

Notice how the two dreams of the officials are about coordinated images of provision and sustenance (bread and wine). The coming famine will bring a scarcity of just these things, so this story points forward as well as backward.

Reflection Question

What role do dreams play in Genesis and beyond in biblical literature?

Session 12: Joseph the Wise Deliverer of Egypt

Key Takeaways

- Yoseph is lifted out of the pit, shaved, and given a whole new set of garments. In the Bible, shaving often marks a transition between two phases of life or states of being.
- The doubling in Pharaoh's dream points to one reality confirmed by God, giving us further insight into the pattern of doubling in the Yoseph story as a whole.
- Yoseph is presented as a new Noah, with Pharaoh's house as the ark where others will find shelter and provision.

Yoseph Elevated To Become Wise Deliverer of Egypt

Genesis 41:1-16

Dreams and Their Interpretation

41:1-8

Pharaoh's Two Dreams

- 7 good cows eaten by 7 bad cows
- 7 good sheaves swallowed by 7 bad sheaves
- Pharaoh's spirit is troubled, no interpreter for the dreams

41:9-13

The Cup-Bearer Captain Tells About Yoseph

- A story of two dreams
- Young Hebrew boy

41:14-16

Yoseph Brought to Pharaoh

- Yoseph lifted out of the pit and given new garments
- Only Elohim can interpret dreams

Genesis 41:17-36

Interpretation of Pharaoh's Dreams and a Plan

41:17-24

Pharaoh Recounts His Two Dreams

- 7 good cows eaten by 7 bad cows
- 7 good sheaves swallowed by 7 bad sheaves

41:25-32

- The two dreams are one in meaning
- 7 good cows/sheaves are 7 years of abundance
- 7 bad cows/sheaves are 7 years of famine
- Elohim has doubled the dreams because he is about to do it

41:33-36

- Appoint a wise man to divide the land into five
- Pharaoh should store up food during 7 years of abundance
- The land won't be cut off during the 7 years of famine

Genesis 41:37-57

Yoseph's Plan Is Realized and the Dreams Come to Pass

41:37-46

- Pharaoh recognizes Yoseph as a wise man with the Spirit of Elohim
- Yoseph elevated to second-place ruler over Egypt and given royal garments
- Yoseph rides the chariot, and Egypt kneels before him

41:47-52

- Pharaoh gives Yoseph an Egyptian name and provides him an Egyptian wife
- Yoseph stores up food during the 7 years of abundance
- Yoseph's wife has two sons who are named

41:53-57

- The 7 years of abundance come to an end
- The 7 years of famine begin
- The famine is strong over all the land, the people cry out for bread

This large, culminating chapter brings many of the themes in Genesis 37-41 to a partial climax. It consists of three large parts, arranged in a large symmetry, though there are many interconnections between each of the parts.

- Part 1 (Gen. 41:1-16) introduces Pharaoh's two dreams about the seven cows and sheaves, interpreted by Yoseph, who is elevated up out of the pit and given new clothes.
- Part 2 (Gen. 41:17-36) focuses on the dialogue between Yoseph and Pharaoh about the two dreams about seven cows/sheaves and how they point to seven years of abundance and famine.
- Part 3 (Gen. 41:37-57) recounts Yoseph's second elevation and second set of new garments, marking him as the second-in-command over all Egypt who will prepare for the seven years of abundance and famine.

¹ And it came about after **two years** of days,
that Phar'oh **had a dream**,
and look: he was standing by the river,
² and look: from the river there came up **seven cows**,
beautiful to see, and fat of flesh,
and they grazed in the marshes,
³ and look: **seven other cows** came up after them,
bad to see, and skinny of flesh,
and they stood beside the cows on the shore of the river,
⁴ and the cows that were bad to see and thin of flesh,
they ate the **seven cows** that were beautiful to see and fat.

And Phar'oh woke up.

⁵ And he fell asleep **and dreamed a second time**,
and look: **seven ears of grain** came up on one stalk, fat and good,
⁶ and look: **seven ears of grain**, thin and burned by hot east wind, sprouted after them,
⁷ and the ears of grain that were thin swallowed the **seven ears** that were fat and full.

And Phar'oh woke up, and look: it was **a dream**.

⁸ And it came about in the morning that his spirit was agitated,
and he sent and he called to all the sorcerers of Egypt and all its wise ones,
and Phar'oh recounted to them **his dream**,
but there was for Phar'oh **no interpreter** for it.

⁹ And the captain of the cup-bearers spoke to Phar'oh, saying,
"I am, today, about to **make remembrance** of my sins.
¹⁰ Phar'oh was angry with his servants,
and he gave me into the prison,
the house of the captain of the butchers,
me, and the captain of the bakers;

11 and we dreamed a dream in one night, I and he,
 each according to the interpretation of his dream, we dreamed,
 12 and there with us was a young man, a Hebrew servant of the captain of the butchers,
 and we recounted to him our dreams,
 each according to his dream, he interpreted.
 13 And just as he interpreted for us, so it came about.
 He returned me to my post, and he hung him.

14 And Phar'oh sent and he called Yoseph,
 and he made him run out of the pit,
 and he was shaved and he changed his clothes,
 and he came to Phar'oh.

15 And Phar'oh said to Yoseph,
 "I dreamed a dream,
 but there is no interpreter of it.
 I have heard about you,
 saying that you can hear a dream to interpret it."

16 And Yoseph answered Phar'oh, saying,
 "Not really me!
 Elohim can attest to the peace of Phar'oh."

Genesis 41:1-16. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Pharaoh's Dreams and His Officials' Dreams

There is a clear similarity between Pharaoh's dreams and those of the officials he imprisoned in the previous chapter. This sets up an analogy between the two, so their dreams and following fulfillment create expectation in the reader that all four dreams will follow a similar course.

Genesis 40	Genesis 41
Gen. 40:5 The cupbearer and baker of Pharaoh each have a dream: "The two of them dreamed a dream on one night, each according to the meaning (פִּתְרוֹן) of his dream"	Gen. 41:1-8 Pharaoh has two dreams in one night: "And it came about in the morning ..."
Gen. 40:6 As a result, "they were vexed (זָעַזְעוּ)"	Gen. 41:8 As a result, his breath was "flustered"
Comparing Genesis 40 and 41. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Genesis 40	Genesis 41
	(פעם)
Gen. 40:8 “There was not an interpreter (פֶּתֶר אֵין) of it”	Gen. 41:8 After consulting his sorcerers, “there was no interpreter (אֵין פֹּתֵר) of them”
Gen. 40:10 Cupbearer’s dream: “On a vine were three tendrils, and as it blossomed, a flower came up (עָלָה) and bloomed a cluster of grapes”	Gen. 41:5-7 Second dream: “Seven grain-ears came up (עָלָה) in one stalk, fat and good ...”
Gen. 40:17 Baker’s dream: “Three baskets of cake ... and the top basket had all food (מֵאֵכֶל) for Pharaoh ...”	Gen. 41:1-4 First dream: “Seven cows came up (עָלָה), beautiful of appearance (מְרֵאָה) ... and seven other came up (עָלָה) and ate (אָכַל) the seven beautiful of appearance cows”
Gen. 40:1 The cupbearer and baker are imprisoned because “they sinned (חָטָא) against Pharaoh”	Gen. 41:9 The cupbearer reminds Pharaoh of “my sins” (חָטָא)
Gen. 40:12, 18 Yoseph interprets: “This is its interpretation” (זֶה פִּתְרוֹנוֹ)	Gen. 41:28 Yoseph interprets: “This is the matter (הוּא הַדְּבָר) which I speak to Pharaoh: What God is about to do, he has shown to Pharaoh.”
Gen. 40:8 “Don’t interpretations belong to God?”	Gen. 41:16 “Apart from me! God will give an answer to the wellbeing of Pharaoh”
Comparing Genesis 40 and 41. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

17 And Phar’oh spoke to Yoseph ,

“In **my dream** , look I was standing on the shore of the river,

18 and look, from the river came up **seven cows**, fat of flesh and beautiful of form, and they grazed in the marshes.

19 And look, **seven other cows** came up after them, impoverished, very **bad** of form, and empty of flesh;

I had not seen anything so **bad** as these in all the land.

20 And the cows, the empty and **bad** ones, they ate the **seven cows**, the first fat ones,

21 and they went into their innards,

but it wasn’t known that they went into their innards, as their appearance was just as **bad** as in the beginning.

And then I woke up.

22 And I saw in **my dream** ,
and look: **seven ears of grain** coming up from one stalk, full and **good** .
23 And look: **seven hardened ears of grain**, thin and shriveled by the east wind, sprouting after them,
24 and the ears of grain, the thin ones, swallowed up the **seven ears of grain**, the **good** ones.

And I spoke to the sorcerers ,
but there was no one to tell it to me.

25 **And Yoseph said to Phar'oh** ,
" **The dream** of Phar'oh, it is one.
What Elohim is about to do, **he has told** to Phar'oh .
26 **The seven good cows, they are seven years**,
and **the seven good ears of grain, they are seven years**.

It is one dream .
27 And the thin and **bad** cows that came up after them,
they are **seven years**,
and the **seven** ears of grain, the empty ones, shriveled by the east wind,
they are **seven years** of **famine** .
28 This is **the word that I have spoken** to Phar'oh,
what Elohim is about to do, **he has shown** it to Phar'oh .

29 Look, **seven** years are coming,
of great **fullness** in all the land of Egypt.
30 And there will arise **seven** years of **famine** after them,
and all the **fullness** in the land of Egypt will be forgotten,
and the **famine** will bring an end to the land,
31 and the **fullness** of the land will not be known,
because of that **famine** , and afterwards,
because it will be very heavy.
32 And about **the doubling** of **the dream** of Pharaoh, two times,
indeed **the spoken-word** is firmly established by Elohim,
and Elohim is just about to do it.

33 And now, let Phar'oh see to a man, an understanding and wise one,
and he should set him over the land of Egypt.

34 **Phar'oh should do it**,
and he should **appoint appointees over the land**,
and divide the land of Egypt into five in the **seven years of fullness** .
35 And they should gather all the food of these coming **good** years,

and they should store grain under the hand of Phar'oh,
food in the **cities** that they should guard.

36 And the food can be **appointed for the land**,
for the **seven years** of the **famine** that will be in the land of Egypt,
so the land won't be cut off by the **famine**."

Genesis 41:17-36. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

37 And the word was **good** in the eyes of Phar'oh
and in the eyes of all his servants;

38 and Phar'oh said to his servants,
"Is there another man like this,
who has **the spirit of Elohim in him**?!"

39 And Phar'oh said to Yoseph,
"Following from the fact that **Elohim made all this known to you**,
there is no one as **understanding and wise** as you!

40 **You yourself** will be **over my house**,
and upon your mouth, all my people will kiss.
Only in the throne will I be greater than you."

41 And Phar'oh said to Yoseph,
"Look, **I have made you to be over all the land of Egypt**."

42 And Phar'oh removed his ring from **upon his hand**,
and he gave it **upon the hand** of Yoseph,
and he clothed him in garments of linen,
and he set a necklace of gold **upon his neck**.

43 And he made him ride in the second chariot which belonged to him,
and he called out before him,
"Kneel!"
And so **he made him to be over all the land of Egypt**.

44 And Phar'oh said to Yoseph,
"**I myself** am Phar'oh,
and **aside from you, no man will lift his hand or his foot**, in **all the land of Egypt**."

Genesis 41:37-44. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

45 And **Phar'oh called the name of Yoseph**,
"Tsaph'nath-Pa'ne'akh" (Egyptian = "The Deity Said, 'He Will Live!'")
and he gave to him **Asenath, daughter of Potiphra, the priest of 'On**, as a wife,
and Yoseph went out over the land of Egypt.
46 Now, Yoseph was **a son of thirty years** when he stood before Phar'oh king of Egypt,
and Yoseph went out from before Phar'oh,
and he passed **through all the land of Egypt**.

47 And the land produced for **the seven years of fullness**, many handfuls,
48 and he gathered all **the food** of the years which were in the land of Egypt,
and he put **the food** into cities,
food of the fields of the city that were around it,
he put into its midst.
49 And Yoseph stored up **grain** like the sand of the sea,
it was very abundant,
to the degree that one stopped counting, because it was beyond numbering.

50 Now, for Yoseph were born two **sons**, before **the year of famine** came,
whom **Asenath, the daughter of Potiphra, priest of 'On**, she bore for him.
51 And **Yoseph called the name** of the **firstborn**,
"**Menasheh (מנשה)**,"
because Elohim has made me forget (נשח) all my toil and all the house of my father."
52 And **the name** of the **second**, **he called**,
"**Ephrayim (אפרים)**,"
because Elohim has made me fruitful (פרי) in the land of my oppression."

Genesis 41:45-52. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

53 And so were **finished** the **seven years of fullness**
that were **in the land of Egypt**,
54 and so **began** the **seven years** of the coming **famine**,
just as **Yoseph** had said.
And the famine was in all the lands,
but in **all the land of Egypt** there was **bread**.

55 And there was **famine in all the land of Egypt**,
and the people cried out to Phar'oh for **bread**,
and Phar'oh said to all of Egypt,
"Go to **Yoseph**,

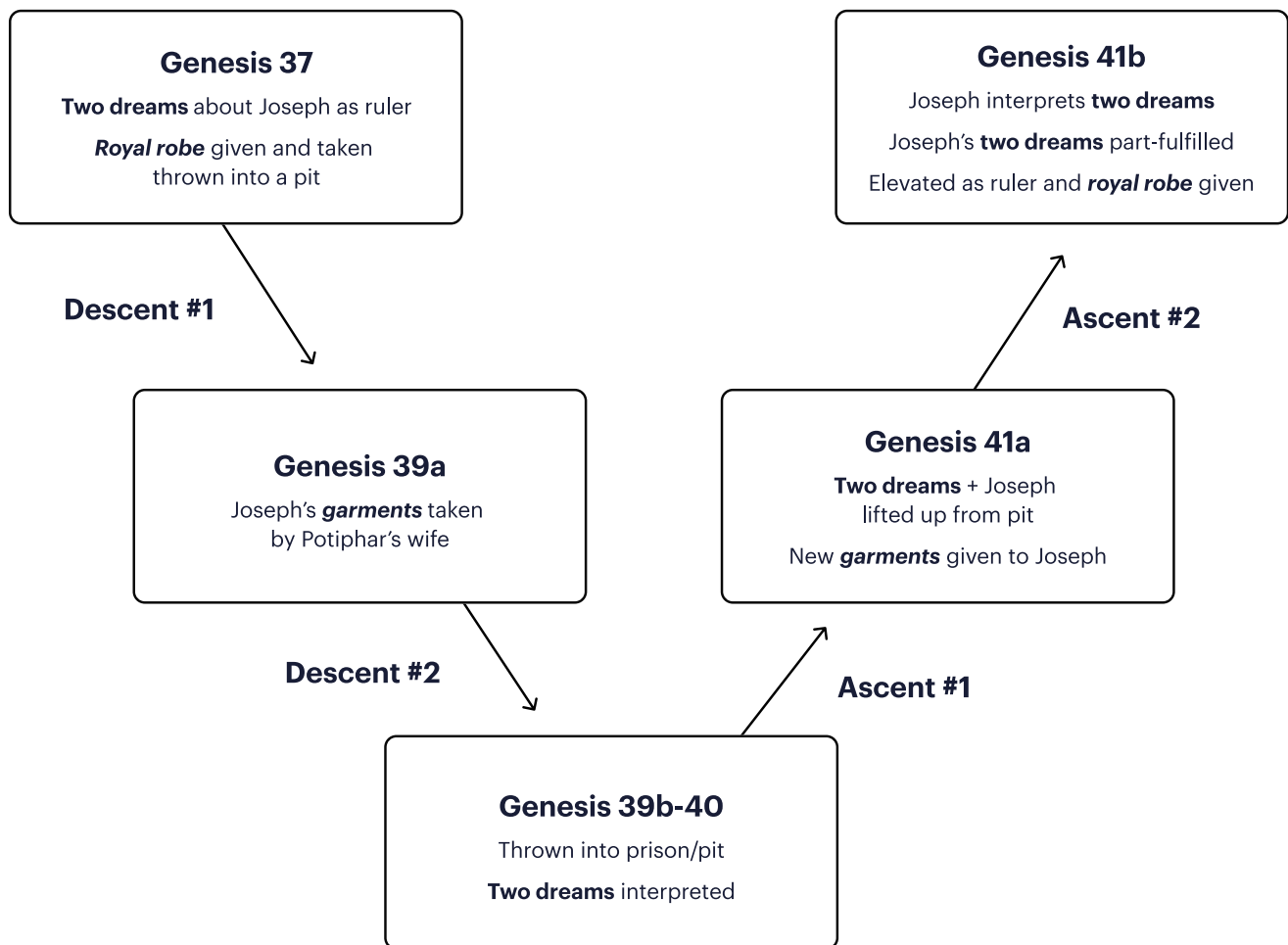
he will tell you what to do!"

⁵⁶ And the **famine** was upon **all** **the face of Egypt**,
and **Yoseph** opened up everything that was in them,
and he sold **grain to Egypt**,
and the **famine** was strong **in the land of Egypt**,
⁵⁷ and **all the land** was coming **to Egypt** to buy **grain** from **Yoseph**,
because **the famine was strong in all the land**.

Genesis 41:53-57. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

The Descent and Exaltation of Yoseph

In Genesis 41, the narrative arc that began in chapter 37 comes full circle. Yoseph's two dreams that led to his double descent (from a pit into Egypt, from a house into a prison) bring us to a pivot where two more dreams become the key to his ascent. It is then Pharaoh's two dreams that require Yoseph's expertise, and so he is exalted to interpret the dreams and is placed in the elevated role of second-in-command over Egypt.



The Role of the Garment in the Joseph Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Dreams of Creation and De-Creation

Pharaoh's dreams are packed with vocabulary from [Genesis 1-6](#) that sets up analogies between the years of abundance/famine and the story of creation and de-creation.

Pharaoh's Dreams in Genesis 41	Creation and De-creation in Genesis 1-6
7 cows (פרה) that are fat (בריאת) and beautiful of appearance (יפות מראה) and 7 sheaves that are fat (בריאה) and good (טוב)	7 days of creation (ברא) that result in trees with fruit (פרי) that are good of appearance (טוב מראה)
<i>Pharaoh's Dreams as Decreation.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Pharaoh's Dreams in Genesis 41	Creation and De-creation in Genesis 1-6
7 cows (פרה) that are bad (רע) of appearance (מראה), that eat (אכל) the fat cows, ending the time of abundance 7 sheaves that are thin and burned by hot wind (קדים) rise up to swallow (בלע) the good sheaves	The fruit (פרי) on the tree of knowing good (טוב) and bad (רע) is eaten (אכל), resulting in exile and the end of abundance The fruit (פרי) on the tree of knowing good (טוב) and bad (רע) is swallowed, so Yahweh appears in a storm wind (רוח) to the humans
7 bad cows and 7 bad sheaves will consume the abundance of the 7 good cows/sheaves = 7 years of famine that will decrease the 7 years of abundance	Gen. 1:1-2:3, 7:4 Noah waits 7 days for the arrival of the flood that will undo the creation that was made in 7 days.
Gen. 41:21 After the bad cows/sheaves eat the good cows/sheaves, "their appearance was still bad, just as in the beginning (תחלה)."	Gen. 1:1, 7:23-8:1 After the flood waters rise and destroy all life on the land, creation reverts back to wild, wastes, and darkness as in the beginning.
Gen. 41:38 "Can there be found a man like this one, in whom is the Spirit of God (רוח אלהים)?"	Gen. 1:2 "and the spirit of God (רוח אלהים) was hovering over the waters"
<i>Pharaoh's Dreams as Decreation. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

The subtle allusions create a meaningful relationship between the seven days of creation that result in fruit and goodness and the seven years of abundance that Pharaoh has dreamt about. It also creates the inverse analogy between the seven days Noah waits for the flood de-creation and the seven years that threaten to bring an end of all life in the land.

This point leads us to a whole additional set of hyperlinks in [Genesis 41](#) that connect back to the flood story as a whole in [Genesis 6-9](#).

The Selection of a Remnant for a Flood of Famine

Recall that [Genesis 37-39](#) was filled with hyperlinks to [Genesis 1-4](#), where Yoseph was depicted as an appointed ruler whose rule was usurped through the deception and jealous anger of his brothers. Now that Yoseph has been delivered from their evil schemes and exalted once again, the narrator begins to depict him on analogy with Noah during the generation before the flood.

Yoseph describes the 7-year famine as cosmic and cataclysmic in scope:	The flood is described as cosmic and cataclysmic in scope: Gen. 6:17 "Behold, I, even I am bringing the flood of
<i>Being Remembered in the Famine and Flood. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Gen. 41:31 “ the famine will bring a total end to the land ... for it will be extremely heavy ”	water upon the land, to ruin all flesh in which is the breath of life , from under the skies; everything that is on the land shall perish .” Gen. 7:4 “For after seven more days , I will send rain on the land forty days and forty nights; and I will wipe away from the face of the land every living thing that I have made.”
Yoseph urges Pharaoh to prepare so that “ the land will be not cut off by the famine” (ולא תכרת הארץ ברעב)	Gen. 9:11 God makes a covenant with Noah that “ all flesh will not be cut off (ולא יכרת כל בשר) again by the waters of the flood.”
Gen. 41:56 The famine (רעב) is set on analogy to the waters of the flood: the famine is “ strong ” (חזק), “ over all the face of the land ” (על כל פני הארץ)	Gen. 7:18 the floodwaters were “ mighty ” (גבר) “over the land” (על הארץ) Gen. 7:23 all standing things were blotted out “from upon the face of the land ” (על פני האדמה)
The language of Yoseph storing up food for the great famine: “Let Pharaoh store up grain as food (אכל) in the cities, and it will be food (אכל) appointed for the land”	Gen. 6:21 “And take for yourself from all the food (מאכל) that will be eaten (אכל), and gather together to yourself, and it will be for food (אכלה) for you.
Egypt is the place of refuge under Yoseph’s leadership: Gen. 41:56 he “ opens ” (פתח) the storehouses of grain	The ark is the place of refuge under Noah’s leadership, the door of which is “closed” (סגר) until Noah “ opens ” (פתח) the window.
Gen. 40:14-15 Yoseph asks the the cupbearer “ remember ” (זכר) him “in the pit” (בור) Gen. 40:23 but he does “ not remember ” (לא זכר), “he forgot”	Gen. 8:1 God “ remembered ” (זכר) Noah in the waters
<i>Being Remembered in the Famine and Flood. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Yoseph as an Exalted Son of Man (i.e., Adam)

The story of Yoseph’s exaltation is described in language reminiscent of the exaltation of humanity in Genesis 1-3. Just as humanity was raised up from the dust and placed in the high mountain garden, so too Yoseph is raised up from the pit to a place of rule over all the land.

All the lands become famine deserts, but in Egypt "there was bread" (Gen. 41:54) because of Yoseph's rule. During the famine, all Egypt comes to Pharaoh, who tells them to go to Yoseph, who sells grain (וישבר) to Egypt and to all the land (Gen. 41:55-57). This feels like an Eden scene where all those outside of the abundant-garden land are now flowing into the land and are met by Yoseph, Pharaoh's second self (see below) and are given bread.

The scene where Pharaoh exalts Yoseph in Genesis 41:39-46 supplies foundational vocabulary and conceptual categories for the exalted son of 'adam role that was forfeited by Adam and Eve in Genesis 2-3 and is recovered in Daniel 7. The portrait of Pharaoh sharing his rule with Yoseph as "second-self" is quite detailed.

- Pharaoh says to Yoseph: "Only on the throne will I be greater than you" (Gen. 41:40); "all my people will kiss upon your mouth" (Gen. 41:40; see Psalm 2).
- Pharaoh shares his "ring from his hand and give it upon the hand of Yoseph, and he clothed him with garments of linen" (Gen. 41:42).
- Pharaoh makes Yoseph "ride on the second chariot" (במרכבת המשנה), and he calls out before Yoseph "Bow!" (אברך), and "he [Pharaoh] set him [Yoseph] over all the land of Egypt" (Gen. 41:43).
- "I am Pharaoh, and apart from you no one will lift his hand or foot in all the land of Egypt" (Gen. 41:44).

Yoseph's name Tzaphenath-Pa'neakh has been given many interpretations.

- Hebrew root derivations: *tsefunot* ("hidden things"), *mofia'* ("he reveals"), *nokhot* ("easily")—"The One Who Easily Reveals Hidden Things." (Targums and *Genesis Rabbah* 90,4)
- Egyptian derivation: (1) *Dd-p3-ntr-iv.f-aynh*, "God Speaks and He Lives," or "The God Has Said: He Will Live" (Steindorff, Redford).

This scene which equates Yoseph/Pharaoh in terms of shared authority is explored further in the following moments of the Yoseph narrative.

- In Genesis 44:18, Yehudah says to Yoseph, "For as you, as Pharaoh," meaning "You are as Pharaoh in this moment."
- In Genesis 45:8, Yoseph says, "God made me as a father to Pharaoh, and as the lord of all his house, and ruler over all the land of Egypt."
- In Genesis 45:9, Yoseph says, "God has made me as lord for all the land of Egypt, come down (רדה, cf. רדה "rule" in Gen. 1:28).

Reflection Question

How have the previous chapters of the Yoseph story prepared readers to expect the elements of the flood melody that play out in Genesis 41?



Module 4: Joseph Tests His Brothers

SESSIONS 13-17

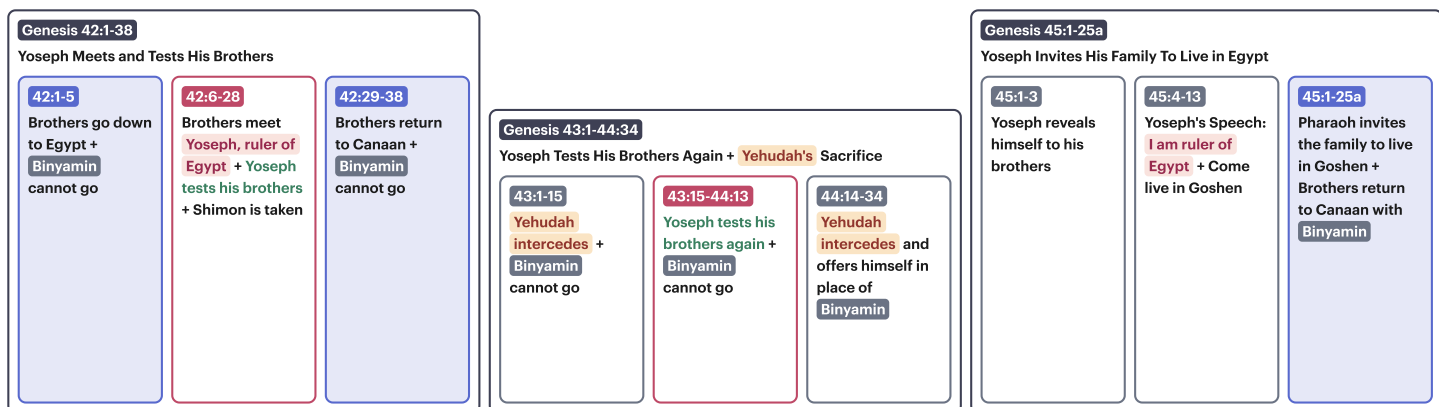
After years, famine brings the brothers back together again. How will Joseph treat the brothers who betrayed and abandoned him? Dive in and find out.

Session 13: The Brothers Go Down to Egypt

Key Takeaways

- Binyamin has replaced Yoseph in his father's heart as the beloved son.
- When Yoseph meets his brothers again, he turns their betrayal back on them, deceiving them and throwing them into prison. But ultimately, his aim is to test them.
- Yoseph accuses his brothers of coming to "look upon the nakedness" of the land (Gen. 42:9), identifying them with the sin of Ham when they ought to reflect the righteousness of Shem.
- The biblical authors put Yoseph testing his brothers on analogy with God testing Abraham.

Yoseph Tests His Brothers



Genesis 42:1-45:25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Act 2 of the story of Yoseph and his brothers consists of three main parts. The plot conflict between Yoseph and his brothers, which was set in the background for chapters 38-41 is now picked up and placed in the foreground again.

- In part 1 (Gen. 42:1-38), the conflict is introduced—Yoseph meets his brothers and tests their trustworthiness, imprisoning one.
- In part 2 (Gen. 43:1-44:34), the conflict intensifies to a climax—Yoseph tests his brothers again, compelling Yehudah to confess and offer himself as a substitute.
- In part 3 (Gen. 45:1-25a), the conflict resolves—Yoseph reveals himself to his brothers and invites his father and family to live in the safety of Goshen.

This forward, linear movement of parts 1-3 is simultaneously overlaid with a symmetrical literary design, indicated by the repetition of key words and themes.

42:1-5

- Ya'akov sends the brothers to Egypt for food: Binyamin cannot go
- **42:4** Ya'akov didn't send Binyamin, so that a disaster doesn't happen to him

42:6-28

- **42:6** Brothers meet Yoseph, ruler (השליט) of Egypt + Shim'on taken as a slave

42:29-38

- Brothers return to Canaan with food: Binyamin still cannot go
- **42:38** Binyamin not allowed to go, so that disaster doesn't happen to him

Genesis 43:1-44:34**43:1-15**

- Yehudah intercedes with Ya'akov, offering himself as a substitute for Binyamin

43:16-44:13

- Yoseph tests his brothers again + takes Binyamin as a slave

44:14-34

- Yehudah intercedes with Yoseph, offering himself as a substitute for Binyamin

Genesis 45:1-25a**45:1-3**

- Yoseph weeps and reveals himself to his brothers

45:4-13

- **45:8** Yoseph's speech: "Elohim has made me ruler (משל) of all Egypt"

45:14-25a

- Yoseph & brothers weep and he sends his brother back Ya'akov in Canaan with Binyamin

Genesis 42:1-45:25. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph's Brothers Are Sent to Egypt

Genesis 42:1-5

42:1

Ya'akov Sees That There Is Grain in Egypt

42:2

Ya'akov Orders His Sons To Go Down to Egypt for Grain

- "Buy grain, so that **we live and don't die!**" (מות + חיה)

42:3-5

Ya'akov Sends His Sons Without Binyamin

- 42:4 "So that a disaster doesn't happen (קרא) to him"
- 42:5 The sons go down to Egypt "Because the famine was severe in the land of Canaan"

Genesis 42:6-28

42:6-13

Yoseph Recognizes His Brothers, and Treats Them as Spies

- 42:10-11 "We came to buy grain ... we are upright, sons of **one (אחד) man** ... not spies!"

42:14-20

Yoseph Tests His Brothers and Demands They Bring Binyamin Down to Egypt

- 42:18 "Do this and **live (חיה)**"
- 42:20 "Let your words be proven trustworthy, **and y'all won't die (מות)**"

42:21-28

Yoseph Returns the Brothers' Silver and Sends Them Back to Canaan

- 42:27 "One (אחד) of the brothers opens his sack and finds silver"

Genesis 42:29-38

42:29-34

The Brothers Report to Ya'akov About the Harsh Ruler and the Loss of Shimon

- **42:29** The brothers return to the land of Canaan
- **42:29** They report to Ya'akov “all that happened (קרה) to them”
- **42:32** We said, “We are 12 sons of our father ... but one (אחד) is no more (איננו)”

42:35

The Brothers Find the Silver in Their Bags and Are Afraid

42:36-38

Ya'akov Responds to His Sons and Won't Allow Binyamin To Go

- **42:36** “Yoseph is no more (איננו), and Shimon is no more (איננו), and you would take Binyamin?!”
- **42:38** Binyamin's brother is dead (מות), so he will not go down with you ... so that a disaster doesn't happen (קרה) to him

Genesis 42:1-34. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yaaqov Sends His Sons to Egypt

¹ And Ya'akov saw that there was grain in Egypt,

and Ya'akov said to his sons,

“Why do you look at each other?”

² And he said,

“Look, I have heard that there is grain in Egypt,
go down there and buy grain for us from there,
so that we can live and not die!”

^a ³ And the ten brothers of Yoseph went down to buy grain in Egypt,

⁴ but Binyamin, the brother of Yoseph he did not send with his brothers,

^b because he said,

“So that disaster won't happen to him.”

⁵ And the sons of Yisra'el came to buy grain in the midst of those coming,

ב'

^c because there was the **famine** in the land of Cana'an.

Genesis 42:1-5. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Going to Egypt for Food ... Again

Now that the famine has begun, Yaaqov sees that a life-and-death decision is before them: They must go to Egypt to get food. This invites the reader to recall the parallel moment in the story of Abraham, after he first entered into the land of Canaan in Genesis 12.

Genesis 12:10 Instructor's Translation

Now there was a famine in the land, and Avram went down to Egypt to sojourn there, because the famine was heavy in the land.

This story about Abram in Genesis 12:10-20 focuses on his lack of trust in Yahweh and how he lies about Sarai to preserve his own life at her expense. This Egypt-famine episode in Abram's life was set on analogy to the garden-fruit-tree episode in Genesis 3 and focused on Abram's deception. Abram took on the role of the deceptive snake lying about the beautiful tree as he lied about his beautiful wife.

In this story about Abraham's grandson (Yaaqov) and great-grandsons (the 12 sons) going to Egypt in a time of famine, we are again anticipating a story of deception. But this time, the deceiver and his motives are going to be totally different!

The New Beloved Son

Notice that Yoseph's brother Binyamin has taken the place of Yoseph as the beloved son of Yaaqov. In contrast to Yaaqov's careless sending of Yoseph to his brothers back in Genesis 37, here Yaaqov will not give up the final son of his beloved wife Rachel. Notice the contrast.

Genesis 37: Yoseph Sent to His Brothers

Gen. 37:12-13

And **his brothers** went to shepherd the flock of their father in Shkhem, and Yisrael said to Yoseph, "Aren't your brothers shepherding in Shkhem? Go, **let me send you to them** ..." And **he sent him** from the valley of Hebron, and he came to Shkhem.

Genesis 42: Binyamin Not Sent With His Brothers

Gen. 42:3-4

And **the brothers** of Yoseph, ten, they went down to buy grain in Egypt, but Binyamin, the brother of Yoseph **he did not send with his brothers**, because he said, "So that disaster won't happen to him."

Sending and Not Sending the Brothers. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Life and Death and Food

Notice how the themes and key words of Genesis 2-3 are being evoked and inverted here.

- Instead of abundant food in a garden, the land has become a food-desert in a famine.
- Instead of abundant life, the land will now lead people to death unless they strive to produce food through difficult work and suffering.

Yoseph Meets His Brothers

In this dramatic section, Yoseph has his first encounter with his brothers after 13 years. The scene unfolds in three steps.

A - Genesis 42:6-13: The brothers leave the land and meet Yoseph, who accuses them of being spies.

B - Genesis 42:14-20: Yoseph proposes a test to prove the character of the brothers; Shimon is imprisoned.

A' - Genesis 42:21-28: The brothers confess their sin against Yoseph and return to the land grieved and guilty.

⁶ Now, Yoseph was the ruler over the land,
he was the one **selling grain** to all the people of the land,
and **the brothers** came,
and **they bowed down to him**, faces on the ground,

⁷ and Yoseph **saw** **his brothers**,
a and he **recognized** them,
and he made himself **unrecognizable** to them,
and he spoke to them harsh things,
and he said to them,
b "From where have y'all come?"
And they said,
"From the land of Cana'an, **to buy food**."
a' ⁸ And Yoseph **recognized** **his brothers**,
but they did not **recognize** him.

⁹ And Yoseph remembered **the dreams which he dreamed about them**,

Yoseph Speaks

A and he said to them ,
"Y'all are **spies** !
Y'all have come **to look upon the nakedness of the land** !"

Brothers Speak

¹⁰ **And they said to him** ,
"No, my master!
Your servants have come **to buy food** .

R

11 We are **all sons of one** man.
We are **upright** !
Your servants are not **spies** !”

Yoseph Speaks

A' 12 **And he said to them** ,
“No! Y'all have come **to look upon the nakedness of the land** .”

Brothers Speak

B' 13 **And they said** ,
“Your servants, we are **two and ten brothers**
sons of one man in the land of Cana'an.
And look, **the little one** is with his father,
and the **one** , he is no more.”

Genesis 42:6-13. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Yoseph Inverts the Brothers' Schemes

Notice how this section consists of three parts, the outer frames focusing on Yoseph's encounter with his brothers (Gen. 42:6) and his dialogue with them (Gen. 42:9-13). These outer parts surround the center part, which focuses on Yoseph's recognition of them. This uncommon word “recognize” appears four times in a short space, and it forms a link back to the brothers' response to Yoseph's arrival back in Genesis 37.

Genesis 42:7-9: Yoseph Sees His Brothers

And Yoseph **saw** **his brothers** ,
and he **recognized** them,
and he made himself **unrecognizable** (ויתנכר) to them.

And Yoseph **recognized** his brothers,
but they did not **recognize** him.
And Yoseph remembered the dreams which he dreamed
about them

“to make oneself unrecognizable” = Heb. **wayyitnakker**

Genesis 37:18-19: The Brothers See Yoseph

And **they saw** him from afar,
and before he came near to them,
they made a deceitful plan (ויתנכל) to
kill him.
And they said, each to his brother,
“Look, this master of the dreams, he
comes!

“to make a deceitful plan” = Heb.

Joseph and His Brothers See Each Other. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Joseph and His Brothers See Each Other. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph's response to his brothers recalls the brothers' response to him back in chapter 37, which raises the question of Yoseph's motives. It would be understandable if he saw this as an opportunity for revenge against his brothers. But it's also possible that Yoseph's suffering has shaped him into a more self-aware person who will not flaunt his privileged position as he did when he was 17 years old.

A Test and the Nakedness of the Land?

When Yoseph accuses his brothers of being spies, he creates an opportunity to discover whether or not they will tell the truth. In other words, Yoseph is testing his brothers' integrity.

This explains why the narrative from this point onward contains numerous verbal hyperlinks back to the test of Adam and Eve's faithfulness in [Genesis 3](#).

Gen. 42:9

and he said to them, "Y'all are spies!

Y'all have come to **see the nakedness** of the land!"

Gen. 3:7

Then **the eyes of both of them were opened, and they knew that they were naked**; and they sewed fig leaves together and made themselves loin coverings.

Gen. 9:22

Ham, the father of Canaan, **saw the nakedness** of his father, and told his two brothers outside.

Genesis 3 and 9 in the Joseph Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

These two stories from Genesis 1-11 are themselves tightly connected.

- Because of the snake, Adam and Eve are deceived and eat the fruit that enables them to "see the nakedness" of their bodies and then provide somewhat pathetic clothing for themselves.
- Because of the wine of the garden, Noah becomes a drunk fool, and his son Ham (the ancestor of Egypt! See Gen. 10:6) sees his nakedness.

Here in [Genesis 42](#), Yoseph accuses his brothers of being like a foolish Adam and Eve coming up with inadequate responses to their nakedness and like Ham, father of Egypt, who takes advantage of others.

Dreams and Their Fulfillment

Notice also how this section draws attention to the dreams of Yoseph and how they are beginning to be fulfilled.

- Genesis 37: Yoseph dreams of becoming a ruler whose family bows down to him.
- Genesis 42: Yoseph remembers his dreams as his brothers bow down before him.

Yoseph ... The Disguised Deceiving Tester

The previous section portrayed Yoseph’s brothers as Adam and Eve figures who are looking for food and seeing nakedness. This section takes the analogies with Genesis 3 further—Yoseph will propose a test that will prove the trustworthiness of his brothers.

In an ironic twist, Yoseph becomes the disguised deceiver who accuses his brothers’ of treachery precisely in order to test their integrity. This is an inverted analogy, where Yoseph takes on the role of deceptive figures in Genesis, but with a different aim. His goal is not to trap his brothers but to recreate the scenario of Genesis 37 in order to see if they have changed.

- The spiritual being in Genesis 3 disguised as a snake ([Gen. 3](#)).
- Abraham lying to Pharaoh in Egypt ([Gen. 12](#)).
- Yaaqov disguised as his brother to deceive his father ([Gen. 27](#)).
- Tamar disguised as a prostitute to deceive her father-in-law in order to save the family ([Gen. 38](#)).

This last and most recent disguised deceiver is of special importance because the story of Yehudah and Tamar was placed right after the story of Yoseph and his brothers in order to create an analogy between the two.

The Third Day and the Loss of a Son

Notice that Yoseph’s proposal quickly changes from (a) all the brothers imprisoned and one goes back to Yaaqov to (b) only one of the brothers imprisoned and the rest go back to Yaaqov. Yoseph is being quick on his feet, trying to disorient the brothers, all in an effort to recreate the circumstances of their betrayal in [Genesis 37](#).

Genesis 42	Genesis 22
Yoseph tests his brothers “on the third day” to see if they will abandon one of their brothers.	God tests Abraham “on the third day” to see if he will surrender his beloved son.
Genesis 42	Genesis 37
Yoseph takes one brother and allows the others to abandon him in Egypt while they return with food.	Yoseph is the one brother taken, while the others abandon him to Egypt while they return with the bloody garment.
Genesis 42 Versus 22 and 37. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

How the brothers react in this “replay” of their betrayal will tell Yoseph everything he needs to know.

This story is also designed to link back to the binding of Isaac in [Genesis 22](#).

Reflection Question

How is Yoseph testing his brothers like God testing Abraham?

Session 14: Jacob's Lost Sons

Key Takeaways

- Reuven laments that their brother's blood is required of them, activating a pattern of innocent blood crying out to God for justice that stretches all the way back to Cain and Abel in Genesis 4.
- Yoseph's translator is called a "mediator," the same word used to describe the prophets who stand in the gap and intercede between God and Israel.
- The Bible presents a realistic portrait of the human condition, and characters who seem simple at first glance have layers of complexity and insight.

The Brothers' Confession

²¹ And each man said to his brother,
"Oh no! **We are guilty** concerning **our brother**,
when we saw the **distress** (צרה) of his very being, when he pleaded for favor from us,
and **we didn't listen**!
For this reason, this distress (צרה) **has come upon us!**"

²² And Reuven answered them saying,
"Didn't I speak to you, saying,
'Don't **sin** against the boy!'
But **y'all didn't listen**,
and now look, **his blood is required!**"

²³ Now, they did not know that **Yoseph was listening**,
because there was a mediator between them,
²⁴ and he turned away from them and wept,
and **he returned** to them,
and **he spoke** to them,
and he took **Shim'on** from them,
and he **bound him up** before their eyes.

²⁵ **And Yoseph commanded**
that they should fill their **bags** with **grain**,
and **to return** their **silver**, each in his **sack**,

and to give them **rations** (צֹדֶה) for the road.

And so it was done for them .

26 And they took up their **grain** onto their donkeys,
and they went from there,

27 and **one** opened up his **sack**, to give fodder to his donkey at the night-stop,
and he saw his **silver**,
and look, it was in the mouth of his **bag** .

28 And he said **to his brothers**,

“My **silver** has been **returned** ,
and look, its it my **bag** !”

And their hearts went out,

and they shuddered, **each man to his brother, saying** ,

“ **What is this that Elohim is doing to us?!** ”

Genesis 42:21-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

After Yoseph recreates the scenario of Genesis 37 by imprisoning Shimon as a test (recall that this test is set on analogy to the snake and the test of Adam and Eve), his brothers begin processing the poetic justice of their situation. And they do so in speeches filled with the language of the Cain and Abel story from Genesis 4.

Genesis 42	Genesis 4
Gen. 42:21 “We are guilty concerning our brother”	Gen. 4:13 “My guilt/punishment is too great to bear!”
Gen. 42:22 “Didn’t I say, ‘Don’t sin against the boy?’”	Gen. 4:7 “If you don’t do good, sin is crouching at the door; it’s desire is for you, and you can rule it.”
Gen. 42:22 “Now look, his blood is required”	Gen. 4:10 “The voice of your brother’s blood is crying to me from the ground.”
Gen. 42:28 “What is Elohim doing to us?!”	Gen. 4:10 “What is this you have done?!”
Comparing Genesis 42 and Genesis 4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Just as God confronted Cain after murdering his brother, now Yoseph confronts his brothers after they sold him as a slave and pretended that he was murdered. This scene of Yoseph bringing his brothers' sin to light is clearly being linked to God’s confrontation with Cain to bring his murderous sin to light.

III-Gotten Silver

The narrative focuses on the silver found in the mouth of the camel bags. This seems to be an intentional parallel to the “20 shekels of silver” that the brothers received by selling Yoseph as a slave headed for Egypt (recall Gen. 37:27-28). Now the brothers are in Egypt, and though a brother was imprisoned, they now also have their money back!

Yoseph here recreates the circumstances of his slavery sale down to the last detail. The brothers now have extra money and plenty of food for a time, the only cost is their brother. Will the brothers go back and lie to Yaaqov again, as they did about Yoseph, or will they choose differently?

The Brothers Return to Yaaqov

Report of Yoseph's Speech

- 29 And they came to Ya'akov **their father** **in the land of Cana'an** ,
A and they told him **everything that happened** to them, saying,
30 “ **The man, the master of the land, spoke** harsh things **to us** ,
and he took us to be like **spies** of the land!

Report of Brothers' Speech

- 31 **And we said to him** ,
‘We are **upright** !
B We are not **spies** !
32 We are **two and ten brothers, sons of our father** .
One is no more ,
and the **little one** is with **our father** today, **in the land of Cana'an** .’

Report of Yoseph's Speech

- 33 **And the man, the master of the land, said to us** ,
‘**By this I will know that y'all are upright** :
Your **one brother** , make him rest here with me,
A' and the famine-ration for your houses, take and go!
34 And bring to me **your little brother** ,
so I can know that y'all are not spies, that y'all are upright !
I will give **your brother** to you,
then you may trade in the land.”

35 And it came about, as they were emptying their **sacks** ,
that look, each had a **pouch of silver** in his **sack** ,
and they saw the **pouches of silver** , they and their father,
and they became afraid.

Ya'akov's Speech

36 **And their father Ya'akov said to them**,
"Y'all have bereaved me!
A **Yoseph is no more** !
Shim'on is no more!
And you would take **Binyamin** ?!
These things always come upon me !"

Reuven's Speech

37 And **Reuven** said to **their father** , saying,
B "Put **my two sons** to death,
if I do not return him to you!
Give him into my hand,
and I will return him to you!"

Ya'akov's Speech

38 **And he said** ,
" **My son** will not **go down** with y'all,
A' **because his brother is dead** ,
and he alone is the remnant,
and **should disaster happen to him** on the road you go upon,
then you would make my gray-hair **go down** to the grave in grief."

Genesis 42:29-38. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Yaaqov's Many Lost Sons

Notice how Yaaqov sees a disastrous pattern at work in his life. He compares the past loss of Yoseph to the present loss of Shimon. And now both are compared to the potential loss of Binyamin in the future.

Also recall how Yaaqov's lost sons were earlier compared to Yehudah's two lost sons, Er and Onan, who both died at the beginning of Genesis 38. The loss of those two sons was restored by the birth of the twins from Tamar, the disguised deceiver whose deception led to life.

Here Yaaqov's two lost sons (Yoseph and Shimon) are going to be restored through the disguised deception of Yoseph! But not before another layer of complications and testing.

Reuven's Inadequate Offer

In Genesis 37, Reuven proposed a plan to save Yoseph that did not work. Instead, it was the plan of his younger brother Yehudah that was accepted, and so Yoseph was sold as a slave. Now Reuven, the firstborn of Yaaqov, offers the lives of his own two sons in the place of Shimon and Binyamin. While this could appear noble, it does seem a bit misdirected. Instead of confessing his own treachery and betrayal, he offers up the lives of his innocent sons to die for his own sins.

Yaaqov refuses this offer, as it will only result in more death. It's better to cut his losses and move forward. This portrait of Reuven, as a failed firstborn, repeats his failure from Genesis 37 and opens the way for his younger brother Yehudah to propose an even more noble plan, which is precisely what's going to happen.

Binyamin, the New Yoseph

Notice how Yaaqov's response mirrors the response he gave when he was shown Yoseph's garment.

Genesis 42:38

And he said,
 "My son will not go down with y'all,
 because his brother is dead,
 and he alone is the remnant,
 and should disaster happen to him ... **you would make
 my gray-hair go down to the grave in grief ."**

Genesis 37:35

And all his sons and all his daughters got
 up to comfort him,
 and he refused to be comforted,
 and he said, "Surely, **I will go down to my
 son, grieving, to the grave !"**
 And his father wept for him.

Grieving in Genesis 42 and Genesis 37. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph's Brothers Take a Second Trip to Egypt

Genesis 43:1-15

43:1-5

Ya'akov & Yehudah Debate About Going Down to Egypt; Without Binyamin, They Cannot Return

- **43:3** "[Yoseph] swore an oath (העֵד הָעֵד) that we can't see him with our brother"
- **43:5** "If you do not send him, we cannot go down"

43:6-7

Ya'akov & The Brothers Debate About Yoseph's Demand to See Binyamin

43:8-15

Yehudah and **Ya'akov** Debate Going Down to Egypt With Binyamin

- **43:8** "Send the young boy (נֶעֱר) with me!"
- **43:9a** Yehudah swears to offers his life as a **substitute pledge (עֶרֶב)** in place of Binyamin
- **43:9b** "If I do not return [Binyamin] to you, it will be my sin against you all my days"

Genesis 43:15-44:13

43:15-25

The Brothers Go Down to Egypt, Return the Silver, and Are Brought Into Yoseph's House For A Meal

- **43:16** Yoseph said to the one over his house, "Bring the men inside"
- **43:21-22** "We brought the [extra] silver in our hands ... we don't know who put it in our bags!"

43:26-34

Yoseph Seats the Brothers for a Meal, Treating Binyamin With More Favor Than the Brothers

44:1-13

The Brothers Are Sent Back to Canaan, Binyamin Is Caught With the Silver Divination Cup

- **44:1-2** Yoseph said to the one over his house, "Put silver in each man's bag ... and put my silver cup in the bag of the little one"
- **44:8** "Look, we found silver in our bags and we returned it to you!"

Genesis 44:14-34

44:14

Yehudah & Brothers Return to Yoseph and Fall Down Before Him

44:15-17

Yoseph & **Yehudah** Discuss About the Stolen Silver Divination Cup

44:18-34

Yehudah's Speech Before Yoseph

- Yehudah retells the events of 43:1-15:
 - **44:33** "Let the young boy (נער) return back up with his brothers!"
 - **44:32-34** He offers his own life as a substitute pledge (ערב) in place of Binyamin and his father
 - **44:32** "If I do not return [Binyamin] to you, it will be my sin against my father for all my days"

Genesis 43:1-44:34. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This large section is the center of the center of the story of Yoseph and his brothers. It consists of three larger units (Gen. 43:1-15, 43:15-44:13, and 44:14-34) designed as a symmetry.

- The outer sections highlight a transformed Yehudah, who sees that their entire family is going to die if Yaaqov won't surrender the life of Binyamin. He is compelled to do the opposite of what he did to Yoseph in Genesis 37, and he offers his own life in the place of Yoseph's brother.

- The inner section focuses on the climactic additional test that Yoseph forces the brothers to undergo. With Binyamin now in Egypt, Yoseph can test their integrity even more precisely: he will create a scenario where they are forced to choose between Binyamin and a load of silver, just they did in Genesis 37.
- This three-part section brings all the themes and conflict between Yoseph and his brothers to a climax, as the brothers' evil comes full circle upon them.

It is also important to notice that Genesis 43-45 replays the main movements of the preceding Genesis 42. However, each step of the narrative in Genesis 42 is developed in greater detail and drama by its parallel in Genesis 43-45. In this way, the story feels like an intensified replay that forces the drama to its finish.

Genesis 42	Plot Elements	Genesis 43-45
Gen. 42:1-4	Yaaqov sends his sons to Egypt to buy grain (שֶׁבֶר) and get food.	Gen. 43:1-14
Gen. 42:5	Arrival in Egypt	Gen. 43:15-25
Gen. 42:6-16	First audience with Yoseph	Gen. 43:26-34
Gen. 42:17	Brothers in custody	Gen. 44:1-13
Gen. 42:25	Departure from Egypt with money secretly returned in the bags	Gen. 44:1
Gen. 42:18-24	Second audience with Yoseph	Gen. 44:14-45:15
Gen. 42:25-28	Departure from Egypt	Gen. 45:16-24
Gen. 42:29-38	Sons report to Yaaqov	Gen. 45:25-28
<i>Plot Elements of Genesis 42-45. Adapted from Godon J. Wenham, Genesis 16-50, 419.</i>		

Reflection Question

How are tragic characters in the Bible valuable for modern readers?

Session 15: The Brothers Return to Egypt

Key Takeaways

- The phrase “see my face” (Gen. 43:3, 5) links Yoseph and his brothers to the reconciliation of Yaaqov and Esau, which points to the larger reality of reconciliation with God.
- Yehudah offers his own life as a substitute for the beloved son. This is what rescues the family from death and opens up the chance for life.
- Genesis 43 is Yaaqov’s Mount Moriah moment as he finally surrenders his beloved son.

Yaaqov Sends His Sons Again, With Binyamin

Yaaqov and Yehudah Go Head to Head

This unit consists of alternating dialogues between Yaaqov and his sons, but the narrative especially highlights Yehudah, who becomes the successful intercessor on behalf of the entire family.

The thematic focus points are the need to “return” to get food so that they can live and the necessity of giving up the “son/brother” to make the journey to Egypt.

This scene shows Yehudah’s transformation of character since chapters 37-38. Just as Yehudah compelled the brothers to sell Yoseph to the traders who took him to Egypt, so now Yehudah compels his father to send Binyamin so they can go down trade in Egypt. That similarity also highlights a contrast.

- In Genesis 37, Yehudah profited at the expense of the beloved son.
- In Genesis 38, Yehudah spared his only remaining son Shelah, though he gave a down payment (ערב) to gain sexual pleasure with Tamar.
- In Genesis 43, Yehudah asks Yaaqov to risk the loss of his beloved and only remaining son of Rachel by giving his own life as a down payment (ערב).

Notice the contrast between Reuven and Yehudah’s intercession with Yaaqov.

Reuven’s Offer: Genesis 42:37

And Reuven said:
“You may put to death my two sons
if **I don’t return him to you**,

Yehudah’s Offer: Genesis 43:8-9

And Yehudah said to Israel his father:
“Send the boy with me ...
I give myself as a pledge,

Comparing Reuben’s and Judah’s Offers. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Reuven's Offer: Genesis 42:37

give him into my hand
and **I will return him to you** .”

Yehudah's Offer: Genesis 43:8-9

from my hand you can require it,
if **I do not return him to you**
and set him before you,
then **it will be my sin** against you all the days.”

Comparing Reuben's and Judah's Offers. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Reuven's offer to his father shows he is ready to offer something of extreme value—the lives of his two sons. However, the idea backfires. Yaaqov would lose not only Binyamin, but also two of his grandsons (not to mention that the son making this offer is the one who betrayed him by sleeping with his wife in [35:20-22](#)).

Yehudah's offer, by contrast, shows a deep change of character, with an allusion back to [Genesis 38:17-18](#). Yehudah offers his own life as a “down-payment” (ערב), reminding the reader of his self-oriented down-payment for quick sex in [chapter 38](#). In this story, Yehudah's pledge shows a focus on the well-being of others, his father, and the life of Binyamin, as well as the lives of the children of the entire family (“our little ones”).

These narrative plot elements make a powerful point that links back to the overall themes of Genesis.

Yehudah's offer of his own life as a substitute for the beloved son is what rescues the family from death and opens up the chance for life.

Yaaqov sends the brothers and the beloved son to offer “as an offering, a little balm (צרי) and a little honey, aromatic gum (נבאת) and myrrh (לט), pistachio nuts and almonds” ([Gen. 43:11](#)). These are precisely the objects that the Yishmaelites were carrying when they took Yoseph down to Egypt ([Gen. 37:25](#)).

Yoseph Tests His Brothers a Second Time

¹⁵ And the men took this **offering**,
and they took **the double silver** in their hand,
and Binyamin,
and they got up and **they went down** to Egypt,
and they stood before Yoseph.

¹⁶ And Yoseph saw with them Binyamin,
and he said to **the one over his house**,
“**Bring the men into the house**,
and slaughter a slaughter-animal and **prepare it**,
because the men will **eat with me at noon**.”

17 And the man did just as Yoseph said,
and **the man brought the men into the house** of Yoseph,

18 and the men became afraid, because **they were brought into the house** of Yoseph,
and they said,

“It’s on account of **the silver that was returned in our sacks** in the beginning,
we are being brought in so he can roll over on us and fall upon us,
and to take us as servants, and our donkeys!”

19 And they drew near to **the man who was over the house** of Yoseph,
and they spoke to him at the door of the house,

20 and they said,

“Please, my master!

We came down in the beginning **to buy grain**,

21 and it came about when we went to the night-stop,

and we opened **our sacks**,

and look, **the silver** of each was in the mouth of **his sack**,

our silver by its weight,

so we return it in our hands,

22 and other **silver** **we have brought down** in our hand **to buy grain**.

We don’t know who put our **silver in our sacks**!”

23 And he said,

“Peace to y’all, don’t be afraid.

Elohim, and the Elohim of your fathers **has given you a treasure in your sacks**.

Your silver came to me.”

And he brought out Shim’on to them.

24 And **the man brought the men into the house** of Yoseph,
and he gave them water,
and they washed their feet,
and he gave fodder to their donkeys.

25 And **they prepared** the **offering** until Yoseph came **at noon**,
because they heard that **they would eat bread** there.

Genesis 43:15-25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

The Brothers Prepare Their Offering

Notice how this section begins and ends with references to the “offering” (מנחה) that the brothers have prepared for Yoseph (Gen. 43:15, 25). This is the same word first used to describe the offerings of Cain and

Abel

([Gen. 4:3-4](#)), and it also alludes to the sacrifice of Noah (“offering” has the letters of Noah's name in the middle) that turned the curse of the flood into a blessing of new creation.

After this section, however, all mention of the food offering falls away because Yehudah's offering of his own life takes center stage. It's as if Yehudah becomes the real “offering” in place of the food offering.

God at Work in Hidden Ways

The brothers' fear is highlighted in [Genesis 43:18](#). They are convinced that Yoseph is setting them up for a trap because of the mistaken silver. How ironic, because Yoseph is in fact testing them with this silver, but not in the way they assume.

This scene highlights the brothers' developing characters yet again, by focusing on the silver in their bags. They know that they are innocent regarding the money, and ironically so does Yoseph, but they assume Yoseph will use it as evidence of their dishonesty. The conversation at the “door of the house” becomes the pivot point, as their fears and honesty are expressed to Yoseph's servant, who ironically tells them that “God has given you treasure!”

The irony, of course, is that while they are innocent regarding this particular silver, they are guilty of taking the silver for selling their brother in [chapter 37](#), which this silver recalls. But in this case, the brothers show that they value honesty and their brother's safety over the money, a big contrast from chapter 37.

Reflection Question

How does the phrase “you cannot see my face” in [Genesis 43:5](#) connect to the theme of the reconciliation of the brothers, and how does it play into reconciliation with God?

Session 16: Judah's Offering

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew words for “divination” and “snake,” *nakhash*, are spelled with the same letters. Yoseph’s cup of divination identifies him as the disguised tester, but instead of a trap, his test provides an opportunity for his brothers to do the right thing.
- Throughout Genesis, when the son is lost through death or exile, it is only when a chosen son gives up their life and is replaced by a sacrificial substitute that the story of God’s purposes moves forward.
- The portrait of the two brothers, Yoseph and Yehudah, is really about one thing—a beloved son who gives up his own life as a substitute for many so all might be saved.

Rival Brothers Eating in Unity and Disunity

26 And Yoseph came **into the house**,
and **they brought to him** the **offering** that was in their hand, **into the house**,
and they bowed down to him on the ground.

27 And he asked them about their **peace**,
and he said,
“Is there **peace** to **your father**, **the old one**,
of whom you spoke?
Is he still alive?”

28 And they said,
“There is **peace** for **our father**.
He is still alive.”

And they kneeled and bowed down.

29 And he lifted his eyes,
and he saw **Binyamin his brother**, the son of his mother,

and he said,
“Is this **your brother**, **the little one**,
of whom you spoke?”

And he said,

“May Elohim **show favor** to you, my son.”

³⁰ And Yoseph acted quickly, because his compassion-guts were warmed for **his brother**,
and he sought to weep,
and he went into a room,
and he wept there.

³¹ And he washed **his face** ,
and he went back out,
and he restrained himself,
and he said,

“Set out **the bread**.”

³² And they set him by himself,
and them by themselves,
and the Egyptians who **ate** with him by themselves,
because the Egyptians aren’t able to **eat bread** with Hebrews,
because it is taboo for Egyptians.

³³ And they sat **before his face** ,
the **firstborn** according to his **first-born status** ,
and **the small-one** according to his **small-one status** ,
and the men were shocked, each to his companion.

³⁴ And he took portions to them from **before his face** ,
and the portion of **Binyamin** was greater than all their portions by five-hands,
and **they drank and they drank heavily** with him.

Genesis 43:26-34. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

This scene revolves around a huge meal shared by multiple rival parties.

- Yoseph and his brothers
- The sons of Yisrael (from Shem) and the sons of Egypt (from Ham)

While this meal is going to set in motion the events that lead to the reconciliation of Yoseph and his brothers, they are still divided among themselves, and the rift between them and Yoseph is still huge.

Elements of brotherly unity are prominent in this scene.

- Yoseph is reunited with his brother Binyamin, who is his inverted doppelganger in this moment—Binyamin the beloved son has been brought down to Egypt by the brothers who are carrying money they believe doesn’t belong to them.
- But the presence of Binyamin with the money shows that the brothers have truly changed since Genesis 37. They now have two-times the money, and could easily abandon father and brother and run

away with the cash. But instead, they have safely delivered both brother and money out of devotion to their father.

- The brothers' bowing down means much more than the first time in [Genesis 42:6](#). It provides a second fulfillment of Yoseph's dreams in [Genesis 37:7-10](#), but it does more given the intervening narrative. Now the brothers' bowing is before not just Yoseph as their authority, but as their merciful brother who is coming to know that they also fear God as he does.
- The meal scene recalls the multiple "reconciliation over meals" design patterns; when brothers make peace they often "eat and drink" together (Isaac and Abimelech in [Gen. 26:30](#), Yaaqov and Laban in [Gen. 31:46, 54](#)).
- This scene also reverses the betrayal in Genesis 37, when the brothers threw Yoseph into the pit, "they sat down to eat bread" ([לֹאכַל לֶחֶם](#), [Gen. 37:24](#)). So now in this moment of potential reconciliation, they sit down to eat bread ([Gen. 43:31](#)), BUT they are sitting separately, which becomes a physical image of their relational separation.

Elements in this scene also highlight the remaining disunity among the brothers. The seating scene highlights multiple remaining rifts in the relationship in increasing stages.

- In [Genesis 43:32](#), Yoseph and his brothers and the Egyptians (sons of Ham) cannot yet sit together (notice how the rift between the sons of Ham and Shem are set in relationship to the rift between the sons of Rachel and Leah).
- In [Genesis 43:33](#), The brothers are arranged according to their "rival" birth positions: recalling Reuven's power grab from Yaaqov in [Genesis 35:22](#), and Shimon and Levi's treachery in [chapter 34](#).
- In [Genesis 43:34](#), Binyamin is favored over his brothers, which recalls Yaaqov's favor of Yoseph.

This is all part of Yoseph's test!

- After restoring Shimon to the brothers ([Gen. 43:23](#)), Yoseph has all the brothers together, and this meal of reconciliation becomes one more stage to the test as he recreates the scene from [Genesis 37](#).
- Yoseph seats the brothers according to birth order, which brings to mind the unfair elevation of Yoseph that generated their rivalry in the first place. From Reuven down to Binyamin, each is sat according to their rank, which would highlight Binyamin's low status in the family.
- But then, Yoseph brilliantly gives Binyamin five times more food than any of the other brothers! Yoseph is treating Binyamin with extravagant favor, just as Yaaqov treated him. Yoseph's coat of colors is matched by Binyamin's five portions!
- Yoseph's goal is to recreate the conditions of [Genesis 37](#), to see if the brothers are going to treat Binyamin, the beloved son of Yaaqov, the way that they treated him.

Yoseph the Righteous Snake-Tester

44:1 And he commanded the one over his house, saying,
"Fill **the sacks** of the men with food,
as much as they are able to carry.
And set **the silver** of each in **the mouth of his sack**.
2 And **my goblet, the goblet** of silver,

you will set in **the mouth of the sack** of **the little one** ,
and **the silver** of his trade-grain.”
And he did **according to the word** that Yoseph spoke.

³ At the morning light,
the men were sent out, they and **their donkeys**.

⁴ **As they went out of the city**,
they had not gone far,
then Yoseph said to the one over his house,
“Get up, chase after the men,
and overtake them and say to them,
‘Why have to repaid evil in the place of good?!
⁵ Isn’t **this** what my master uses to drink?
And doesn’t he **perform divination with it** ?
You have done evil by doing this!’”

⁶ **And he overtook them**,
and **he spoke to them these words** ,

⁷ **and they said** to him,
a “Why does my master **speak words** like these?!
Far be it from **your servants** to do a thing like this!
b ⁸ Look, **the silver** that we found in **the mouth of our sacks**,
we returned it to you from the land of Cana’an,
so how could we steal from the house of our master, **silver or gold** ?
a’ ⁹ **The one** among **your servants** with whom **it is found**, he must die,
and as for us, **we will become your servants** .”

¹⁰ **And he said** ,
“So now, **according to your words** , so it will be.
The one with whom **it is found** **will become my servant** ,
and y’all will be innocent.”

¹¹ And they each quickly got down **his sack** , onto the ground,
and each opened up **his sack** ,

¹² **and he searched**, starting with **the biggest** and finishing with **the smallest** ,
and he found the goblet **in the sack** of **Binyamin**.

¹³ And they tore their garments,
and each burdened upon **his donkey**,
and they returned to the city.

Yoseph brings his test of the brothers to its climax.

- The scene is framed by Yoseph's filling of the sacks, placing the cup, and the brothers leaving the city, matched by their opening the sacks, finding the cup, and going back to the city.
- Yoseph replays his first test, of giving them their silver in return ([ch. 42](#)), but now the stakes are higher, with the silver cup in Binyamin's bag. If the brothers resisted the temptation to take off with the double money in chapter 42, now they are in a position to take double the money and be rid of their brother. After Yoseph's attempt to arouse the brothers' jealousy by giving the extra portions to Binyamin, he now provides them with an attempt to ditch their favored younger brother.
- Notice also how the brothers' suggestion is countered by Yoseph's servant, precisely in order to provide the brothers with the perfect chance to abandon Binyamin and take off with the money.

The Brothers' Suggestion	The Servant's Restatement
(1) With whomever it is found	Now let it also be according to your words, (1) with whomever it is found
(2) among your servants, let him die,	(2) shall be my servant,
(3) and we also will be my lord's slaves.	(3) and y'all shall be innocent.
<i>Brothers' Suggestion Versus Servant's Restatement.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

The focus on the "silver goblet" is curious, along with the apparently random statement of Yoseph that he uses the goblet to perform divination. This phrase is very intentional, however, as it forms a hyperlink to two earlier stories.

- Yaaqov's flight from Laban
- Rachel's theft of the idols

Genesis 44	Genesis 30-31
Gen. 44:4 "Go, chase after (רדף אחרי) the men and overtake them (נשג)"	Gen. 31:23 Laban "took his brothers and chased after (רדף אחרי) him ... and overtook (דבק) him in the hills"
Gen. 44:4 "Why have you repaid good with	Gen. 31:24 God to Laban: "Be careful that you
<i>Comparing Genesis 44 and Genesis 30-31.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Genesis 44	Genesis 30-31
bad/evil?"	don't speak to Yaaqov good or bad."
Gen. 44:5 "Doesn't [Yoseph] perform divination (נחש) with this cup?"	Gen. 30:27 Laban: "I have learned by divination (נחש) that Yahweh has blessed me on account of you."
Gen. 44:2 The cup is placed in the saddle-bag of Binyamin, son of Rachel	Gen. 31:19, 34 Rachel stole the household idols that belong to her father and placed them in the camel's saddle-bag
Gen. 44:12 Yoseph's servant "searches" (חפש) for the cup, starting with the oldest and ending with the youngest, finding (מצא) the cup in Binyamin's sack	Gen. 31:33-34 Laban searches through the tents for his idols, starting with the oldest Leah, ending with the youngest Rachel, finding (מצא) nothing.
Gen. 44:5 "You all have done a bad thing by doing this!"	Gen. 31:26 "What have you done, by deceiving me?"
Gen. 44:9 "The one with whom it is found, that one will die."	Gen. 31:32 "The one with whom you find your idol-gods, that one will not live."
<i>Comparing Genesis 44 and Genesis 30-31. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

These parallels clearly establish an analogy between Yaaqov and Rachel's deception of Laban and the staged "deception" of the brothers against Yoseph. This parallel, however, only highlights the ironic reversals at work.

- In reality, it is Yoseph who is counter-deceiving his brothers for their original betrayal and deception against him and Yaaqov.
- This is another example of the children replaying and intensifying the failures of their parents, in ways that twist and invert the original evil.

Yehudah Surrenders His Life for Binyamin

¹⁴ **And Yehudah came**, and his brothers, into the house of Yoseph, and he was still there, and he fell before him on the ground.

Yoseph Speaks

- ¹⁵ And Yoseph said to them,
A "What is **this thing that you have done** ?!
Don't you know that a man like me **performs divination** ?"

Yehudah Speaks

- ¹⁶ And Yehudah said,
" **What can** we say to **my master** ?
What can we speak?
B **What can** we do to prove ourselves right?
Elohim **has found** out the iniquity of **your servants** .
Look, we are **servants** for **my master** ,
Both us, and **the one with whom the goblet was found in his hand.**"

Yoseph Speaks

- ¹⁷ And he said,
A' "Far be it from me **to do such a thing** !
The man with whom the goblet was found in his hand,
that one will become **my servant** .
And you all can go up in peace to your father."

- ¹⁸ **And Yehudah drew near** ,
and he said,
"Please **my master** ,
let **your servant** speak, please, a word in the ears of **my master** ,
and don't let your anger burn hot against **your servant** ,
because you are like Phar'oh."

Genesis 44:14-18. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

- ¹⁹ " **My master** asked **his servants** , saying,
'Do you have a **father** or **brother** ?'
²⁰ And we said to **my master** ,
'We do have a **father**, **an old one** ,
and **a child** of his old age, **a little one** .
And **his brother** is dead,
and he alone remains of **his mother** ,
and **his father** loves him.'

21 And you said to **your servants** ,
'**Bring him down** to me,
so I can set my eyes upon him.'

22 And we said to **my master** ,
'The **boy** is not able to leave **his father**.
If he leaves, **his father** will die.'

23 And you said to **your servants** ,
'If **your brother** , **the little one** , does not **come down** with you,
you will not again see my face.'

Genesis 44:19-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

A 24 "And it came about, when **we went up** to **your servant** , **my father** ,
that **we told him** the words of **my master** ,

B 25 and **our father said to us** ,
'Return, and buy grain for us, a little food.'

26 **And we said** ,
'**We** are not able to **go down** .
A' If **our brother** , **the little one** , is with us, then we will go down,
because we are not able to see the face of the man,
if **our brother** , **the little one** , is not with us.'

27 And **your servant** , **our father** , said to us,
'You all know that my wife bore for me **two** ,
28 and **the one** went out from me,
and I said,
"Indeed, he has been torn apart!"
And I have not seen him even until now.
29 And you would take also **this one** from before my face?!
Disaster will happen to him!
And then **you will make my gray hair go down in evil to the grave!**'

30 So now, when I go to **your servant** , **my father** ,
and **the boy** is not with us,
his very being is bound together with his very being,
A 31 and when he sees that **the boy** is not with us, **then he will die** ,
and **your servants** **would make the gray hair** of **your servant** , **our father** ,

go down to the grave in grief.

32 Surely, **your servant** has given himself as **a down-payment** for **the boy** with **my father**,
B saying,
'If I do not bring him to you,
it will be my sin against **my father** all of my days.'

33 So now, let **your servant** please sit **in the place of** **the boy** as **a servant** to **my master**,
and **the boy**, let him **go up** with his brothers,
A' 34 because how can I **go up** to **my father**,
and **the boy** is not with me?
So I don't have to see **the evil that would find** **my father**!"

Genesis 44:24-34. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Yehudah's Speech: A Rhetorical Masterpiece

The scene begins and ends with the brothers standing before Yoseph ([Gen. 44:14](#) and [45:1](#)), and the macro-design displays a two-step dialogue between Yoseph and Yehudah. Yoseph's two speeches focus on the stolen cup and the consequence of taking Binyamin as a slave. Yehudah's two responses are paired through the way he and the brothers show complete solidarity with their younger brother Binyamin.

Yehudah's two speeches respond to Yoseph's words in step. In [Genesis 44:16](#), Yehudah reframes the terms of Yoseph's servant by saying that all of the brothers will be enslaved along with Binyamin. Once Yoseph denies this possibility, Yehudah steps up and offers just himself.

Yehudah's speech begins with an opening plea to hear ([Gen. 44:18](#)), and then falls into two parts.

1. Part 1: [Genesis 44:19-28](#) recounts the basic narrative of [chapters 42-43](#) as a series of dialogues between Yoseph and the brothers ([Gen. 44:19-23](#)), and then between the brothers and Yaaqov ([Gen. 44:24-29](#)). Notice how the framing sections focus on Yaaqov's two beloved sons with Rachel, so that Binyamin and Yoseph's death are mentioned in just [Genesis 44:19-20](#) and in [Genesis 44:27-29](#).
 - Inside of that frame, Yehudah presents the brothers as stuck between two impossible expectations: Yoseph said it was impossible to see him or to get food without Binyamin ([Gen. 44:21-23](#)), while Yaaqov made it impossible to take Binyamin to Egypt ([Gen. 44:24-26](#)). This portrays the real tension as taking place between Yoseph and Yaaqov, and paints the brothers as helpless messengers.
2. Part 2: The second half of Yehudah's speech in [Genesis 44:30-34](#) plays to Yoseph's empathy for an old man. In the first and last statements, Yehudah says that if the brothers return to Yaaqov without Binyamin, it will kill their aging father ([Gen. 44:30-31](#) and [44:34](#)). Inside this movement are two paired statements about Yehudah's willingness to give his life in the place of Binyamin's. This is the climax of the speech, and it represents a stunning character development in Yehudah.
 - In [Genesis 44:32](#), Yehudah recounts how he offered himself as a pledge for Binyamin and how leaving Binyamin behind would be an eternal sin against his father.

- In Genesis 44:33, Yehudah turns his past pledge to Yaaqov into a present plea to Yoseph as he offers himself “in the place of” his brother. This is precisely what Yehudah did not do in chapter 37, when he tried to profit off the slavery of the beloved son Yoseph. In this moment, Yehudah reverses his past failure and redeems his compromised character.

Yehudah Becomes Adam and Eve and Cain

This exchange between the two brothers Yoseph and Yehudah is packed with verbal links to earlier narratives that carry on the analogies with Genesis 3-4 that began earlier.

Yoseph is portrayed as Elohim, who tests Adam and Eve and shows up asking Cain what he has done.

Genesis 44	Genesis 3-4
Gen. 44:15 Yoseph: “Don’t you know that a man like me performs divination (נחש ינחש)?”	Gen. 3:1 “Now, the snake (נחש) was shrewd, more than any beast of the field.”
Gen. 44:15 “What is this thing that you have done?!”	Gen. 3:13 Yahweh to Eve: “What is this thing that you have done?” Gen. 4:10 Yahweh to Cain: “What have you done?”
Gen. 44:16 “Elohim has found out (מצא) the iniquity (עון) of your servants.”	Gen. 4:13-14 Cain to Yahweh: “My iniquity (עון) is too great to bear ... anyone who finds (מצא) will kill me.”
Gen. 44:18 Yehudah to Yoseph: “Don’t let your anger burn hot against your servant.”	Gen. 4:6 Yahweh to Cain: “Why does your anger burn hot?”
<i>Repeated Language in Genesis 44 and Genesis 3-4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Yoseph’s confrontation with his brothers is compared here to God coming to Adam and Eve and Cain immediately after their acts of folly and evil (and recall that Gen. 3-4 first set up the analogy between parents and children).

The snake/cup turns out to be an instrument of testing the faithfulness of the chosen ones.

Binyamin and Yehudah, the Son and the Substitute

Yehudah’s speech culminates a large-scale design pattern that has been at work since Genesis 37. Since the beginning of the story of Yoseph and his brothers, the narrator has been showing how the two sons of the beloved Rachel are parallel to Yaaqov, Isaac, and Abel.

Parallels With Abel

Abel is the younger son who is murdered by his older brother because he's filled with jealousy and anger at Yahweh's favor on his offering. // Binyamin is the younger brother of Yoseph, who is sold as a slave and virtually "murdered" by his jealous and angry older brothers.

The deceased Abel is replaced with Seth, who is born "in the place of" (תחת) his brother Abel (see Gen. 4:25-26). // Binyamin is replaced by Yehudah, who offers himself "in the place of" (תחת) Binyamin.

Parallels With Yaaqov

Binyamin is, along with Yoseph, a beloved son of Yaaqov's beloved wife Rachel. // Yaaqov is the beloved son of Rebekah. Binyamin is the last remaining son of Rachel, and he is not allowed to leave the land because of his brothers' treachery that involved a deceptive goat-skin designed to trick their father (Gen. 37). // Yaaqov is the beloved son of Rebekah, and he is forced to leave the land because of his treachery that involved a deceptive goat-skin designed to trick his father (Gen. 27).

Binyamin is finally made to go into exile where he and his brothers are tested with a "stolen" cup of divination hidden in the camel bags. // Yaakov goes into exile and eventually is tested with "stolen" idol-gods for divination that are hidden in camel bags.

Binyamin is restored to his father once his older brother Yehudah offers himself as a substitute. // Yaaqov is restored to his father after he offers his own life in the place of his wives and children (Gen. 32).

Parallels With Isaac

Isaac was a miraculous son born to an infertile Sarah. // Yoseph and Binyamin were miraculous sons born to an infertile Rachel.

Isaac was the beloved and favored secondborn son of Abraham. // Yoseph and Binyamin were the beloved and favored sons of the beloved and favored Rachel who was the secondborn herself.

Abraham and Sarah wronged and abused Hagar and Ishmael in their efforts to produce a son. // Yaaqov wronged Leah because of his love for Rachel.

God tested Abraham by demanding that he give up the life of the beloved son, often called "the boy" (הנער) as an offering. // Yaakov is double-tested as he loses the life of Yoseph (which involved a substitute animal death), and then he is forced to surrender the life of Binyamin (also called "the boy" הנער).

At the last moment, God provides a substitute for Isaac in the form of a ram offered in the place of the beloved son. // At the last moment, Yehudah offers himself as a substitute in the place of the beloved son.

Abraham's surrender of Isaac opens up God's covenant blessing for all the nations. // Yehudah's surrender of his own life opens up reconciliation, abundant food, security, and life for Yaaqov's family.

Conclusion

These portraits of Binyamin, Yehudah, and Yoseph bring the themes of Genesis 1-3 to their culmination. The promise of the seed of the woman in Genesis 3:15, who is at odds with the snake and those who give in to its lies, has led to a clash of siblings and the death or exile of a child in every generation. In each case, it is only

after a chosen son gives up their life and is replaced by a sacrificial substitute that the story of God's purposes moves forward.

This is the precisely the same theme we see surfacing in the Prophets of the Hebrew Bible. God plans to raise up a suffering servant who is a royal-prophet-priest, who will stand up to rebellious Israel, only to be rejected and killed as a substitute, leading to victory and rule over Israel and the nations. This is what Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the scroll of the twelve are all about!

Reflection Question

Reflect on the ways that Yoseph and Yehudah each represent different aspects of the same theme: the chosen son who must offer himself as a substitute for others.

Session 17: Reconciliation of the Brothers

Key Takeaways

- Returning to the flood melody, Yoseph's offer of refuge in Egypt echoes the safety of the ark during the de-creation of the cosmos.
- The name Goshen is a wordplay on the Hebrew word for "garden" (gan), representing an abundance of God's provision in the midst of famine.
- God rescuing Yaaqov's family from destruction is about a rebirth for all humanity.
- Yehudah's self-sacrifice reverses the pattern of sibling rivalry and conflict that runs through the entire book of Genesis.

Section 3: Genesis 45:1-25a

A – Genesis 45:1-3

Yoseph Reveals Himself to His Brothers

- **45:2** "and he gave his voice in **weeping (בכי)** "
- **45:2** "**and Egypt heard, and it was heard in the house of Pharaoh** "
- **45:3** "and he said, 'I am Yoseph, your brother!'"
- **45:3** "and they could not answer him, because **they were stunned (בהל)** "

B – Genesis 45:4-13

45:4-7

- **45:4** "I am Yoseph your brother!"
- **45:7** "**Elohim sent me** here before you, to keep alive a remnant for you"
- **45:6** "**there are still five more years of the famine** "

45:8

- "Pharaoh has placed me as a father ... and a master ... and a ruler over all the land"

45:9-13

- **45:9** "**Elohim has placed me** as a master for all of Egypt"

- 45:11 “there are still five more years of the famine”

A' – 45:14-25a

Yoseph and the Brothers Embrace

- 45:14-15 “and he wept (בכה), and he kissed his brothers, and wept (בכה) over them”
- 45:16 “And the voice was heard in the house of Pharaoh”
- 45:24 “And he sent his brothers ... and said to them, ‘Don’t disturb each other (רגז) on the road!’”

Genesis 45:1-25. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

In this section, Yoseph reveals himself to his brothers while also revealing his understanding of God’s plan in all of these terrible events. Yoseph becomes an interpreter not just of dreams, but of his own life story. He sees the providence of God turning the brothers’ evil into good.

Notice the symmetrical design of this section.

- In the outer parts (Gen. 45:1-3 and 45:14-25a), Yoseph’s weeping is highlighted, as well as the loud sound of crying that can be heard all throughout the royal palace. These outer sections also show the brothers in a state of shock (נבהל, Gen. 45:3) and agitation (רגז, Gen. 45:24). These two words are often used as synonyms for people in a state of shock, fear, and anger when they experience traumatic events (see Exod. 15:14; Joel 2:1).
- In the center part (Gen. 45:4-13), Yoseph twice warns his brothers about the five remaining years of famine (these warnings form a literary frame around verse 8), and he tells them how Elohim turned the brother’s treachery into a rescue by sending him to Egypt to become ruler of all.

Yoseph Reveals Himself to His Brothers

¹ And Yoseph was not able to restrain himself for all those standing by him,
and he called out,
“Every man, go out from me!”
And no man stood with him when Yoseph made himself known to his brothers .

² And he gave his voice in weeping,
and Egypt heard,
and the house of Phar’oh heard,

³ and Yoseph said to his brothers ,
“I am Yoseph!
Is my father alive?!”
And his brothers were not able to answer him,

because they were stunned before him.

Genesis 45:1-3. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Yoseph's Speech of Self-Revealing

⁴ And Yoseph said to his brothers,
"Draw near to me, please!"

And they drew near.

And he said,

"I am Yoseph, **your brother** !

The one you sold to Egypt!

A ⁵ And now, don't let your heart be grieved with pain,
and don't let there be hot anger in your eyes,
because you sold me here,
because **Elohim sent me before you all for the preservation of life !**

B ⁶ Because these **two years of famine** have been in the midst of the land,
and there are **yet five years** in which there is no plowing or harvest,

⁷ and **Elohim sent me before you all**

A' to set up for you all **a remnant** in the land,
and **to preserve you all alive** ,
as **a great escaped-remnant**.

⁸ So now, **you all did not send me here, but Elohim** ,
and **he has set me up as a father to Phar'oh** ,
and **as a master for all his house** ,
and **as one who rules over all the land of Egypt** .

⁹ **Hurry**, and **go up** to **my father** ,
and say to him,

'Thus says Yoseph **your son** ,

"Elohim has set me up as master of all Egypt .

Come down to me.

Don't just stand there!

a ¹⁰ **And you will dwell in the land of Goshen** ,

b and you will be close to me,

c you and your sons and the sons of your sons,

and your flocks and your cattle and everything that is yours.

a' ¹¹ **And I will support you there** ,

b' because there are **five more years of famine** ,

c' so that you are not dispossessed, you and your house and everything that is yours."

¹² And look, your **eyes** are **seeing** ,

and the **eyes** of **my brother Binyamin**,
 that it is my **mouth** that is **speaking** to you.
 13 So you must tell **my father** of all my honor in Egypt,
 and of everything that you've **seen**,
 and **you must hurry** and **bring down my father** to here."

Genesis 45:4-13. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Yoseph as an Image of Elohim and a New Noah

When Yoseph reveals himself to his brothers, his speech is packed with verbal links back to the portraits of the image of God from Genesis 1:26-28 and to the story of Noah in Genesis 6-8.

Yoseph as the Image of Elohim

Humanity in Genesis 1-2	Yoseph in Genesis 45
Elohim created human as a divine image to rule (רדה, Gen. 1:26) over the land and its animals, as a mirror of the heavenly lights who were appointed to rule (משל, Gen. 1:14-16) over the day and night.	Elohim appointed Yoseph as a father and master of Egypt who will rule (משל, Gen. 45:8) over all the land of Egypt, and so the brothers are to tell their father to "go down" to Yoseph (רדה, ירד, Gen. 45:9) and to tell him of all the "honor/glory" (כבוד, Gen. 45:13).
Yahweh Elohim elevated human from the dust of the land outside of Eden and "gave him rest" (נוח, Gen. 2:15) in the garden to offer access to unending life (חי לעולם, Gen. 2:9; 3:22).	Elohim has elevated Yoseph from sale to slavery (Gen. 45:4) outside their homeland, up to a place of rule, in order to preserve life (למחיה, Gen. 45:5).
<i>Humanity in the Beginning and Joseph at the End. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Recall that Yoseph's dreams were about his future rule over his family and over "the sun, moon, and stars" (the only other time that phrase occurs in Genesis aside from Gen. 1:14-16). And so Yoseph is depicted as "ruling" (משל) with the same verb used of the rule of the heavenly lights in Genesis 1!

After the suffering of Yahweh's chosen one, they are elevated to a place of honor and rule over the nations, in order to provide life for all!

Yoseph as a New Noah

Noah in Genesis 6-9	Yoseph in Genesis 45
Elohim warns Noah of the coming flood: "After seven more days (לִימִים עוֹד שְׁבַע) I will bring rain upon the land" (Gen. 7:4)	"For these two years a famine (i.e., not enough water) has been in the land, and there are still five more years (וְעוֹד חֲמֵשׁ שָׁנִים) of no harvesting or reaping" (Gen. 45:6)
"You will take animals ... to keep alive (לְחַיֹּת) seed on the land on the face of the land ... (Gen 7:3)" + "Elohim wiped away every living thing from the face of the land, but Noah and those with him were a remnant (שְׂאֵר) in the ark" (Gen. 7:23)	"Elohim sent me before you, to set up for you a remnant (שְׂאֵרִית) in the land, and to keep alive (לְחַיֹּת) a great escaped-remnant (פְּלִיטָה)" (Gen. 45:7)
Elohim instructs Noah about how to provide food for himself, his family ("you, your sons, your wife, and your sons wives ... and all the animals"), and the animals during the flood (Gen. 6:21)	Yoseph instructs his brothers to get their father, so that he can provide them with food ("for you, your sons, and your sons' sons, and your flocks and your cattle, and I will sustain you there") during the famine (Gen. 45:10)
<i>The Flood Narrative in the Joseph Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Yoseph's speech to his brothers shows how he is being portrayed as a new Noah, a righteous one that Elohim has chosen for preserving a remnant in the land, so that a new creation (human and animal!) can be birthed in a time of cosmic re-creation (the famine // the flood).

Notice the focus on the preservation of both human and animal life in both stories.

Also notice that this whole scene takes place in the Pharaoh's "house" (הַבַּיִת), which is the word "ark" spelled backward (תֵּבָה)!

Yoseph Sends His Brother Back to Yaaqov

¹⁴ And he fell upon the neck of **Binyamin his brother** and he wept, and **Binyamin** **wept** upon his neck.

¹⁵ And he kissed all of **his brothers**, and he **wept** over them, and afterward **his brothers** spoke with him.

¹⁶ And the voice was heard in the house of Phar'oh, saying, "The **brothers of Yoseph** have come!" And it was **good in the eyes** of Phar'oh,

and **in the eyes** of his servants,

¹⁷ and Phar'oh said to Yoseph,

"Say to **your brothers**,

Do this:

a Load your beasts,

and leave, go to the land of Cana'an,

b ¹⁸ and **take** **your father** and your households,

and **come** to me,

c and **I will give** you **the good** of the land of Egypt,

and eat the fat of the land!

¹⁹ And you are being commanded.

Do this:

a' **Take** for yourselves from the land of Egypt **carts**,

for your children and for your wives,

b' and you will carry **your father**,

and you will **come**.

c' ²⁰ And **your eyes**, don't let them pity your belongings,

because **the good** of all the land of Egypt, it is for you!"

²¹ And the sons of Yisra'el did so.

And Yoseph **gave** them **carts** according to the mouth of Phar'oh,

and he **gave** them fodder **for the road**.

²² And to all of them he **gave** to each a change of clothes,

and to **Binyamin** he **gave** three hundred silver and five changes of clothes,

²³ and to **his father** he sent like this:

Ten donkeys carrying from **the good** of the land of Egypt,

and ten female donkeys carrying grain,

and bread and provisions for his father **for the road**.

²⁴ And he sent **his brothers** and they went,

and he said to them,

"Don't let yourselves get angry **on the road**."

^{25a} And so they went up out of Egypt.

Genesis 45:14-25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Brothers Dwelling Together in Unity

Yoseph's reconciliation with his brothers is portrayed with language that deliberately recalls the reconciliation of his father Yaaqov with his estranged brother Esau.

Yoseph and His Brothers: Genesis 45:14-15

And **he fell upon the neck** of Binyamin his brother
and he wept ,
and Binyamin **wept upon his neck** ,
and he **kissed** all of his brothers,
and he wept over them.

Yaaqov and Esau: Genesis 33:3-4

... and he came near to his brother.
Then Esau ran to meet him,
and he embraced him,
and **he fell on his neck** and **kissed** him,
and they wept .

Jacob and Esau Reflected in Joseph and His Brothers. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

After Yaaqov's 20-year exile, caused by his deception of his father and brother, the brothers finally meet. Yaaqov discovers mercy, and there is a powerful embrace that brings the two brothers together.

Similarly, after Yoseph's 13-year exile, caused by his brothers' jealousy and after the deception of their father, the brothers finally meet and Yoseph shows them mercy.

However, Yoseph's reconciliation with his brothers isn't just a parallel with the Yaaqov and Esau story. Both stories of reconciled siblings bring to a climax the "conflict of seeds" and "sibling rivalry" themes in the book of Genesis.

- Round 1: Humanity vs. the snake
- Round 2: Abel vs. Cain
- Round 3: Shem and Japheth vs. Ham
- Round 4: Abraham vs. Lot
- Round 5: Isaac vs. Ishmael
- Round 6: Yaaqov vs. Esau
- Round 7: Yoseph vs. his brothers

"Each of these sibling rivalries or 'seed conflicts' develops the paradigmatic conflict first announced in Genesis 3:15 and then portrayed in Cain's murder of Abel. While only Genesis 4 ends in murder, the threat of fratricide against the covenant seed looms throughout each of these conflicts. The seed conflict between Joseph and his brothers is, thus, climactic in Genesis, as the brothers' intense animosity for Joseph evokes ... Genesis 4. ... The dramatic twist in the Joseph story is that Joseph's wise plan to 'test' his brothers (42:15-16), coupled with Judah's repentance (44:18-34), lead to a reversal of the Cain and Abel story. ... The unresolved brotherly strife of previous generations is finally overcome by Yoseph's ruse in chapters 42-45, and by his refusal to exact vengeance on his brothers after Jacob's death (50:15-21). In this way, the Joseph story reverses one of the primary literary motifs in Genesis. Sibling conflict has racked the covenant family and endangered the seed since Adam and Eve's first children. Joseph undoes the cycle of violence, but only by exercising forgiveness after his own humiliation and exaltation. In this way, Joseph is an anti-Cain. He is truly his brothers' keeper."

Emadi, Samuel (2018). "Covenant Typology, and the Story of Joseph". Tyndale Bulletin. 100-101.

The Ark-Eden of Egypt

Recall how the above paragraph of Yoseph's speech (Gen. 45:4-13) portrayed him as a new Noah-like remnant who was chosen out of the generation of the famine to preserve life for a remnant that would survive through the de-creation. Here in this paragraph, that analogy continues.

Pharaoh begins commanding Yoseph and the brothers to "go" (בוא) back to their land and to "take" (לקח) their father and animals and "come into" (בוא אל) Egypt, where they can have food (אכל) and enjoy the good of the land. All of this language is a hyperlink back to God's speech to Noah before the flood.

Pharaoh to Yoseph and the Brothers: Genesis 45

17 ... "Say to your brothers,
'Do this:
Load your **animals**,
and leave, **go to** (בוא אל) the land of
Canaan,
18 and **take** (לקח) your father and your
households,
and **come to** (בוא אל) me,
and I will give you the good of the
land of Egypt,
and **eat** (אכל) the fat of the land!
19 And you are being **commanded**
(צוה).
Do this:
Take (לקח) carts from the land of
Egypt,
for your children and for your wives,
and you will carry your father,
and you will **come** (בוא).
20 And don't let your eyes pity your
belongings,
because the good of all the land of
Egypt,
it is for you!"
21 And the sons of Yisrael **did so**
(עשה בן).

God to Noah: Genesis 6-7

Gen. 6:20 "Of the birds after their kind, and of the animals
after their kind, of every creeping thing of the ground after its
kind, two of every kind will **come to** (בוא אל) you to keep
them alive."

Gen. 7:1 Then the Lord said to Noah, "**Enter** (אל ... בוא) the
ark, you and all your household, for you alone I have seen to
be righteous before me in this time."

Gen. 6:21-22 "As for you, **take** (לקח) for yourself some of all
food that can be eaten (אכל), and gather it to yourself; and it
shall be for **food** (אכלה) for you and for them."

Gen. 7:2 "You will **take** (לקח) with you of every clean **animal**
by sevens, a male and his female; and of the **animals** that
are not clean two, a male and his female."

Gen. 6:22 **And so Noah did** (עשה); according to all that God
had **commanded** (צוה) him, **so he did** (כן עשה).

Gen. 7:5 Noah **did** (עשה) according to all that the Lord had
commanded (צוה) him.

Pharaoh Speaking to Joseph Like God Speaking to Noah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject
Classroom: Joseph (2022).

These verbal hyperlinks set up a network of analogies between the story of Noah and the flood and the story of Yoseph and the famine.

- Pharaoh // Elohim give commands to Yoseph and his brothers // Noah and his family.

- A de-creation event comes upon the land, taking away life.
- God chooses one righteous leader (Yoseph // Noah) to create a place of refuge (the “good” of Egypt // the ark) where their family can be delivered.
- The chosen ones take many animals into the refuge where they can live. Notice that the word “carts” (עגלות) is literally the Hebrew word “calves” (עגל), referring to a cart drawn by oxen.
- The chosen ones obey the commands.

Reflection Question

What are some of the ways that the biblical authors link the rescue of Yaaqov’s family in Egypt to the rescue of Noah’s family in the ark?



Module 5: Joseph Rescues Egypt and His Family

SESSIONS 18-20

God provides safety and life for Jacob's family while a flood of famine unmakes the land. See Joseph as a new Noah saving the remnant of God's people.

Session 18: Jacob's Journey to Egypt

Key Takeaways

- Averting crisis with the family moving to Egypt, the final third of the Yoseph story highlights the tension of temporary safety outside the land of promise.
- Upon hearing the news that Yoseph is alive, Yaaqov metaphorically dies, coming back to life when he believes the news. This foreshadows a future-looking hope of return to the land and new creation life.
- The list of the 70 nations in Genesis 10 and the 70 descendants of Yaaqov are connected. The fate of the nations is bound up with the fate of the family of Israel.

Yoseph Rescues Egypt and His Family

Genesis 45:25b-47:31			Genesis 48:1-49:28		Genesis 49:29-50:26	
The Remnant of Yaaqov Is Rescued in Egypt			Yaaqov Blesses His Seed		Death in Egypt, Forgiveness, and the Ascent to Canaan	
45:25b-46:30	46:31-47:11	47:12-27	47:28-31	48:1-22	49:1-28	49:29-50:14
Yaaqov and 70 family go down to Egypt	Pharaoh and Yoseph settle Yaaqov's family in Goshen during the 7-year famine	Yoseph keeps family and nations alive during the 7-year famine	Yaaqov lives 10+ years in Egypt, requests burial in Canaan	Yaaqov adopts and blesses Yoseph's 2 sons + Inversion of birth order	Yaaqov blesses or curses 12 sons + Inversion of birth order + Yehudah made ruler	Yaaqov requests burial in Canaan + 70 days of weeping + Yoseph "goes up" to bury Yaaqov in Canaan
						50:15-21
						Yoseph forgives and reconciles with brothers
						50:22-26
						Yoseph requests burial in Canaan + Swears an oath

Genesis 45:25-50:26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Genesis 45:25b- 47:31
45:25b-46:30 • Ya'akov and 70 (שבע) family members go down (יָרַד) to Goshen-Egypt
46:31-47:27 • 46:31-47:11 Yoseph provides food and settles his family in Goshen during the 7-year famine • 47:12-27 Yoseph provides food for all of Egypt during the 7-year famine
47:28-31 • Ya'akov lives 10 + 7 years (שבע) in Egypt • Ya'akov makes Yoseph swear an oath (שבע) that he be buried in Canaan

Genesis 48:1-49:28

- **48:1-22** Ya'akov adopts and blesses Yoseph's two sons
- **49:1-28** Ya'akov blesses or curses his 12 sons

Genesis 49:29- 50:26

49:29-50:14

- **Ya'akov requests his burial in Canaan**
- Ya'akov dies + **70 (שבע)** days of weeping
- Yoseph makes the brothers **go up (עלה)** to Canaan **to bury Ya'akov**

50:15-21

- Yoseph forgives and reconciles with his brothers

50:22-26

- **Yoseph** makes family **swear an oath (שבע)** **that he be buried in Canaan**

Genesis 45:25-50:26. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This final act of the story of Yaaqov's sons is also the final act of the Genesis scroll as a whole. It has been designed with three main parts.

- In part 1 (Gen. 45:25b-47:31), Yaaqov and his family go down to Egypt where they are rescued from the famine and where Yaaqov makes his request to be buried in Canaan.
- In part 2 (Gen. 48:1-49:28), Yaaqov offers blessings and curses for his sons and grandsons, passing on the covenant promise to the next generation.
- In part 3 (Gen. 49:29-50:26), Yaaqov again requests a burial in Canaan and then dies.

Notice the symmetrical design of the various parts of this composition.

- The section opens and closes with a focus on the burials of Yaaqov and Yoseph, both related to a covenant oath of future burial in the land.
- In the center are the blessings for the next generation and beyond.
- The middle unit of the opening and closing parts (Gen. 46:31-47:11 and 50:15-21) both involve Yoseph providing food for his brothers and forgiving them and setting them up well in the land of Egypt.

Yaaqov and His Family Descend to Egypt

Genesis 45:25b-46:30

45:25b-28

The Brothers Come From Egypt to Ya'akov in Canaan

- The brothers “came to the land of Canaan, to Ya'akov their father”
- “Yoseph is still **alive!** ... **I will see him before I die!**”

46:1-27

- **46:1-7** Ya'akov's vision of Yahweh at Be'er-**Sheva'** (שבַּע)
- **46:7-27** List of Ya'akov's **70** (שבע) descendants who went to Egypt

46:28-30

The Brothers and Ya'akov Come to Yoseph in Egypt

- The brothers and Ya'akov come to the land of Goshen to meet Yoseph”
- “**I can die now, because I have seen your face, that you are alive!**”

Genesis 46:31-47:27

46:31-47:11

Yoseph Settles His Brothers and Father in Goshen-Egypt

- **47:11** “and Yoseph gave them **a land-possession (אֲחֻזָּה) in the land of Egypt**”

47:12-26

- Yoseph provides food for all of Egypt by purchasing all the land

47:27

- “And they dwelt **in the land of Egypt and took possession (אָחֲזוּ) of it**”

Genesis 47:28-31

47:28

- Ya'akov lived in Egypt for **17 years** (שבע), and lived for a total of 140 + **7 years** (שבע)

47:29-30a

- Ya'akov requests to be buried back in Canaan with his fathers

47:30b-31

- Ya'akov makes Yoseph **swear an oath (שבוע)** to bury him in Canaan

Genesis 45:25-47:31. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

In this first part of act 3, Yoseph's brothers arrive back in Canaan and report to Yaaqov that Yoseph is still alive. The entire part has been given a three-part symmetrical design.

- Unit 1 (Gen. 45:25b-46:30): Yoseph's brothers return to Yaaqov in Canaan and report that Yoseph is alive; Yaaqov wants to go down and see him before his own death.
- Unit 2 (Gen. 46:31-47:27): While in Egypt, the seven-year famine rages on, but Yoseph provides food for all of Egypt and for his own family in Goshen-Egypt.
- Unit 3 (Gen. 47:28-31): Now at the end of his life, Yaaqov requests that after he dies Yoseph bury him up in Canaan.

Yaaqov's Journey Down to Egypt

45:25b **And they came to the land of Canaan**, to **Ya'akov their father**,

²⁶ and they told him, saying,

"Yoseph is still alive!

And indeed, he is the ruler of all the land of Egypt!"

And **his heart stopped**, because he did not believe them.

²⁷ And they spoke to him all the words of Yoseph that he spoke to them,

and he saw **the carts which Yoseph had sent**,

and their father Ya'akov's breath-energy **came back to life**,

²⁸ and Yisra'el said,

"It more than enough that **Yoseph my son is alive**.

I will go and I will see him before **I die**."

46:1 And he set out, **Yisra'el and all that belonged to him**,

and he came to **Be'er-Sheva' (= Well of Seven)**,

and he sacrificed sacrifices to **the Elohim of his father Yitskhaq**.

² And Elohim said to Yisra'el in visions of the night,
and he said,

"Ya'akov, Ya'akov!"

And he said,

"Look, it's me!"

³ And he said,

"I am El, **the Elohim of your father**."

Don't be afraid to **go down to Egypt** ,
because I will set you up as a great nation there.

⁴ I will **go down with you to Egypt** ,
and I will make you go back up, indeed, a going up,
and Yoseph will set his hand on your eyes."

⁵ And Ya'akov got up from **Be'er-Sheva'** ,
and the sons of Yisra'el picked up Ya'akov their father,
and their children and their wives,
on **the carts that Phar'oh had sent** to carry him;
⁶ and they took their herds and all their possessions,
which they possessed in the land of Cana'an,
and they went to Egypt , Ya'akov and all of his seed with him:
⁷ his sons and the sons of his sons with him,
his daughters and the daughters of his sons,
and all his seed,
he brought with him to Egypt .

vv. 8-27: List of **70** descendants of Ya'akov "**who went to Egypt** "

²⁸ Now, he sent Yehudah before him to Yoseph,
to instruct before him toward Goshen,
and they came to the land of Goshen .
²⁹ And Yoseph bound up his chariot,
and he went up to meet **Yisra'el his father** in Goshen,
and he saw him,
and he fell upon his neck,
and he wept upon his neck even more.
³⁰ And Yisra'el said to Yoseph,
"**I can die** this time, after I have seen your face,
because **you are still alive** ."

Genesis 45:25-46:30. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yaaqov's Death and Revival

This unit begins with a short paragraph about Yaaqov's response to the report that Yoseph, his beloved son, is still alive. Notice the interplay of "life" and "death" language and focus on Yaaqov's "death" and "revival" as he takes in this news.

a ²⁵ And they came to the land of Cana'an, to **Ya'akov** their father,
²⁶ and they told him, saying,

A b “Yoseph is still alive!
 And indeed, he is the ruler of all the land of Egypt!”
a' And **his heart stopped**, because he did not believe them.

B 27 And they spoke to him all the words of Yoseph that he spoke to them,
 and he saw the carts which Yoseph had sent,
 and their father Ya'akov's breath-energy **came back to life**.

A' a 28 And **Yisrael** said,
 b “It more than enough that **Yoseph my son is alive**.
 a' I will go and **I will see him** before **I die**.”

Genesis 45:25-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Notice how in this section, Yaakov undergoes a death and resurrection as he processes the news that his son Yoseph, presumed to be dead, is actually alive.

A - v. 26: “Yoseph is alive!” > “his heart stopped”

B - v. 27: Yaaqov sees and comes “back to life”

A' - v. 28: “Yoseph is alive!” > “I will see him before I die”

This short sequence is an important first statement of a key theme in this section about death and the hope for future life. Here Yaaqov metaphorically dies and is revived from that death. This anticipates the future moment when Yaaqov is going to literally die at the conclusion of this act (in Gen. 50). Yaaqov's “revival” is also a future anticipation of when he will be made to “go up” to be buried in Canaan in the cave of Makpelah, an Eden spot that is familiar to the reader from Genesis 23. The imagery of Yaaqov's body “going up” to an Eden burial is an important icon of the hope of resurrection in Genesis that will be drawn upon and developed by the later prophets (Ezek. 37 is a great example).

These images of Yaaqov's (a.k.a. Yisrael's) death and resurrection act as surrounding frames around the whole of this final act of the Genesis scroll.

Genesis 45:25b-30

- **45:26** Ya'akov metaphorically **"dies"** upon hearing that Yoseph is alive
- Ya'akov's spirit **"comes to life"** when he sees evidence that Yoseph is alive
- **45:28** "It is enough Yoseph my son is still alive; I will go and see him before **I die**"

Genesis 46:1-49:33

- Ya'akov and 70 descendants descend into Egyptian exile

Genesis Gen 50:1-26

- **49:33** Ya'akov actually **dies** at the end of his years
- **50** Yoseph leads a procession to **"make the bones of Ya'akov go up"** to be buried in the cave of Makpelah in Canaan

Genesis 45:25-50:26. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Elohim informs Yaaqov that he will be descending to his death in Egypt, but that the divine presence will be with him and will bring up him up out of Egypt as well (Gen. 46:4). This revelation at Beersheba creates an important analogy between Yaaqov and his son that continues throughout the rest of the Genesis scroll.

- Yoseph goes down into a pit (בור) and to Egypt // "going down" (ירד) into the grave.
- Yahweh was with Yoseph in Egypt (Gen. 39:2, 21).
- Yoseph was elevated out of the pit (בור) and up over Egypt // "alive from the dead" (Gen. 45:28).
- Yaaqov will go down (ירד) to Egypt and will die there.
- Yahweh will be with Yaaqov in Egypt (Gen. 46:4).
- Yahweh will make Yaaqov "go up" (עלה) from Egypt.

Yaaqov as a New Abraham and Isaac

In Genesis 46:1-5, Yaaqov's vision in Beersheba is set on analogy with similar visions and altars built in this very spot by Isaac and Abraham.

Yaaqov at Beersheba	Isaac at Beersheba	Abraham at Beersheba
Gen. 46:1-4 So Yisrael set out with all that he had, and came to Beersheba , and offered sacrifices (ויזבח זבחים) to the God of his father Isaac . God spoke to Israel in visions of the night and said, "Yaaqov, Yaaqov." And he said, "Here I am." He said, " I am God, the God of your father ; do not be afraid to go down to Egypt, for I will make you a great nation there. " I will go down with you to Egypt, and I will also surely bring you up again; and Yoseph will close your eyes."	Gen. 26:23-25 Then [Isaac] went up from there to Beersheba . The Lord appeared to him the same night and said, " I am the God of your father Abraham ; Do not fear , for I am with you . I will bless you, and multiply your seed , For the sake of my servant Abraham." And he built an altar (מזבח) there ...	Gen. 22:11, 17-19 "Abraham, Abraham." And he said, "Here I am!" ... indeed I will greatly bless you, and I will greatly multiply your seed because you have obeyed my voice." So Abraham went ... to Beersheba; and Abraham lived at Beersheba .
<i>Jacob, Isaac, and Abraham at Beersheba. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>		

Beersheba was where Abraham settled after his great act of obedience in Genesis 22, and Beersheba was where Isaac settled after God explicitly told him not to go to Egypt (Gen. 26:2).

The divine summons "Yaaqov, Yaaqov!" recalls the same summons given to Abraham in the moment his act of greatest obedience (Gen. 22:11). In Genesis 22, Abraham has just given away his beloved son, while in Genesis 46, Yaaqov is about to receive back his beloved son.

The Goshen-Garden in Egypt

When Yoseph invites his father and family to come down to Egypt, he has prepared a special place for them called "Goshen" (Gen. 45:10; 46:28-29, 34; 47:1-4, 6, 27).

Geographically, Goshen was a rural region outside of the main urban areas of Egypt's cities. The importance of Goshen's location on the outskirts of Egypt will play an important role in Genesis 47.

In these passages, Goshen is described as:

- A place where Yaakqov and his family "can be near" Yoseph and have their needs provided for (Gen. 45:10-11).
- A place where Yoseph's brothers can shepherd their flocks in peace (Gen. 47:1-4).

- A place where one can enjoy the “good of the land” (Gen. 47:6).
- A place where Yaaqov’s family can experience Elohim’s blessing (Gen. 47:27).

Isn’t it interesting that the first and last letters of the Hebrew word “Goshen” spell the Hebrew word for “garden”?

English: Garden

Hebrew: **g** a **n** / גן

English: “Goshen”

Hebrew: **g** oshe **n** / גושן

“Goshen” is Israel's Eden-ark refuge during the time of famine, and they will remain there until the years of famine are over so they can be delivered from their exile and restored to the promised land.

Yehudah the Leader of the Tribes

In Genesis 46:28, the narrator highlights Yehudah’s role in leading the seed of Yaaqov down into Egypt, specifically “instructing them to Goshen.” This prominent role for Yehudah among the brothers has been strategically placed here to match the other significant moments in Genesis 37-50 that highlight Yehudah’s role among his brothers.

Genesis 37:2-41:57			Genesis 42:1-45:25a			Genesis 45:25b-50:26		
37:2-36 Yoseph and Yaaqov descend to Egypt/pit/grave because of brothers' deception	38:1-30 Yehudah's 2 sons die, 2 sons born + Royal "staff"	39:1-41:57 Yoseph elevated as ruler of Egypt + Plan to rescue from 7 years of famine + Divide land into fifths	42:1-38 Brothers descend to Egypt + Tested by Yoseph	43:1-44:34 Brothers tested by Yoseph + Binyamin taken + Yehudah offers himself as a sacrifice	45:1-25a Yoseph sends brothers back to Yaaqov	45:25b-47:31 Yoseph ruler of Egypt enacts plan to rescue from 7 years of famine + Divide land into fifths	48:1-49:28 Yaaqov adopts 2 sons + Blesses many + Yehudah's royal "staff"	49:29-50:26 Brothers forgiven + Yaaqov ascends from grave to Canaan + Yoseph hopes to ascend

Genesis 37:2-50:26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yehudah is mentioned in the first two literary units of Genesis 37-41, and these two roles of Yehudah are symmetrically matched by his position and role in Genesis 45-50.

- In Genesis 37, Yehudah betrays Yoseph, which leads Yoseph down to Egypt. // In Genesis 46, Yehudah leads his entire family down to Yoseph in Egypt.
- In Genesis 38, Yehudah’s staff and future seed are rescued from death. // In Genesis 49, Yehudah is elevated to the position of royal firstborn in the family, and his future seed will rule the nations.
- In Genesis 43-44, the center of the entire act is Yehudah’s self-giving offer of his own life in place of the beloved Binyamin.

Altogether, these stories about Yehudah paint a powerful portrait of the future messianic ruler from the line of Yehudah. After Yehudah’s two failures, he is given a double role of honor and royal exaltation, not just for himself, but as a pointer to his future seed who will rule over the nations. But that future royal rule is qualified by the story of Yehudah’s greatest act, which was to lay down his life for his brother, which opened up the pathway to life and blessing for others.

The 70 From Yaaqov and From Noah

⁸ And these are the names of the sons of Yisra'el

who went to Egypt,

Ya'akov and his sons:

Reuven was the firstborn of Ya'akov.

⁹ And the sons of Reuven:

Khanokh and Paul' and Khetzron and Karmi.

¹⁰ And the sons of **Shim'on** :

Yemu'el and Yamin and Ohad and Yakhin and Tzokhar and Sha'ul son of a Canaanite woman.

¹¹ And the sons of **Levi** :

Gershon, Qohath, and Merry.

¹² And the sons of **Yehudah** :

'Er and 'Onan and Shelah and Peretz and Zerakh.

And 'Er and 'Onan died in the land of Canaan,

and the sons of Peretz were Khetzron and Khamul.

¹³ And the sons of **Yissakhar** :

Tola' and Puwwah and Yov and Shimron.

¹⁴ And the sons of **Zevulun** :

Sered and Elon and Yakhle'el.

¹⁵ **These are the sons of Le'ah**, whom she birthed for Ya'akov in the land of Paddan-Aram, and also **Dinah** his daughter.

All the lives of his sons and daughters were thirty-three .

¹⁶ And the sons of **Gad** :

Tziphyon and Khaggi and Shuni and Etzbon, Eri and Arodi and Ar'eli.

¹⁷ And the sons of **Asher** :

Yimnah and Yishwah and Yishwi and Beriyah, and Serakh their sister.

And the sons of Beriyah were Kheber and Malki'el.

¹⁸ **These are the sons of Zilpah**, whom Lavan gave to Le'ah his daughter, and she birthed these for Ya'akov, **sixteen lives** .

¹⁹ **The sons of Rakhel**, wife of Ya'akov:

Yoseph and **Binyamin** .

²⁰ And there were born for Yoseph in the land of Egypt

the ones whom Asenath daughter of Potiphera priest of 'On birthed for him,

Manasseh and Ephraim.

²¹ And the sons of Binyamin:

Bela' and Bekor and Eshbal, Gera and Na'aman, Ekhi and Ro'sh, Muppim and Khuppim and Ard.

²² **These are the sons of Rakhel** whom she birthed for Ya'akov: every life, **fourteen** .

23 And the sons of **Dan** : Khushim.

24 And the sons of **Naphtali** :

Yakhtze'el and Guniy and Yetzer and Shillem.

25 These are **the sons of Bilhah** whom Lavan gave to Rakhel his daughter, and she bore these for Ya'akov: every life, **seven** .

26 And every life-being **that went to Ya'akov in Egypt** , those who came out from his loins, except for the wives of Ya'akov, every life-being: **sixty and six** .

27 And the sons of Yoseph who were born for him in Egypt: two life-beings. Every life-being for **the house of Ya'akov that went to Egypt** : **seventy** .

Genesis 46:8-27. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

This tribal list of 70 descendants from Yaaqov is designed with three parts: an introduction and conclusion that frame a four-part list of Yaaqov's sons from each of his four wives.

Notice the wives are listed according to number of sons, not by the order in which they were married to Yaaqov (see [Gen. 29-30](#) for details).

The list is full of challenging chronological details that don't seem to match the narrative context.

- Yehudah is said to have two grandsons by now ([Gen. 46:12](#)).
- Binyamin is said to have ten sons, but he is portrayed as a boy in the preceding narrative ([Gen. 46:21](#), compared with Gen. 42-44).

Just as in Genesis 1 and 10, the number seven is a key organizing number in this genealogy.

"It is clear that seven (and multiples thereof) is prominent in this genealogy, whose total number of entries is 70. Rachel has fourteen descendants, and Bilhah has seven. Together they have twenty-one. Together Leah and Zilpah have forty-nine descendants. The seventh son of Jacob listed in this genealogy is Gad. Gen. 29-30 (see [30:11](#)) is the only other Jacobite genealogy in which Gad is placed in the seventh position. Interestingly, the numerical value of the seventh-placed Gad is seven (g = 3; d = 4)."

Hamilton, Victor P. (1995). [The Book of Genesis, Chapters 18-50](#). Eerdmans. 598-599.

These challenges raise the question of why the narrator would want to include a genealogical list that introduced such challenges into the narrative. The answer seems to be in the fact that when the list's numbers are summarized, they lead to the number 70. This number allowed the genealogy to play a symbolic and structural role in the story.

This long list of Yaaqov's 70 descendants who go down into Egypt is matched by the list of 70 nations that come from Noah's three sons after getting off of the ark (Gen. 10). The parallel is purposeful and loaded with significance.

Noah's Descendants in Genesis 9:18-10:32	Yaaqov's Descendants in Genesis 46
A few go into the ark, but then come out and become 70 nations	70 go down into Goshen-Egypt, and are fruitful and multiply and become a great nation
Gen. 9:18-19, 10:1 The 70 nations emerge from the three sons who “come out of the ark” after the flood	Gen. 46:26 The 70 descendants who “come out of the loins of Yaaqov” and go down to Egypt during the famine
The 70 nations come from the “remnant” that was preserved through the flood	The 70 descendants are the “remnant” that will be preserved through the famine
The 70 nations are those who will experience the blessing given to the family of Abraham	The 70 descendants are the source of the divine blessing given to Abraham for the nations
<i>Noah's and Jacob's Descendants. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

“The list of names in these verses appears to have been selected to total 'seventy' ([46:27](#)). It can hardly go without notice that the number of nations in [Genesis 10](#) is also 'seventy.' Just as the 'seventy nations' represent all the descendants of Adam, so now the 'seventy sons' represent all the descendants of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob—the children of Israel. Here in narrative form is a demonstration of the theme in [Deuteronomy 32:8](#) that God apportioned the boundaries of the nations (Gen. 10) according to the number of the children of Israel. Thus the writer has gone to great lengths to portray the new nation of Israel as a new humanity and Abraham as a second Adam. The blessing that is to come through Abraham and his seed is a restoration of the original blessing of Adam, a blessing which was lost in the Fall. The picture of God that emerges from these pages is not merely a God who works with his own chosen people for their good alone, but also a God who works with the nations to bring about his plan of salvation and blessing.”

Sailhamer, John H. (1995). [The Pentateuch as Narrative: A Biblical-Theological Commentary](#). Zondervan Academic. 225.

Reflection Question

What is significant about the connection between the 70 descendants of Yaaqov and the list of the 70 nations in [Genesis 10](#)?

Session 19: From Canaan to Goshen

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov assigns Yehudah with the role of instructing the family, charting his character transformation into a humble leader.
- Yehudah is the fourth son, continuing a pattern of three-plus-one surprise bonuses in Genesis.
- The wilderness is outside the land of promise, but it is also the place where God draws his people close to him.

Yoseph Delivers His Family and Egypt From Ruin

Genesis 46:31-47:11

A – Yoseph Provides for His Family

46:31-34

Yoseph Prepares His Brothers To Meet Pharaoh

- **46:34** “Say you are shepherd of the flock ... **so that you can dwell in the land of Goshen**”

47:1-4

Yoseph Introduces His Brothers to Pharaoh

- **47:4** “We are shepherds of the flock ... let you servants **dwell in the land of Goshen**”

47:5-11

Pharaoh Responds to Yoseph’s Brothers

- **47:6** “Make your brothers ... **dwell in the good of the land ... in the land of Goshen**”
- **47:11** “And Yoseph **made them dwell** ... **in the land of Egypt, in the good of the land,** **and he gave them a possession**”

Genesis 47:12-26

B – Yoseph Provides for Egypt

- **47:12-17** Year one: Yoseph exchanges Egypt’s animals for food

- **47:18-27** Year two: Yoseph exchanges Egypt's people and land for food

Genesis 47:27

A' – Yoseph Provides for His Family

- “And Yisrael **dwelt in the land of Egypt, in the land of Goshen,** **and they took possession of it,** and they were fruitful and they multiplied.”

Genesis 46:31-47:27. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

In this unit, Yoseph acts to rescue his family and all of Egypt from the famine. The symmetrical design of this unit highlights the dual role that Yoseph plays for both his family and for Egypt.

A - Genesis 46:31-47:11: Yoseph makes a successful plan to settle his family in Egypt.

B - Genesis 47:12-26: Yoseph's plan to save Egypt from famine succeeds.

A' - Genesis 47:27: Yoseph's family settles in Egypt and experiences the Eden blessing.

Yoseph's Wise Plan for His Family

46:31 And Yoseph said to **his brothers and to the house of his father**,

“I will go up and I will tell Phar'oh,
and I will say to him,

a ‘**My brothers and the house of my father** who were in **the land of Cana'an** **have come to me.**

32 And the men are **shepherds of the flock**, because they are **men of the herd**,
and their flocks and their cattle and everything which belongs to them, **they have brought.**’

33 And it will come about when Phar'oh calls for you and says,
b ‘**What is your work?**’

34 And you all will say,

b' ‘**Your servants** are **men of the herd**, from our youth until now,
both us and our fathers.’

a' On account of this **you will dwell in the land of Goshen**,
because every **shepherd of the flock** is taboo for the Egyptians.”

47:1 And Yoseph went and told Phar'oh and said,

“**My father and my brothers** and their flocks and their cattle and everything that belongs to them,

a **they have come** from **the land of Cana'an**,
and look, they are **in the land of Goshen.**”

2 And from some of his brothers he took five men,
and he stationed them before Phar'oh,

3 and Phar'oh said to **his brothers**,
b “**What is your work?**”

b' And they said to Phar'oh,
"Your servants are shepherds of the flock, both us and our fathers."

4 And they said to Phar'oh,

"We have come to migrate in the land,

a' because there is no grazing land for the flocks of your servants,
because the famine is heavy in the land of Cana'an .

And now, please let your servants dwell in the land of Goshen ."

5 And Phar'oh said to Yoseph, saying,

"Your father and your brothers have come to you,

6 the land of Egypt is before you .

Have your father and your brothers dwell in the good of the land .

Let them dwell in the land of Goshen ,

and if you know that there are among them men of nobility,
then set them as captains of the flock that belongs to me."

7 And Yoseph brought Ya'akov his father

a and he stood him before Phar'oh,

and Ya'akov blessed Phar'oh ,

b 8 and Phar'oh said to Ya'akov,

"How many are the days of the years of your life ?"

9 And Ya'akov said to Phar'oh,

"The days of the years of my migration are thirty and one hundred,

b few and bad have been the days of the years of my life ,
and they have not reached the days of the years of the lives of my fathers
in the days of their migrations."

a' 10 And Ya'akov blessed Phar'oh ,

and he went out from before Phar'oh.

11 And Yoseph made his father and his brothers dwell ,
and he gave them a land-possession in the land of Egypt ,
in the good of the land , in the land of Ra'amses,
just as Phar'oh had commanded.

Genesis 46:31-47:11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

In Genesis 46:31-47:4, Yoseph presents his brothers to Pharaoh, but only after outlining a long and clever plan to make sure that Pharaoh invites his family to settle in Goshen, on the outer edge of Egypt.

Yoseph offers wise counsel to his brothers for how to speak in the throne room of Pharaoh, so they both honor the king but also ensure their settlement in Goshen. Yoseph advises them to tell Pharaoh up front that they are shepherds (רעה צאן) and keepers of herds (אנשי מקנה), two ways of describing the same thing.

"[An] apparent difficulty [is caused] by Joseph's mention in [46:34](#) that all shepherds are abhorrent to the Egyptians. The best solution is to regard this clause as the reason to mention the brothers' occupation, rather than as a reason to avoid mentioning it. Since the Egyptians will be wary of semi-nomadic shepherds, there will be less trouble if they are kept away from the capital, even if it means that they must stay in what was a sensitive border region. Since other Egyptians may have viewed them suspiciously, Pharaoh may be more inclined to keep them separate, and not move them from their current location in Goshen ([47:1](#)). ... On this reading, Joseph correctly anticipates Pharaoh's question to the brothers ('What is your occupation?' in [46:33](#) and [47:3](#)), which was essential to the success of his plan. ... Joseph's carefully prepared plan secures his goal of enabling the brothers to live in Goshen, use its rich land, and keep a degree of separateness from the Egyptians. ... The focus in this passage appears to be on yet another of Joseph's wise plans coming to successful fruition."

Wilson, Lindsay (2004). [*Joseph, Wise and Otherwise: The Intersection of Wisdom and Covenant in Genesis 37-50*](#). Paternoster. 189.

The opposition of the Egyptians to "shepherds of the flock" (רעה צאן, [Gen. 46:32](#); [47:3](#), [34](#)) also activates the ancient hostility between Abel the "shepherd of the flock" (רעה צאן, [Gen. 4:2](#)) and Cain the first city builder. In an analogous way, the sons of Shem (the Israelites) and the sons of Ham (the Egyptians) represent the same divide between vocation and between brothers.

Yaaqov's Disappointing Blessing on Pharaoh

In an ironic scene in [Genesis 47:7-10](#), Yaaqov is presented as a sad, unhappy figure reflecting on his pain and loss over the decades while in the presence of the king who just saved his entire family by generously providing for them!

Yaaqov blesses Pharaoh before blessing any of his sons in [Genesis 48-49](#). This is the first appearance of the word "bless" since [Genesis 39:5](#) (God "blessed the house of Potiphar on account of Yoseph"). This story is the first explicit appearance of the word "blessing" that the patriarch offers to the nations, anticipated in God's promise to Abraham in [Genesis 12:3](#).

In [Genesis 47:1-12](#), Pharaoh gives the Israelites a possession in the land of Goshen, Egypt. He sets the "good" (טוב, מיטב) of the land before them and invites them to work "in the land of Ramses" ([Gen. 47:11](#)). As a result, Pharaoh receives a blessing (ברך) from Yaaqov ([Gen. 47:7, 10](#)). This is another example of the paradigm, "Those who bless you will be blessed" ([Gen. 12:2-3](#)). This is all setup for the Pharaoh of [Exodus 1](#), who enslaves the Israelites, kills them, and forces them to build the store city in Ramses ([Exod. 1:11](#)), and that Pharaoh experiences curse instead of blessing.

Reflection Question

How does the wilderness present the ideal of intimacy with and faithfulness to God in the biblical story?

Session 20: Joseph Leads Egypt Through a Famine

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov blesses Pharaoh. This is the first time Abraham's family explicitly blesses the nations as promised by God in Genesis 12:3.
- Yoseph rescues the people and animals of the land from the flood-like famine, once again cast as a new Noah.
- Yoseph's wise administration of the land foreshadows his descendant Joshua and his leadership of Israel.
- Yaaqov's age when entering Egypt helps us calculate the family's time in Canaan as 215 years, precisely half the 430 years of their future Egyptian exile.

Yoseph the Wise Deliverer of Egypt ...

¹² And Yoseph supported his father and his brothers and all the house of his father with **bread** for the mouth of the children.

¹³ And there was no **bread** in all the land, because **the famine** was heavy, very much.

And the land of Egypt became weary, and the land of Canaan, because of **the famine**.

¹⁴ And Yoseph gathered all **the silver** that was found in the land of Egypt and in the land of Canaan, in exchange for the grain that they were buying, and Yoseph brought **the silver** into the house of Pharaoh.

¹⁵ And **the silver** came to an end from the land of Egypt and from the land of Canaan, and all Egypt came to Yoseph saying,

"Give us **bread**,
so **we can live and not die** before you,
because there is no **silver**!"

¹⁶ And Yoseph said,

"Give **your herds**,
and I will give to you in exchange for **your herds**,

if there is no **the silver** .”

17 And they brought **their herds** to Yoseph,
and Yoseph gave them **bread** in exchange for their horses and flock-**herds** and cattle-**herds** and
donkeys,
and he led them out for **bread** in exchange for **their herds** in that year.

18 And **that year** **came to an end (תתם)**,
and they came to him in **the second year**,
and they said to him,
“We cannot hide it from my master,
that **the silver** **has come to an end (תם)**;
and the **herds** of animals belong to my master.
There is nothing remaining before my master except our bodies and our land.
19 **Why should we die** before your eyes, both us and our land?
Purchase us and our land in exchange for bread,
and **we and** our land **will become servants for Phar’oh**,
and give us **seed**, **so we can live and not die**,
and so the land **will not be desolated (תשם)!**”

20 And Yoseph **purchased all the land of Egypt** for Phar’oh,
because Egypt sold, each one his field,
because **the famine** was strong over them.
And **the land** became Phar’oh’s.
21 And **he made the people into servants**,
from one end of the border of Egypt to the other end.
22 Only **the land of the priests he did not purchase**,
because there was from Phar’oh a decree for priests,
that they should eat their decreed amount that Phar’oh gave them.
For this reason they **did not sell their land**.

23 And Yoseph said to the people,
“Look, **I have purchased you all today and your land** for Phar’oh.
Behold! There is **seed** for you all,
so you can **sow your land**.
24 And it will come about that you all will give to Phar’oh **a fifth**,
and **four-parts** will be for you all,
for seed of the field and for your food,
and for whoever is in your houses,

and for food for your children.”

25 And they said,

“You have **saved our lives**!

Let us find favor in the eyes of my master,

and **we will be servants for Phar’oh**.”

26 And Yoseph set this up as a decree until **this day** for **the land of Egypt**:

“**A fifth** is for Phar’oh,

except only **the land** of the priests is not for Phar’oh.”

27 And Yisra’el dwelt in the land of Egypt, in the land of Goshen,

and they took possession of it,

and they were fruit and multiplied, very much.

Genesis 47:12-27. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

This narrative unit departs from the thematic focus on Yoseph’s reconciliation and reunion with the brothers and Yaaqov. In fact, Yoseph’s family doesn’t even appear in this scene. The focus has shifted entirely to Yoseph’s leadership over Egypt. This story is the proper follow-up to Yoseph’s proposal to Pharaoh in Genesis 41, and much of the chapter’s vocabulary links back to that story.

Genesis 41

Genesis 47:11-27

Gen. 41:27, 30, 31, 36 Pharaoh’s dreams are about seven years of famine.

Gen. 41:31 “the famine will be heavy (כבד)”

Gen. 41:56 “the famine will be strong (חזק)”

Gen. 47:15 The first year of famine was finished

Gen. 47:13 “the famine was heavy (כבד)”

Gen. 47:20 “the famine was strong (חזק)”

Gen. 41:34 “let Pharaoh appoint appointees over the land, and take **one-fifth** (חמש) of the land of Egypt”

Gen. 47:24 “you give **one-fifth** (חמישית) to Pharaoh”

Gen. 47:26 “to Pharaoh belongs a **fifth** (חמש)”

Gen. 41:35 “and let them gather all the food of the good years and let them heap up grain”

Gen. 47:14 “and Yoseph gathered up all the silver that was found in the land of Egypt ... for the grain which they were buying”

Repeated Language in Genesis 41 and Genesis 47. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

... From the Chaos of the Flood/Famine

This story portrays the famine on analogy to the flood, and Yoseph takes on the role of Noah in delivering God's salvation ("bread" and "life") to those who come to him. The same strategy was at work in Genesis 40-41, where Yoseph was the Noah-figure sent ahead to prepare food (אכל) in Egypt for his family.

Parallels	Yoseph in Genesis 47	Noah in Genesis 6-9
The flood/famine de-creates the land	Gen. 47:13 "The famine was heavy (כבד) in the land" Gen. 47:20 "The famine was strong (חזק) over Egypt"	Gen. 7:18 "The waters were mighty (גבר) on the land" Gen. 7:20 "The waters were mighty (בגר) and covered the hills"
Noah and his family are the only remnant; the remnant of Egypt survives only because of Yoseph	Gen. 47:18 "There is nothing remaining (שאר) before my lord, except our bodies (גויה) " "	Gen. 7:23 "And there remained (שאר) only Noah and who was with him on the ark" Gen. 6:17 "I am about to bring the flood ... everything on the land will perish (גוע)" Gen. 7:21 "And all flesh perished (גוע) which crawls upon the land ..."
The ark is the vehicle for saving life; Yoseph's plans are the means of saving life	Gen. 47:19 "So we can live (חיה) and not die!" Gen. 47:25 "You have given us life (חיה)!"	Gen. 6:19-20 "From every living thing (חי) from all flesh, two from all you will bring into the ark to keep alive (חיה) ... two from all will come to you, to stay alive (חיה)"
God provides life and food for those on the ark; Yoseph provides bread of life for those in Egypt	Gen. 47:24 "Four-parts will be for you for seed in the field and for your food (אכל)"	Gen. 6:21 "Take for yourself from all the food (מאכל) which will be eaten, and gather it to yourself and it will be for you for food (אכל)"
Noah's salvation results from his divine favor; the Egyptians seek Yoseph's favor for salvation, which is really God's favor on Yoseph	Gen. 47:25 "May we find favor in the eyes of my lord ..."	Gen. 6:8 "And Noah found favor in the eyes of Yahweh"
Comparing Joseph and Noah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).		

This also becomes another fulfillment of Noah's curse upon Ham in Genesis 9:25-27: "slave of slaves (עבד עבדים) you will be to your brothers" // Genesis 47:19 "we are slaves (עבדים) to Pharaoh" and remember, "As Yoseph, as Pharaoh" (במוך כפרעה, Gen. 44:18).

Joshua, the Son of Yoseph, and the Priestly Lands

Notice how Yoseph purchases the land on behalf of Pharaoh and then incorporates it into the kingdom's property so that the entire population become Egypt's servants. However, the narrator highlights how the land that belongs to the priests is not incorporated but rather set apart.

This seemingly random detail is a forward anticipation to the future arrangement of the promised land for the tribes of Israel. In the Joshua scroll, we find Joshua, a son of Ephrayim-Yoseph, providing the land allotments to the tribes of his kinsmen, except for the priests, whose land is never to be sold to anyone.

Numbers 35:2-3, 6 Instructor's Translation

² Command the sons of Israel that they give to the Levites from the inheritance of their possession cities to live in; and **you shall give to the Levites pasture lands around the cities.**

³ The cities shall be theirs to live in; and their pasture lands shall be for their cattle and for their herds and for all their beasts. ...

⁶ The cities which you shall give to the Levites shall be the **six cities** of refuge, which you shall give for the manslayer to flee to; and in addition to them you shall give **forty-two cities.**

Deuteronomy 18:1-5 Instructor's Translation

¹ The Levitical priests, the whole tribe of Levi, shall have no portion or inheritance with Israel; they shall eat the Yahweh's offerings by fire and his portion.

² They shall have no inheritance among their brothers;

Yahweh is their inheritance, as he promised them.

³ Now this shall be the priests' due from the people, from those who offer a sacrifice, either an ox or a sheep, of which they shall give to the priest the shoulder and the two cheeks and the stomach.

⁴ You shall give him the first fruits of your grain, your new wine, and your oil, and the first shearing of your sheep.

⁵ For Yahweh your Elohim has chosen him and his sons from all your tribes, to stand and serve in the name of the LORD forever.

Joshua 13:1-2, 14 Instructor's Translation

¹ Now Joshua was old and advanced in years when the LORD said to him, "You are old and advanced in years, and very much of the land remains to be possessed.

² This is the land that remains: all the regions of the Philistines and all those of the Geshurites;"

¹⁴ Only to the tribe of Levi he did not give an inheritance; the offerings by fire to Yahweh, the God of Israel, are their inheritance, as he spoke to him.

Joshua 13:32-33 Instructor's Translation

³² These are the territories which Moses apportioned for an inheritance in the plains of Moab, beyond the Jordan at Jericho to the east.

³³ But to the tribe of Levi, Moses did not give an inheritance; **Yahweh, the God of Israel, is their inheritance**, as he had promised to them.

Yoseph and Joshua, Images of Messianic Rule

This narrative portrait of Yoseph as exalted ruler of Egypt providing bread for the nations has been intentionally crafted to be part of the messianic mosaic of the Hebrew Bible. Later biblical authors draw upon this narrative image as they portray the future seed from the line of Yehudah who will arise to rule the nations.

Psalm 72 is packed with echoes of the Yoseph story.

Psalm 72:1-17 LEB

¹ O God, give your judgments to the king,
and your righteousness to the king's son.

² May he judge your people with righteousness,
and your poor with justice.

³ Let the mountains yield prosperity for the people,
and the hills in righteousness.

⁴ May he provide justice for the poor of the people,
save the children of the needy,
and crush the oppressor. ...

⁸ And may he rule from sea up to sea,
and from the River to the edges of the land. ...

¹¹ and let all kings bow down to him.
Let all nations serve him.

¹² Indeed he will deliver the needy who is crying for help,
and the afflicted who has no helper.

¹³ He will take pity on the helpless and needy,
and the lives of the needy he will save. ...

¹⁶ May there be an abundance of grain in the land
even on the top of the mountains.
May his crop sway like the trees of Lebanon,
and may those from the city blossom like the grass of the earth.

¹⁷ May his name endure forever.
May his name increase [as long as the sun shines],
and let them be blessed in him.
Let all nations call him blessed.

See also: [Isaiah 11:1-12](#); [Hosea 1-3](#) (especially [3:1-4](#)); [Ezekiel 34](#) and [37](#)

Reflection Question

Yoseph shrewdly governs the people of Egypt, but in the process, all the money, livestock, land, and even the people belong to Pharaoh. How can we discern if the narrative presents this as a blessing or an abuse of power?



Module 6: Jacob's Song of Blessing

SESSIONS 21-25

Jacob looks forward to a future for his sons full of blessings and challenges. Discover how his words foreshadow the future of his descendants.

Session 21: Jacob Blesses Joseph's Sons

Key Takeaways

- As Genesis draws to a close, the narrative revisits the question of how God's blessing of Abraham will carry forward, with an intensification of blessing vocabulary not seen for many chapters.
- Yaaqov blessing his sons in Genesis 48-49 is matched by Moses blessing the tribes of Israel at the end of Deuteronomy, creating a bookend frame around the whole Torah.
- Yaaqov adopts Joseph's Egyptian sons as his own, making Egypt part of the family of promise and pointing to a future hope of the inclusion of the nations in the Eden blessing of Abraham's family.

Yaaqov Commissions Yoseph To Bury Him in Canaan

a 28 And Ya'akov **lived** in the land of Egypt for **seven (שבע)** and ten **years**,
b and the **days** of Ya'akov,
b' the **years** of his **life**,
a' were **seven (שבע)** and forty and one hundred **years**.

29 And the days for Yisra'el **to die** came near.
a And he called for his son, for Yoseph,
and he said to him,
 "If, **please**, I have found favor in your eyes,
b **please** set your hand under my thigh,
 and perform loyal love and faithfulness for me:
 please, **do not bury me in Egypt**.
30 But I will **lay down with my fathers**,
a and you will take me up from Egypt,
and you will **bury me in their graves**."

And he said,
 "I will do according your word."
31 And he said,
 "**Swear an oath (השבעה)!**"
And he **swore an oath (ישבע)** to him,
and Yisra'el bowed down upon the head of the bed.

Like Grandson, Like Grandfather

Yaaqov requests that Yoseph specifically take up his body for burial with his fathers in Canaan. This act is portrayed on analogy to the promise the Abraham requested of his servant (likely Eliezer) in Genesis 24.

Yaaqov in Genesis 47	Abraham in Genesis 24
Gen. 47:29a “When the days for Yaaqov to die grew near ...”	Gen. 24:1 “Now Abraham was old, and advanced in years ...”
Gen. 47:29 Yaaqov to Yoseph: “ Place your hand under my thigh , and perform covenant loyalty and faithfulness with me, don’t bury me in Egypt.	Gen. 24:2-3 Abraham to Eliezer: “ Place your hand under my thigh , and swear an oath (שב״ע) to me by Yahweh ... that you won’t take a wife for my son from the daughters of the Canaanites.”
Gen. 47:31 And [Yaaqov] said, “ Swear an oath (שב״ע)!” And [Yoseph] swore (שב״ע) an oath .	Gen. 24:49 Eliezer to Laban: “If you will perform covenant loyalty and faithfulness with my lord, tell me!”
Comparing Jacob and Abraham in Genesis. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Like Abraham, who sought to protect the integrity of God’s promise to him by ensuring that Isaac marry within the chosen line, Yaaqov seeks to protect the future integrity of God’s promise by ensuring that his family’s time in Egypt isn’t permanent and they return to the promised land one day.

The Age of Yaaqov and the Sojourn in Egypt

The details of Yaaqov’s age and the number of years he was in Egypt are more than interesting historical facts. They fit into the larger symbolic chronology of the Torah, and meaning is revealed when the dates are coordinated with other significant events in the Torah.

The 17 years of Yaaqov’s life in Egypt match precisely with the age of Yoseph when he was sold into slavery in Egypt (Gen. 37:2). In this way, the lives of father and son are parallel to each other in relationship to their exiles from the land.

Yaaqov's age, when connected to the ages of the other patriarchs, adds up to a meaningful number.

Abraham	Gen. 12:4 75 yrs old when he entered Canaan Gen 21:5 100 yrs old when he had	Total years the patriarchs sojourned in Canaan:
Patriarchs Sojourning to Canaan. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).		

	Yitskhak Gen. 25:7 175 yrs old when he dies = lived in Canaan 25 yrs before Isaac	25 + 60 + 130 = 215 years
Isaac	Gen. 25:26 60 yrs old when he fathered Yaaqov	
Yaaqov	130 yrs old when he leaves the land of Canaan Gen. 47:28 147 yrs old when he dies	
Hebrew MT of Exodus 12:40-41	"And the sojourn of the Israelites who sojourned in Egypt was thirty years and four hundred."	The 430 year exile in Egypt was twice the number of years the patriarchs were in Canaan (see Isaiah 40:2).
Old Greek translation and the Samaritan version of Exodus 12:40-41	"And the sojourn of the Israelites who sojourned in the land of Canaan and in the land of Egypt was thirty years and four hundred."	The 215 year exile in Egypt was equal to the 215 years the patriarchs were in Canaan.
<i>Patriarchs Sojourning to Canaan. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>		

In this connection, Abraham's life, which began outside the land, is paired with Yaaqov's life, which ends outside the land. Their total time in the land is 215 years, which is precisely half of the time of Israel's exile in Egypt (in the Masoretic text).

The Death and Blessings of Yaaqov

Genesis 48:1-22

- **48:1-12** Ya'akov adopts Yoseph's sons, Ephrayim and Manasseh
- **48:13-20** Ya'akov **inverts the birth order and blessing of the sons**
- **48:21-22** Ya'akov **blesses Yoseph** over and above his brothers

Genesis 49:1-28

49:1-2

Ya'akov Gathers **the Sons of Yisrael** to Announce What Will Happen "In the End of Days"

49:3-27

Ya'akov's Speech to His 12 Sons

- a - **49:3-12** Ya'akov **inverts the birth order and blessing of Leah's sons**
- b - **49:13-17** Ya'akov speaks of **Leah** and **Billah's** sons
- c - **49:18** "For your deliverance I wait, O Yahweh!!"
- b' - **49:19-21** Ya'akov speaks of **Zilpah** and **Billah's** sons
- a' - **49:22-27** Ya'akov **blesses Yoseph** and Binyamin, sons of **Rakhel**

49:28

"These are the tribes of Yisrael ... when their father blessed them "

Genesis 48:1-49:28. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This section contains two deathbed scenes from the end of Yaaqov's life, and they mark the moment when he passes on to his sons the divine Eden blessing that was given to him by his father (back in Gen. 27). Both of these stories share important similarities and differences.

Similarities

Both stories focus on a blessing for Yoseph and his family.

- In Genesis 48, the blessing is for Yoseph and his two sons, especially Ephrayim.
- In Genesis 49, Yoseph receives the greatest and most abundant blessing among the brothers.

Both stories focus on an inversion of sibling birth order.

- In Genesis 48, Ephrayim the younger is elevated and blessed over and above Manasseh the older.
- In Genesis 49, Yehudah the fourth son of Leah is elevated and blessed over and above his three older brothers, Reuven, Shimon, and Levi.

Differences

- Genesis 48 elevates the lineage of Yoseph as the future of the Eden blessing, while chapter 49 elevates the lineage of Yehudah and Yoseph as dual carriers of the Eden blessing.
- Genesis 48 involves only blessing for Yoseph and his sons, while in chapter 49, three sons get a non-blessing (Reuven) or even a curse (Shimon and Levi).

Genesis 48-49 Within the Torah as a Whole

Genesis 48-49 Within the Torah as a Whole



Genesis 48-49 Within the Torah. Diagram created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

The Torah has two bookend frame stories about the final words and death of the leading figure in the story: Yaaqov in Genesis and Moses in Deuteronomy.

- Both Yaaqov and Moses offer a final series of poetic blessings or curses on the twelve sons of Yisrael (Gen. 49 // Deut. 28, 32-33).
- Both Yaaqov and Moses open their poems by claiming that their words speak of realities that are present and future.

Yaaqov in Genesis 48-49

Gen. 49:1

And Yaaqov **gathered his sons** and said,
“ **Gather** around and **I will tell you**
a thing that **will happen in the end of days** .”

Moses in Deuteronomy 27-34

Deut. 31:28-30

“ **Gather** to me all **the elders of your tribes**
For I know that after my death you all are going to
act corruptly ... and evil **will happen to you in the**
end of days”

And **Moses spoke the words** of this song in the
ears of all the assembly of Yisrael.

Comparing Jacob in Genesis 48-49 to Moses in Genesis 27-34. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

In both stories, the dying patriarch warns of a future time of ruin and exile that will be followed by a restoration of the land of promise and the Eden-blessing (Gen. 48:21; 50:24-25 // Deut. 28, 30).

In both stories, the vocabulary of the Eden story fills the poems and narratives (Gen. 48-50 // Deut. 27-34).

The Torah features bookends that both end with the sons of Israel outside the land of promise, waiting for Yahweh to act and bring the next generation into the full realization of the Eden blessing. Yaaqov and Moses offer warnings and hope, and together they offer the readers of the TaNaK in its final form a challenge and a comfort that Yahweh will yet fulfill his ancient promises to Abraham.

Yaaqov Blesses Yoseph's Sons

Genesis 48:1-12

48:1-2

Yoseph Brings His Two Sons to Sick Ya'akov

- 48:1 **"Look, your father is sick"** (הנה אביך חלה)
- Yoseph took his two sons, Manasseh and Ephrayim

48:3-7

Ya'akov Adopts Yoseph's Two Sons As His Own

- 48:5 "Ephrayim and Manasseh, they belong to me"
- 48:6 **"They will be called by (על) the name of their brothers (אחיהם)"**

48:8-12

Ya'akov Takes the Two Sons Upon His Knees for Blessing

Genesis 48:13-20

48:13-14

Ya'akov Inverts the Birth-Order and Blessing of the Sons

- 48:14a **"He set his right hand upon Ephrayim, though he was the smaller one"**
- 48:14b **"He crossed (שכל) his hands"**

48:15-16

Ya'akov Blesses Both Sons

- 48:16 **"May my name and the name of my fathers be called over (על) them"**

48:17-20

Ya'akov Inverts the Birth-Order and Blessing of the Sons

- 48:17 **"He set his right hand upon the head of Ephrayim"**
- 48:19 **"I know (ידע), my son, I know (ידע)"**
- 48:19 **"The smaller one will be greater"** than his brother"

Genesis 48:21-22

Ya'akov Blesses Yoseph Over and Above His Brothers

- 48:21 **"Look, I am dying"** (הנה אנכי מת)

• 48:22 “I give to you one shoulder over (על) your brothers (אחיד)”

Genesis 48:1-22. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This literary unit has been designed with three main parts arranged in a symmetrical pattern.

- The outer sections focus on the impending death of Yaaqov (v. 1 // v. 21), which is the scene where he passes on the blessing to Yoseph’s sons (v. 3-7) and to Yoseph himself (v. 21-22).
- The central section focuses on the inversion of the siblings. Yaaqov replays the ancient pattern of Yahweh’s blessing: He elevates the younger Ephrayim over the older Manasseh.
- The center of the center (Gen. 48:15-16) focuses on the full adoption of the two sons of Yoseph and their inheritance of Yaaqov’s name and blessing.

48:1 And it came about after these things,

a that he said to Yoseph,

“Look, your father is sick.”

b And he took his two sons with him, Manasseh and Ephrayim (אפרים).

2 And he told Ya’akov and said,

a’ “Look, your son is coming to you.”

And he strengthened himself and sat upon the bed.

a 3 And Ya’akov said to Yoseph,

a “El-Shaddai became seen to me,

b in Luz,

b’ in the land of Cana’an,

a and he blessed (ברך) me,

4 and he said to me,

‘Look, I am about to make you fruitful (פרה) and multiply,

and I will give you to become an assembly of nations,

and I will give this land to your seed after you, an eternal possession.’

5 And now, your two sons who were born for you in the land of Egypt,

before I came to you in Egypt,

they will be mine, Ephrayim (אפרים) and Manasseh.

Like Reuven and Shim’on, they will be mine.

6 And your family which you caused to be born after them, they will be yours.

By the name of their brothers, they will be called in their inheritance.

a 7 And as for me, when I came from Paddan-Aram, Rakhel died on me,

b in the land of Cana’an,

b’ on the road with one more stretch of land to enter Ephrathah (אפרתה).

a And I buried her there by the road to Ephrathah (אפרתה) (this is Bethlehem).”

⁸ And Ya'akov **saw** the sons of Yoseph,
and he said,

“Who are these?”

A ⁹ And Yoseph said to his father,
“These are **the sons** who **Elohim** gave to me in this place.”
And he said,
“Take them to me, please,
so that **I can bless (ברך) them.**”

B ¹⁰ Now, the **eyes** of Yisra'el were heavy from age.
He was not able to **see** .

And he drew them near to him,
and he kissed them,
and he embraced them.

A' ¹¹ And Yisra'el said to Yoseph,
“I had not considered that I would **see** your face,
but look, **Elohim** has let me **see** even **your seed** !”

¹² And Yoseph brought them out from upon **his knees (ברכיו)**
and they bowed down, faces to the ground.

Genesis 48:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Blessing, Blessing, Everywhere!

The Hebrew vocabulary of blessing fills this story by using the repetition of the word “blessing” itself (ברכה, ברך) and by using synonyms, related words, and homonym wordplays.

- “bless, blessing” (ברך) in Genesis 48:3, 9, 15, 16, 20
- “knees” (ברכים) in Genesis 48:12
- “fruit/fruitful” in Gen. 48:4
- “Ephrayim” (אפרים, whose name has the word “fruit” in the center, see Gen. 41:52)
- “Ephratah” (אפרטה, a place name with the verb “be fruitful” in the center)
- “multiply” (רבה, associated with the blessing back in Gen. 1:21, 28) in Genesis 48:4

All these repetitions of blessing make it clear that the full scale of the Eden blessing that has been passed on to each generation is now being inherited by the next generation.

The Adoption of Yoseph's Egyptian Sons

Recall from Genesis 41 that Yoseph's two sons are half-Egyptian, and they are from the lineage of Egypt's priesthood located in On.

Genesis 41:45 NASB*

Then Pharaoh named Yoseph Zaphenath-paneah; and he gave him **Asenath, the daughter of Potiphra priest of On, as his wife.** And Yoseph went forth over the land of Egypt.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 41:50-52 NASB*

⁵⁰ Now before the year of famine came, **two sons were born to Yoseph, whom Asenath, the daughter of Potiphra priest of On, bore to him.**

⁵¹ Yoseph named the **firstborn Manasseh**, "For," he said, "God has made me forget all my trouble and all my father's household."

⁵² He named the **second Ephraim**, "For," he said, "God has made me fruitful in the land of my affliction."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This important fact about Yoseph's sons also needs to be connected to the fact that Yaaqov fully adopts Yoseph's Egyptian sons as his own (Gen. 48:5-6).

This incorporation of Egyptian sons into the Eden blessing given to Abraham is crucially important for the overall story of tribal families in Genesis. This is yet another moment where the lineage of Ham begins to merge back together with the lineage of Shem (Recall Noah's sons from Gen. 9:18-27, 10:1-32). Here, the sons of Ham are connected into the line of Shem and the family of Abraham, which means they are connected to the Eden blessing.

Later biblical authors will draw upon this connection when they describe the ultimate restoration of Egypt into the Eden blessings that God has in store for the new creation (for example, see Isa. 19:18-25 and 45:11-15).

This pattern will be developed more in the Prophets and Writings as more descendants from Ham are brought into Abraham's blessing (Rahab and the Gibeonites in Josh. 2 and 9), as well as the sons of Lot (through Ruth the Moabite) and Esau (through Caleb the Kenazite, see Num. 13-14).

Reflection Question

What is significant about Yaaqov adopting Yoseph's sons as his own in Genesis 48?

Session 22: Ephraim and Manasseh

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov's words blessing Yoseph's sons foreshadow the division of the tribes and the loss of Ephrayim in exile.
- In the rest of the Hebrew Bible, the line of Yoseph, through Ephrayim, comes to represent God's promise to bless the nations, and the line of Yehudah comes to represent the blessing of royal rule. Both images are combined in David and Solomon but are separated and scattered in the divided kingdom.

The Inversion of the Firstborn Blessing

13 And Yoseph took the two of them,
Ephrayim at **his right hand**, at the **left hand** of Ya'akov,
and Manasseh at **his left hand**, at the **right hand** of Ya'akov,
and he made them draw near to him.

14 And Yisra'el sent out **his right hand**,
and he set it upon **the head of Ephrayim**,
and he was **the little one**,
and **his left hand** was upon **the head of Manasseh**.
He crossed **his hands**,
because Manasseh was **the firstborn**.

15 And **he blessed** Yoseph and said,
“**The Elohim** before whom **my fathers** walked, **Avraham and Yitskhaq**,
the Elohim who shepherded me from my past until this day,
16 **the messenger** who redeemed me from everything bad,
may he bless the boys,
and may my name and the name of **my fathers** be called over them, **Avraham and Yitskhaq**,
and may they increase into a multitude in the midst of the land.”

17 And Yoseph saw that his father had set **his right hand** upon **the head of Ephrayim**,
and it was bad in his eyes,
and he grabbed **the hand** of his father,
to remove it from upon **the head of Ephrayim**,

onto **the head of Manasseh**.

¹⁸ And Yoseph said to his father,

“Not this way, my father!

Because this one is **the firstborn**!

Set **your right hand** on **his head**!”

¹⁹ And his father refused and said,

“I know, my son. I know.

a He too will become **a people**,

b and he too will become **great**.

b' However, his brother, **the little one**, will be **greater** than him,

a' and his seed will become what fills **the nations**.”

²⁰ And **he blessed them** on that day, saying,

“May Yisra’el speak **a blessing** by your name,

‘May Elohim make (שִׁים) you like **Ephrayim** and like Manasseh!’”

And so he set (שִׁים) **Ephrayim** before Manasseh.

Genesis 48:13-20. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

²¹ And Yisra’el said to Yoseph,

“Look, **as for me** (אֲנִי), I am about to die.

And Elohim will be with you,

and he will cause you all to return to the land of your fathers.

²² And **as for me** (אֲנִי), I give to you one shoulder/shekhem over your brothers,

which I took from the hand of the Amorite with my sword and with my bow.”

Genesis 48:21-22. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

In this story, Yaaqov inverts the birth order and blessing from the younger son to the older. As he does this, he both repeats and intensifies this pattern that has been at work since the early chapters of Genesis.

1. The land beasts and humans
2. Cain and Abel
3. Japheth, Ham, and Shem
4. Haran, Nahor, and Abram
5. Ishmael and Isaac
6. Esau and Yaaqov
7. Manasseh and Ephrayim

While every story of sibling inversion is relevant for understanding this story, of particular importance is the story of Yaaqov's deception of his father Isaac in [Genesis 27](#). This story is modeled after that one in a very intentional way.

Isaac and Yaaqov in Genesis 27	Yaaqov and Yoseph's Sons in Genesis 48
Gen. 27:1 A blind father wants to give a blessing to his older son Esau	A father going blind wants to give a blessing to his son and grandsons
Yaaqov tricks his father by dressing up as his brother	Yaaqov tricks his son by switching his hands
Yaaqov the younger son deceptively gains the blessing of the firstborn son	Yaaqov sneakily gives the blessing of the firstborn son to the younger son
Gen. 25:23 The oracle about Yaaqov "Two nations are in your womb, and two peoples will separate from your innards, and one people will be stronger than the other, and the greater one , he will serve the littler one ".	Gen. 48:19 The oracle about Ephrayim "I know, my son. I know. He too will become a people , and he too will become great . However, his brother, the little one , he will be greater than him, and his seed will become what fills the nations ."
<i>Comparing Isaac and Jacob to Jacob and Joseph. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

In both stories, Yaaqov is the sneaky culprit. In contrast to earlier generations where Yahweh was the one who upset the traditional cultural birth order (animals and Adam; Cain and Abel; Nahor, Haran, and Abram; Ishmael and Isaac). But in [Genesis 27](#) and [48](#), Yaaqov is the one who elevates the younger son to the place of the firstborn.

The Exaltation of Ephrayim

This is the origin story of the rise of the tribe of Ephrayim among the sons of Yisrael. As it turns out, Ephrayim will become the ancestor of the most fruitful and powerful family among all the tribes, which eventually will become the dominant royal house after the kingdom splits into northern Israel and southern Judah after the reign of Solomon.

"The hill country of Ephrayim" = the central hills of the northern tribal kingdom of Israel ([Josh. 17:15](#)).

The Ephrayimites became the most numerous tribe in the land (see [Josh. 17:14-18](#)).

Prominent Ephrayimites in the Torah and Prophets include:

- Joshua (lit. Yehoshua) son of Nun ([Num. 13:8](#); [Josh. 19:49-51](#))

- The idolatrous Ephrayimite Micah who hires the priest ([Judg. 17-18](#))
- Elkanah, the father of Samuel the prophet ([1 Sam. 1](#))
- Jeroboam I, an Ephrayimite who leads a revolt against Solomon's son Rehoboam and forms a secession group of tribes that become "Israel" in the northern hill country ([1 Kgs. 11-14](#))

In the Prophets, "Ephrayim" is a synonym for the northern kingdom of Israel, which can also simply be called "Israel."

- [Isaiah 7 \(vv. 2, 5, 8, 9, 17\), 28:1, 3](#)
- [Jeremiah 4:15; 7:15; 31:6, 9, 18, 20](#)
- [Ezekiel 37:16, 19](#)
- [Hosea 5-14](#)

The Gift of Sh'khem-Shoulder

The phrase used "one sh'khem" (שכם אחד) is odd and capable of more than one meaning.

1. Sh'khem is the name of an ancient Israelite town in the northern hills that would become the territory of Ephrayim. This town would become one of the most important cities among the northern tribes.
Problem: The use of the number "one" is odd because it should be grammatically feminine if it modifies the word "Sh'khem," and even then it would be an odd thing to say in Hebrew.
2. The word "sh'khem" also means "shoulder," which is never used as a metaphor for "portion of land."
However, its synonym *kateph* (כתף) can refer to a "shoulder of land," that is, a slope or side of a hill (see [Num. 34:11](#) or [Josh. 15:8](#)).

"Most likely, shekhem must be connected with the city of Shechem, which is so intimately associated with Jacob and Joseph. Jacob bought a parcel of land there ([Gen. 33:18; Josh. 24:32](#)), the seduction of Dinah took place there, and Simeon and Levi massacred its inhabitants ([Gen. 34](#)). It was to Shechem that Jacob sent Joseph to visit his brothers ([Gen. 37:12, 14](#)), and Joseph himself is to be buried in the city ([Josh. 24:32](#)). Moreover, Shechem lay within the future territory of Joseph's two sons near the border between the two tribes Ephraim and Manasseh ([Josh. 17:7](#)), and it was to become the most important city in the kingdom of northern Israel ([cf. 1 Kings 12:1, 25](#)). The identification of Hebrew shekhem in this verse with the city of Shechem is reflected in the Septuagint translation and in early Jewish sources. It has been accepted by many traditional commentators as well. Yet there are difficulties. First, the phrase 'one Shechem' is very strange, and, in any case, Hebrew usage requires a feminine adjective with a city name ('*akhat*, not '*akhad*'). These problems may perhaps be overcome if shekhem is a play on words using a vocable whose meaning is now lost (possibly 'portion'), which alludes to the city of Shechem."

Sarna, Nahum M. (2001). [Genesis, The JPS Torah Commentary](#). Jewish Publication Society. 330.

Reflection Question

How does Yaaqov's blessing for Ephrayim foreshadow the division of the tribes, exile, and hope for reconciliation on the other side?

Session 23: Judah and Joseph

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov's curse on Shimon and Levi foreshadows the scattering of these two tribes.
- Yaaqov's blessing for Yehudah casts Yehudah as a new Yoseph.
- The story of David is patterned after the story of Yoseph.

Yaaqov's Blessing on His Twelve Sons

Genesis 49:1-2

Ya'akov Gathers His Sons

- **49:2** "Gather sons of Ya'akov, listen to Yisrael your father"

Genesis 49:3-12

Rival Sons of Leah

a - **49:3-4** Reuven

b - **49:5-7** Shim'on and Levi

a' - **49:8-12** **Yehudah (longest blessing)**

Genesis 49:13-21

49:13-17

Sons of Bilhah and Leah

- **49:13** Zevulun
- **49:14-15** Yissakhar
- **49:16-17** Dan

49:18

"For your deliverance I wait, O Yahweh!"

49:19-21

Sons of Bilhah and Zilpah

- **49:19** Gad
- **49:20** Asher
- **49:21** Naphtali

Genesis 49:22-27

Beloved Sons of Rakhel

- **49:22-26** Yoseph (longest blessing)
- **49:27** Binyamin

Genesis 49:28

Ya'akov Blesses His Sons

- “These are the tribes of Israel, and this is what their father said when he blessed them.”

Genesis 49:1-28. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Genesis 49 is a deathbed scene where the dying patriarch utters his final words to his sons.

¹ And **Yaaqov** called for **his sons** and said,

“Gather together and let me tell you all,
what will happen to you all at the end of days.

² Gather and **listen**, **sons of Yaaqov**,
and **listen** to **Yisrael your father** :

Genesis 49:1-2. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The premise of this speech is that a person near death has clarity on matters that are usually opaque. As they draw near to the border of Heaven and Earth, they can see what is to come and anticipate the future. On his deathbed, Yaaqov gathers his sons and offers them a window into their future.

Notice the symmetrical design of the chapter.

- On the outer ends are the first four sons of Leah, with Yehudah receiving the largest and most significant blessing. // The conclusion comes with the two sons of Rachel, with Yoseph receiving the most robust blessing. This design places Yehudah and Yoseph in a parallel relationship, which is crucial to the overall strategy of the Genesis scroll.
- Inside of the two ends are matching lists of three sons.
- And in the very center of the chapter is an odd line that sticks out in the poem. It could be a statement in the mouth of Yaaqov, or it could be an interruption from the narrator to comment on the two

important blessings for Yehudah and Yoseph.

- Either way, this central statement frames the entire poem as a source of hope for future generations who see in these blessings a promise of future deliverance for their family.

Rival Sons of Leah

³ **Reuven**, you are my first-born,
my strength and the beginning of my vigor.

Excelling in dignity,
and **excelling** in **strength**

⁴ uncontrollable like water,
you will **not excel** !

a' Because **you went up** (עלית) on **the bed** of your father
b then you profaned **my couch** —
a' to **my couch** **he went up**!

⁵ **Shim'on and Levi**, brothers;
their schemes are weapons of violence.

⁶ Into their council may my life not enter,
to their assembly may my honor never be joined;
Because in **their anger** they murdered men,
and in **their pleasure** they hamstringed oxen.

⁷ Cursed be **their anger** for it is **strong**
and **their wrath**, because it is harsh.

I will divide them up among Ya'akov,
and I will scatter them among Yisra'el.

a ⁸ **Yehudah**, as for you, **your brothers will praise you** (יודוך).
b Your hand (ידך) will be on the neck of your enemies (איביך),
a' the **sons of your father** (אביך) **will bow down to you**.
a ⁹ A **cub of a lion** is Yehudah
b from the prey, my son, **you have gone up** (עלית) .
a' He crouches, he lies down, like a **lion**,
b' and like a **young lion**, **who will make him rise up** ?

¹⁰ **The scepter** will not depart from Yehudah
nor **the ruler's staff** from between his feet,
unto when he comes to whom it belongs,
and the obedience of the peoples will belong to him.

¹¹ Binding **his donkey to the vine**,
and **a son of his mare to the offshoot**,
he washes his clothing in **wine**,
and his robe **in the blood of grapes**.

¹² Eyes sparkle from **wine**,
and teeth white from **milk**!

Genesis 49:3-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

The Non-Blessing on Reuven

Genesis 49:3-4 Instructor's Translation

³ **Reuven**, you are my first-born,
my strength and the beginning of my vigor.
Excelling in dignity,
and **excelling** in **strength**
⁴ uncontrollable like water,
you will **not excel**!
Because **you went up** (עלית) on **the bed** of your father
then you profaned **my couch** —
to **my couch** **he went up!**

“My firstborn” activates the “reversal of the firstborn” pattern: the beasts (Gen. 1-2), Cain (Gen. 4), Japheth (Gen. 9-10), Ishmael (Gen. 21), Yaaqov (Gen. 25, 27), and Yehudah/Yoseph.

Notice how Yaaqov describes Reuven using the imagery and language of Genesis 1.

- The word “beginning” (ראשית) and “uncontrollable waters” recalls “tohu vavohu” (Gen. 1:2).

“You went up on the bed of your father” is a reference to the story in Genesis 35:22: “It came about while Israel was dwelling in that land, that Reuven went and lay with Bilhah, his father’s concubine, and Israel heard.” This was Reuven’s grab for power by sleeping with the slave of Yaaqov’s favorite wife Rachel after she died.

While Yaaqov does not curse Reuven, he certainly does not pass on the firstborn blessing to him.

The Chronicler reflected back on this story and retold it in this way.

1 Chronicles 5:1-2 NASB*

¹ Now the sons of **Reuven the firstborn** of Israel
(for he was the firstborn,

but because he defiled his father's bed,
his birthright was given to the sons of Yoseph the son of Israel;
so that he is not enrolled in the genealogy according to the birthright.

² Though **Yehudah prevailed over his brothers**,
and from him came the leader,
yet **the firstborn right belonged to Yoseph**)

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"While Reuben is the biological oldest son, his corresponding rights of status were transferred to Joseph. Yet, even Joseph realized this birthright only to a certain extent, since 'Judah became strong among his brothers.' The author here suggests, then, three levels of priority among the sons of Jacob: the biological firstborn, the legally nominated elder, and the one who wielded actual authority. ... In full accord with his general world-view, the Chronicler explains Reuben's loss of his birthright as a punishment for sin, a theological conviction which is presented as an interpretation of texts in Genesis. ... The transfer of the birthright to Joseph is the second stage of the midrashic course. The legal implication of Jacob's words in Genesis 48:5, 'And now, your two sons ... Ephraim and Manasseh shall be mine, as Reuben and Simeon are,' is that these sons of Joseph are raised to the status of full membership among the tribes of Israel. In terms of inheritance, Joseph's portion in Jacob's inheritance was increased from one part (which would have been divided among his descendants) to two."

Japhet, Sara (2013). [I & II Chronicles: A Commentary](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 133.

The Curse on Shimon and Levi

Genesis 49:5-7 Instructor's Translation

⁵ **Shimon and Levi**, brothers;
their schemes are weapons of violence.
⁶ **Into their council** may my life not enter,
to their assembly may my honor never be joined;
because in **their anger** they murdered men,
and in their pleasure they hamstrung oxen.
⁷ Cursed be **their anger** for it is **strong**
and **their wrath**, because it is harsh.
I will divide them up among Yaaqov,
and I will scatter them among Israel.

The poem reflects back on the narrative of [Genesis 34](#), where Shimon and Levi led the massacre of the Canaanites in Shkhem. Even the vocabulary is linked to the narrative.

- "in their anger" (באפם) → "and they were very angry" (ויחר להם מאד, [Gen. 34:7](#))
- "they killed a man" (הרגו איש) → "and they killed every male" (ויהרגו כל זכר, [Gen. 34:25](#))

The curse (ארור) brought on Levi and Shimon sets them on analogy with Cain ([Gen. 4:11](#)) and with Ham ([Gen. 9:25](#)), who acted shamefully or murderously against their own family members and were exiled and cursed.

It is important to note, however, that the curse on Levi is reversed at Mount Sinai in the golden calf debacle, where Levi's violence earns him a "blessing" (Exod. 32:29) as he executes the idolators who worshipped the golden calf.

The "angry murder" pattern is activated here, linking Shimon and Levi to Cain, Lamech, Esau, and the brothers of Yoseph.

Yaaqov says that Shimon and Levi will be "scattered" (פּוּץ) and "divided" (חֵלֶק). These are the same words associated with the division of the nations during the Babylon debacle (see Gen. 11:8-9 and Deut. 32:8-9). This is reflected in the biblical version of Israel's history, where Levi is selected out of the tribes and not counted among them. As for Shimon, after the tribes go into the land under the leadership of Joshua, the tribe of Shimon is never heard of again (their appearance in Judges 1:3, 17 is their last in the Torah-Former Prophets).

Reflection Question

What are some of the ways the story of David follows the pattern of the Yoseph story?

Session 24: The Lion of Judah

Key Takeaways

- The New Testament authors reveal that the royal lion of Yehudah is also the sacrificial lamb that was slain, portraying Jesus' death and resurrection as the fulfillment of Yehudah's royal exaltation.
- The royal rod (or scepter) of Yehudah can represent either punishment or rule. Later biblical authors will interpret this promise to Yehudah as both judgment and blessing.
- The final section of the blessing of Yehudah looks forward to Eden abundance under the rule of the promised king.

The Royal Blessing on Yehudah

³ **Reuven**, you are my first-born,
my strength and the beginning of my vigor.

Excelling in dignity,
and **excelling** in **strength**

⁴ uncontrollable like water,
you will **not excel** !

a' Because **you went up** (עלית) on **the bed** of your father
b then you profaned **my couch** —
a' to **my couch** **he went up**!

⁵ **Shim'on and Levi**, brothers;
their schemes are weapons of violence.

⁶ Into their council may my life not enter,
to their assembly may my honor never be joined;
Because in **their anger** they murdered men,
and in **their pleasure** they hamstrung oxen.

⁷ Cursed be **their anger** for it is **strong**
and **their wrath**, because it is harsh.

I will divide them up among Ya'akov,

and I will scatter them among Yisra'el.

- a 8 **Yehudah**, as for you, **your brothers will praise you** (יִדּוּד).
b Your hand (יָד) will be on the neck of your enemies (אֹיִבִּים),
a' the **sons of your father** (אֲבִיךָ) **will bow down to you**.
a 9 A **cub of a lion** is Yehudah
b from the prey, my son, **you have gone up** (עָלִיתָ).
a' He crouches, he lies down, like a **lion**,
b' and like a **young lion**, **who will make him rise up**?

10 **The scepter** will not depart from Yehudah
nor **the ruler's staff** from between his feet,
unto when he comes to whom it belongs,
and the obedience of the peoples will belong to him.

11 Binding **his donkey to the vine**,
and **a son of his mare to the offshoot**,
he washes his clothing in **wine**,
and his robe **in the blood of grapes**.
12 Eyes sparkle from **wine**,
and teeth white from **milk**!

Genesis 49:3-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

This blessing on Yehudah is one of the high points of the Genesis scroll, and it develops the theme of the coming seed of the woman (from Gen. 3:15) in ways that echo throughout the rest of the Bible.

Yehudah as a New Yoseph Among the Brothers

Here Yehudah is named the leader among the brothers, and his role in the family is described with precisely the same language used in the blessing that Yaaqov received from Isaac (Gen. 27:29) and in the language used throughout Yoseph's story about his elevation to a place of rule among the brothers.

The Blessing Isaac Gave to Yaaqov in Genesis 27:29

Peoples will serve you
and **people groups will bow down to you**,
you will be mighty for your brothers
and **the sons of your mother will bow down to you**

Yaaqov's Blessing for Yehudah in Genesis 49:8-12

Yehudah, as for you, **your brothers** will praise you;
your hand will be on the neck of your enemies

Blessings for Jacob and Judah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

the sons of your father will bow down to you.

...

The scepter will not depart from Yehudah
nor the ruler's staff from between his feet,
unto when he comes to whom it belongs,
and the obedience of the peoples will belong to him.

Yoseph and His Brothers in Genesis 37:10 and 42:6

Gen. 37:10 Am **I and your mother and your brothers**
to **bow down to you** on the ground?

Gen. 42:6 And **the brothers** of Yoseph came
and **they bowed down to him**, faces on the ground.

Blessings for Jacob and Judah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

The blessing of Yehudah says in no uncertain terms that a future seed will arise from his lineage and that ruler will receive the homage of the tribes of Israel and of the nations when he comes into his rule. And that homage is described in the language of the narrative about Yoseph and his brothers. In other words, the story of Yoseph's rise to a place of rule among his brothers is here turned into a narrative analogy that is applied to the future rule of the seed of Yehudah. This poem shows how the author of Genesis wants us to read the Yoseph story through a messianic lens as a story that points forward to another future ruler from the tribe of Yehudah who will arise to rescue the tribes of Israel and the nations.

Now it is clear why the stories of David and Solomon, descendants from Yehudah, echo so powerfully in the Prophets and Psalms and are always being connected back to this promise and the imagery of the story of Yoseph.

- [Isaiah 2:1-4](#), [11:1-12](#), [49:1-8](#), [52:13-53:12](#), [61:1-10](#)
- [Ezekiel 34](#), [36-37](#)
- [Hosea 3](#)
- [Amos 9:11-15](#)
- [Micah 4:1-6](#), [5:1-10](#)
- [Psalms 2](#), [20-22](#), [72](#), [89](#), [110](#), [132](#)
- Etc.

"Unlike the imagery used of the other sons, the words of Jacob regarding Judah are quite transparent, though they are, of course, made up of poetic images. Judah is described as a victorious warrior who returns home from battle and is greeted by the shouts of praise from his brothers. The parallelism ... is extended by the statement, 'Your father's sons will bow down to you.' It is difficult not to see in this statement an intentional allusion to the dream of Joseph ([37:10](#)) in which his father's sons would come to bow down before him. In other words, what Joseph's dreams predicted and then did happen in the course of the narrative (e.g., [42:6](#)), these stories are here being transferred to the future of the house of Judah.

That which happened to Joseph is portrayed as a picture of that which would happen to Judah 'in the last days' (49:1)."

Sailhamer, John H. (1995). [*The Pentateuch as Narrative: A Biblical-Theological Commentary*](#). Zondervan Academic. 235.

"In this blessing Jacob depicts the coming Judahite with imagery that closely resembles the life of Joseph. ... Indeed, the image of eleven brothers 'bowing' to their royal sibling in Genesis 49:8 reads like a summary of the preceding Joseph story. This similarity is deliberate. Joseph is a 'narrative prefiguration' of Judah's seed ... the life of the future royal seed of Judah is patterned on the life of Joseph. Joseph is the type of king Israel will see again. ... In short, Jacob's prophecy is the most explicit evidence from Genesis that Joseph's character functions typologically, his life is a pattern of things to come."

Emadi, Samuel (2018). [*"Covenant, Typology, and the Story of Joseph"*](#). Tyndale Bulletin, Volume 69.1. 79-81.

The later David narratives explicitly portray him according to the pattern of Yoseph.

- Both are shepherds: [1 Samuel 16:11, 19](#) // [Genesis 37:2](#)
- Both selected over their brothers to a place of royal rule: [1 Samuel 16:6-13](#) // [Genesis 37:5-11](#)
- Both were sent to assuage the troubled king of his "bad spirit": [1 Sam. 16:16-18](#) // [Genesis 41](#) and Pharaoh's dreams.
- Both were sent by their fathers to inquire about the shalom of their brothers: [1 Samuel 17:17-18](#) // [Genesis 37:13-14](#); in both stories the brothers are hostile: [1 Samuel 17:28](#) // [Genesis 37:18-28](#).
- Both predict that a foreign leader will have their "head lifted off" (Goliath in [1 Sam. 17:46](#) // the Egyptian baker in [Gen. 40:19](#)).
- Both are endowed with "understanding" (נבון, [Gen. 41:33, 39](#) // [1 Sam. 16:18](#)) by the Spirit of God (רוח אלהים, [Gen. 41:38](#) // [1 Sam. 16:13](#)) and "beautiful of appearance" (יפה מראה, [Gen. 39:6](#) // [1 Sam. 16:12](#) and [17:42](#)) and "a man of form" ([1 Sam. 16:18](#), איש תאר // "beautiful of form" [Gen. 39:6](#), יפה תאר).
- Both are elevated by officials and kings who "set them over" responsibility: Yoseph is "appointed over" (פקד + על) the house of Potiphar ([Gen. 39:4](#)) // David, who is "set over" (שים + על) the army ([1 Sam. 18:5](#)).
- "And Yahweh was/is with him" ([1 Sam. 16:18, 17:37, 18:12, 28](#) // [Gen. 39:2, 21](#)).
- Both are "clothed" (לבש) with royal garments by a king in their exaltation story ([1 Sam. 17:38](#) // [Gen. 41:42](#)).
- David is sent to Saul with a "young goat" ([1 Sam. 16:20](#), גדי עזים), while Yoseph is replaced by his brothers with a "male goat" (שעיר עזים) to trick Yaaqov ([Gen. 37:31](#)).
- David the last-born is loved by Saul ([1 Sam 16:21](#), אהב), while Yoseph the 11th-born is loved by Yaaqov ([Gen. 37:4](#)).
- David "finds favor in the eyes of Saul" ([1 Sam. 16:22](#)). // Yoseph find favor in the eyes of Potiphar ([Gen. 39:4](#)) and the prison officer ([Gen. 39:21](#)).
- Jonathan son of Saul, of Binyamin brother of Yoseph "loves" (אהב) David of Yehudah, brother of Yoseph, and "his life is bound to David's life" ([1 Sam. 18:1](#), נפש יהונתן נקשרה בנפש דוד, // Yehudah appeals to Yoseph concerning his brother Binyamin, saying that Yaaqov "loves" (אהב, [Gen. 44:20](#)) him and that "his life is bound to his life" (נפשו קשורה בנפשו, [Gen. 44:30](#)).
- Yoseph's brothers, including Yehudah, "strip him" (פשט) of his royal garment ([Gen. 37:23](#)), // Jonathan of Binyamin brother of Yoseph "strips off" (פשט) his royal garment and gives it to David of Yehudah ([1 Sam. 18:4](#)).

- The scene of Jonathan (son of Binyamin) parting with David (son of Yehudah) is modeled after the reunion scene of Yoseph and Yehudah and Binyamin, along with all the rest of the brothers.
1. "And [David] fell on his face on the ground and he bowed" (1 Sam. 20:41) // "and [the brothers] bowed down on the ground" (Gen. 43:26) + "and they fell on their faces on the ground" (Gen. 44:14).
 2. "And they kissed each his other and they wept" (1 Sam. 20:41) // "and he fell upon the neck of Binyamin his brother and he wept ... and he kissed all his brothers and he wept over them" (Gen. 45:14-15).

Early Jewish Interpretation of Genesis 49:8-10

"8. Judah, you will your brothers praise, and by your name shall all the Jews be called Jews. Your hands will avenge you of your enemies; all the sons of your father shall advance to salute you. 9. I shall compare you, Judah, to a lion's whelp; you saved my son Joseph from his murderers. From the judgment of Tamar, my son, you are innocent; you will rest and dwell in the midst of battle, like the lion and like the lioness, and there is no nation nor kingdom that shall stand against you. 10. Kings shall not cease from among those of the house of Judah and neither (shall) scribes teaching the Law from his son's sons unto the time King Messiah shall come, to whom the kingship belongs; to him shall all the kingdoms be subject. 11. How beautiful is King Messiah who is to arise from among those of the house of Judah. He girds his loins and goes forth to battle against those that hate him; and he kills kings with rulers, and makes the mountains red from the blood of their slain and makes the valleys white from the fat of their warriors. His garments are rolled in blood; he is like a presser of grapes. 12. How beautiful are the eyes of King Messiah; more than pure wine, lest he see with them the revealing of nakedness or the shedding of innocent blood. His teeth are purer than milk, lest he eat with them things that are stolen or robbed. The mountains will become red from his vines and the vats from wine; and the hills will become white from the abundance of grain and flocks of sheep."

McNamara, Martin, translator (1991). [*Targum Neofiti 1: Genesis \(The Aramaic Bible\)*](#). Liturgical Press.

"8. Judah, you confessed and were not embarrassed; {therefore} your brothers shall praise you. Your hand shall prevail against your adversaries; your enemies shall be shattered; they shall turn their nape from you. Your father's sons shall come before you and salute you. 9. From the house of Judah dominion shall emerge in the beginning and a king shall be raised in the end; because you, my son, withdrew yourself from the sentence of death. He shall rest and dwell with strength like a lion and like a lioness, and there is no kingdom that could move him. 10. The ruler shall never depart from the House of Judah, nor the scribe from his children's children for evermore, unto when the Messiah comes, to whom belongs the kingdom, and him shall nations obey. 11. He shall lead Israel round about his city; the people shall build his Temple; the righteous shall be round about him; and they that carry out the Law shall be with him in study. Let his raiment, be of fine purple, and his garment all woolen, crimson, and of bright sparkling colors. 12. His mountains shall be red with his vineyards; his vats shall be dripping with wine; his valleys shall be white with grain and with flocks of sheep."

Grossfield, Bernard, translator (1988). [*The Targum Onqelos to Genesis \(The Aramaic Bible\)*](#). Liturgical Press.

"Rulers shall not cease from the house of Judah, nor teachers of the law from his posterity, until his descendant Messiah come, and the obedience of all peoples be unto him. How glorious is Messiah of the House of Judah! His loins girded, he will go out to do battle with his enemies. No king and no ruler will prevail against him. The mountains will be dyed red with their blood, and the garments of Messiah will be

like the garments of him that presseth wine. The eyes of Messiah will be clearer than pure wine, for they will never behold unchastity and bloodshed; and his teeth will be whiter than milk, for never will they bite aught that is taken by violence."

Ginzberg, Louis (2003). [*Legends of the Jews \(2nd ed.\)*](#). Jewish Publication Society. 408.

The Royal Rod of Yehudah

The phrase "lion of the tribe of Yehudah" that is found in the New Testament ([Rev. 5:5](#)) comes from this series of poetic images that describe Yehudah as a victor in battle. Notice the important density of royal vocabulary used in [Genesis 49:10](#).

Rod/Scepter

The Hebrew word *shevet* (שבט) means literally, "a wooden staff or rod."

The basic meaning of *shevet* is a wooden stick that symbolizes authority.

- It can mean "one who holds the *shevet*" ([Amos 1:5](#)).
- *Shevet* can also refer to a royal rod used to bring justice, so it is often used to describe a king "smashing with the rod," that is, attacking with an army (see [Isa. 10:15](#), [11:4](#), [28:27](#); [Micah 4:4](#)).
- Connected to the above, the word "rod" can refer simply to punishment (see [Isa. 11:4](#); [Job 37:13](#); [Ps. 89:32](#); [Prov. 13:24](#), [26:3](#), [29:15](#)).
- It can also refer to a shepherd's staff ([Micah 7:14](#); [Ps. 23:4](#)). But because "shepherd" is a common biblical metaphor for "king," these uses often have royal associations as well ([Ezek. 20:37](#)).

Ruler's Staff

The Hebrew word *mekhoqeq* (מחקק) means literally, "one who makes decrees and decisions."

The basic meaning of *mekhoqeq* is a person who carves decrees into stone to enact a decree for a group of people. It's a way to describe a ruler or leader in terms of their role in establishing order by way of legislation.

- The word refers to a person who makes decrees ([Judg. 5:14](#); [Isa. 33:22](#)).
- However, the *mekhoqeq* also came to mean "staff of a legislative ruler," and could be used as a synonym for "scepter" (see [Num. 21:18](#); [Ps. 60:9](#); [Deut. 33:21](#)).

From this point on, these two images (scepter and royal staff) become standard biblical metaphors to describe the future seed from the line of Yehudah who will arise to redeem Israel and the nations (see [Isa. 11:1-11](#); [Ps. 2](#) or [72](#), etc.).

"The Scepter/Rod Will Not Depart Unto/Until ..."

The Hebrew phrase in [Genesis 49:10](#) poses an interpretive challenge, and it's important to remember that the most ancient forms of the Hebrew Bible were written on scrolls without punctuation of any kind. The division of words into phrases, sentences, and paragraphs was passed on as an oral reading tradition and was subject to change. This means that sometimes the traditional sentence and phrase divisions are debatable, or we can

see that even in ancient times there were debates about how exactly to divide a sentence. Genesis 49:10 is one of those texts, and it just so happens that the meaning of an important messianic prophecy hangs in the balance.

The Hebrew text of Genesis 49:10 reads hyper-literally as follows.

Genesis 49:10 Instructor's Translation

1^a it will not depart, the rod, from Yehudah,

1^b nor the ruler-staff from between his feet

unto

2^a because he will come to whom it belongs,

2^b and to him will be the obedience of the nations

The key interpretive question is about the role of the word “unto” (Heb. *ad* / עד) in the sentence. It could be the last word of the poetic lines 1a-b (option 1), or it could be the opening word of the poetic lines 2a-b (option 2). The two options yield Hebrew sentences that are equally possible.

Option 1	Gen. 49:10 Hyper-literal 1^a it will not depart, the rod, from Yehudah, 1^b nor the ruler-staff from between his feet 2^a unto because (= “until”) he will come to whom it belongs, 2^b and to him will be the obedience of the nations 1^a לא יסור שבט מיהודה 1^b ומחקק מבין רגליו 2^a עד כי יבא שילה 2^b ולו יקחת עמים	This is reflected in nearly all of our modern translations
Option 2	Gen. 49:10 Hyper-literal 1^a it will not depart, the rod, from Yehudah, 1^b nor the ruler-staff from between his feet unto (= unto forever, i.e., “ever”) 2^a because he will come to whom it belongs, 2^b and to him will be the obedience of the nations	This interpretation is evident in ancient Jewish tradition (Targum Onqelos, Genesis Rabbah, many medieval Jewish commentators)
<i>Modern and Jewish Translations of Genesis 49:10. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>		

1a לא יסור שבט מיהודה
 1b ומחקק מבין רגליו עד
 2a כי יבא שילה
 2b ולו יקחת עמים

Modern and Jewish Translations of Genesis 49:10. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

There are many grammatical parallels in biblical Hebrew to the phrase for option 2 (see the long list in Richard Steiner, “Four Inner-Biblical Interpretations of Gen. 49:10”, *Journal of Biblical Literature*), but there are very few parallels for option 1, and none of those occur in Hebrew poetry.

In order to make progress on this question, we need to focus on another challenge in this text, and that is the meaning of the word “rod/scepter.”

The Rod of Punishment, Power, or Both?

Recall from the above discussion that the word “rod” (Heb. *shevet*) can refer to a royal rod that symbolizes (1) power or (2) royal power used to bring judgment.

When we combine both possible meanings for “rod” with option 2 above, an interesting interpretation emerges.

1. Meaning 1: Negative

- “the rod (of God’s punishing justice) will not depart from Yehudah ever, for he will come, the one to whom that rod (of royal rule) truly belongs”

2. Meaning 2: Positive

- “the rod (of royal rule) will not depart from Yehudah ever, for he will come, the one to whom that rod (of royal rule) truly belongs”

Meaning 2 is what underlies the repeated promise in the Prophets, of an eternal kingdom that will come from the line of David (see [Isa. 9:1-7](#) or [11:1-11](#)).

Meaning 1 is the clear meaning that Nathan the prophet saw in these words when he reflected them back to David on two occasions. The first occasion is in a promise found in [2 Samuel 7](#).

2 Samuel 7:12-16 NASB*

¹² When your days are complete and you lie down with your fathers,
 I will raise up your seed after you,
 who will come out from you,
 and I will establish his kingdom.

¹³ He shall build a house for my name,

and I will establish the throne of his kingdom unto forever (עד עולם).

¹⁴ I will be a father to him and he will be a son to me;
when he commits iniquity I will correct him,
with a human rod (שבט),
and with the strokes of the sons of humanity,

¹⁵ but my lovingkindness will not depart from him (לא יסור מ-),
as I made it depart (הסרתי) from Saul,
whom I made to depart (הסרתי) from before you.

¹⁶ Your house and your kingdom shall endure before me unto forever (עד עולם);
your throne shall be established unto forever (עד עולם).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Nathan's promise about the future lineage of David appears to take both meanings (1) and (2) into account, and sees both as possible and inevitable. David's descendants will undergo a long period of (1) divine judgment under the rod of punishment as a result of their moral failings. But the covenant failure of David's descendants will not overrule God's promise to raise up a royal deliverer from his line, and so God's loyal-love will not depart from David until there comes a future seed to whom that rule right belongs.

The second occasion is found in 2 Samuel 12, which is a judgment oracle after David's adultery and murder of Bathsheba's husband.

2 Samuel 12:9-10 NASB*

⁹ Why have you despised the word of the LORD by doing bad in his eyes?
You have struck down Uriah the Hittite with the sword,
and you have taken his wife to be your wife,
and you have murdered him with the sword of the sons of Ammon.

¹⁰ And now, the sword will not depart from (לא יסור מ-) your house, unto forever (עד עולם),
because you have despised me and have taken the wife of Uriah the Hittite to be your wife.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Here we find the permanent word of divine judgment on David's house because of his adultery and murder. In place of the "rod of punishing justice" we now have "the sword," which matches the heinous "sword of the sons of Ammon" that David orchestrated to murder Uriah.

For this interpretation, see Richard Steiner (2013), "Four Inner-Biblical Interpretations of Genesis 49:10," *Journal of Biblical Literature*, vol. 132, p. 33-60, especially p. 46-48.

"The One to Whom it Belongs" a.k.a. "Shiloh"

The phrase that appears in Genesis 49:10 is capable of multiple meanings, and it appears that all of them are not just possible, but intended by Yaaqov as an evocative and dense statement.

Literal Meaning

“unto when there comes *sh-loh* (שִׁילָה)”

Possible Meaning 1

shay-loh (שֵׁי לָהּ) = “an offering of tribute to him”

Meaning: The status of ruler will belong to Yehudah, up to the time when a ruler arrives to whom offerings of tribute will come, because the nations will offer obedience to him.

- This seems to be the meaning that is drawn upon by the poet of Psalm 72, who depicts the future messianic king as receiving tribute gifts from the nations (see Ps. 72:8-11, also Isa. 60:6-7 and Zeph. 3:9-10).

Psalm 72:8-11 NASB

⁸ May he also rule from sea to sea and from the River to the ends of the earth.

⁹ Let the nomads of the desert bow before him, and his enemies lick the dust.

¹⁰ **Let the kings of Tarshish and of the islands bring presents;
the kings of Sheba and Seba offer gifts.**

¹¹ And let all kings bow down before him, all nations serve him.

This is the interpretation held in most ancient Rabbinic literature (see *Genesis Rabbah* on Gen. 49:10, and *Yalkut Shimoni*), and it has become the majority view among modern commentators (for a survey of scholars who hold this view, see Richard Steiner (2010), “Poetic Forms in the Masoretic Vocalization of Three Difficult Phrases in Jacob's Blessing,” *Journal of Biblical Literature* vol. 129, p. 219-226).

Possible Meaning 2

shiloh (שִׁילָה) = “Shiloh” (a place name)

Meaning: The status of ruler will belong to Yehudah, up to the time when an event takes place at Shiloh that will change the balance of leadership among the tribes.

- Shiloh was a tent shrine that housed the ark of the covenant in the days of Samuel and the early monarchy (see 1 Sam. 1-2, 7). In this interpretation, this line is a forward reference to the division of the Israelite kingdoms after Solomon's reign, when Ahijah the prophet from Shiloh announced that Yehudah would become a lone kingdom and the northern tribes would secede (see 1 Kgs. 11:29-40).

Possible Meaning 3

shey-loh (שֵׁי לָהּ) = “what belongs to him”

Meaning: The status of ruler will belong to Yehudah, up to the time when an individual comes to whom that royal status truly belongs, and when that ruler comes, the nations will offer their obedience to him.

- This seems to be the meaning that Ezekiel drew from this poem, as he depicts the royal line of David as subject to ruin and divine judgment (see Ezek. 21:21-26), “until he comes, the one to whom justice rightfully belongs, and I will give it to that one” (Ezek. 21:27).

A Ruler Over the Family of Abraham and the Nations

Notice how Genesis 49:8-12 focuses on the dual nature of this future king's rule. It will encompass the tribal brothers of Yehudah, that is, the tribes of Israel. But the nations ("the peoples") will also come under this king's rule as well.

In this pairing, we watch the fulfillment of God's promise to Abraham back in Genesis 12:1-3 that he would provide a blessing for Abraham's family that would flow out and become a blessing for all the nations.

Eden Garden Imagery

The images in Genesis 49:11-12 are dense and riddle-like, but the overwhelming presence of garden imagery is undeniable.

- "binding a donkey to vine" = Productive vines are both precious and fragile, and parking one's donkey next to one would be unthinkable! The animal would devour and stomp all over the fragile vine. But, in an Eden-like world, where vines are plentiful and where "every man sat under his own vine and fig tree" (see 1 Kgs. 4:25; Mic. 4:4; Zech. 3:10), you can park your donkey by a vine and not even think about it. There's another one a few feet away!
- "washing his clothing in wine" = This is a dual image of (1) abundance, because wine was precious and wash-water is definitely not! But in an Eden world, the wash-water is wine, the streets are gold, and the city walls are made of precious stones (alluding to Rev. 21:18-21). This is also an image of (2) royalty: If you dye clothing in wine, it becomes purple, an ancient symbol of royalty (along with blue and red).
- "His eyes sparkle from wine, and teeth are white from milk" = These are also riddle-images of abundance. Sparkling eyes from wine can indicate intoxication (the same word is used in Prov. 23:29), which, in a celebration atmosphere, can be positive and associated with a celebration of God's abundant blessings (see Ps. 104:15). Abundant milk and white teeth are also signs of abundance, signaling large cow herds and healthy teeth.

Reflection Question

What are the possible meanings of the promise that "the scepter will not depart from Yehudah" in Genesis 49:10?

Session 25: Jacob's Poem of Blessing Concludes

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov's words for his sons often carry deep connections to the fate of their descendants in Joshua, Judges, and beyond.
- Dan's blessing could mean he will be a judge over the snake or a snake himself.
- Yoseph is set on analogy with Ishmael, recasting the division of Ishmael and Isaac as a story of reconciliation in this new generation and into Israel's future.

The Word About Zevulun

13 **Zevulun**, he dwells on the **coast of the sea**
and he is on **the coast of ships**,
his north part is by **Sidon**.

a 14 **Yissakhar**, he is a strong donkey
crouching down between the sheep pens.
b 15 And he saw a resting place, that it was **good**
and the land, that it was **pleasant**,
a' and he bowed his shoulder to carry
and he became a forced laborer

16 **Dan (דן)**, he will **judge (ידין)** his people
like one of the tribes of Yisra'el.
May **Dan (דן)** be **a snake** on the path,
a viper along the way,
which bites **the heel** of the horse,
so its rider falls backward.

18 **O Yahweh, I am waiting for your rescue!**

19 **Gad (גד)**, a troop (גדוד) will raid him (יגדנו)
and he will raid (יגד) **with the heel**.

20 From **Asher**, **rich** is his bread,
so he will give **delights** of a king.

21 **Naphtali**, a doe sent out,
who gives lovely lambs.

Genesis 49:13-21. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Yaaqov's word about Zevulun is linked to the region of the land where his descendants would settle in the days of Joshua and the judges (see [Josh. 19:10-16](#), [27](#), [34](#); [Judg. 1:30](#)).

The puzzle, however, is that in Joshua's days, Zevulun settled many miles inland from the northern coast of the Mediterranean. However, "dwelling" doesn't have to mean permanent land-holding. The blessing of Moses on Zebulun ([Deut. 33:18-20](#)) also links this tribe to the sea.

The Word About Yissakhar



IDF Mapping Unit. *The Twelve Tribes of Israel*, [Israel Ministry of Foreign Affairs](#)

This word also relates to the future land settlement of the tribe of Yissakhar. Their land holdings were right next to Zevulun, inland from the coast and south-west of the lake of Galilee (see [Josh. 17:10-11](#), [19:17-23](#)).

[Judges 1:19-34](#) makes clear that most of the tribes were not able to clear the land of its Canaanite inhabitants, and so they intermixed with them. This narrative omits any mention of Yissakhar at all, a fact which this poem appears to explore.

Yissakhar appears to have been a capable tribe ("a strong ass") but he did not use his strength. Rather, this tribe laid down passively (lazily?) among the sheep pens. Why? Because he found a nice resting place that came with a cost: slavery and oppression, precisely the status to which Yissakhar's kinsmen reduced the Canaanites in [Judges 1](#): "forced laborer" (לִמְסָר) = [Judges 1:28](#), [30](#), [33](#), [35](#).

The Word About Dan

The middle line of Yaaqov's poetic word about Dan is capable of two different interpretations, and both seem intended.

Option 1

Genesis 49:16-17 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ Dan, he will judge his people
as one of the tribes of Israel.

¹⁷ **May there be a judge of the snake on the path**
a viper along the way
which bites the heels of the horse
so that its rider falls backward.

Option 2

Genesis 49:16-17 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ Dan, he will judge his people
as one of the tribes of Israel.

¹⁷ **May Dan be a snake on the path**
a viper along the way
which bites the heels of the horse
so that its rider falls backward.

The translation issue revolves around the name “Dan” in the Hebrew phrase יהי דן נחש. The basic challenge is that the name Dan is the Hebrew word for “one who brings justice.”

This yields two possible meanings for Yaaqov’s words.

1. Option 1 anticipates a future Danite who will judge the snake!
2. Option 2 portrays Dan as a snake on a path.

The allusion to Genesis 3:15 is intentional, especially in light of the following word “viper” (שפיפון), which contains the consonants of the key word for “strike” in Genesis 3:15 (שוף).

Dan never settled in their allotted tribal territory (Josh. 19:47) due to Canaanite hostility (Josh. 1:34), so they migrated north of Galilee and settled there (see Josh. 18). They never held permanent land, and they were a small but tenacious tribe.

This tribe produced an important hero, whose story is cryptically anticipated in this poem: Samson in Judges 13-16.

- Samson was a Danite (Judg. 13:2), and his entire story depicts him as a deceiver who is deceived unto his own destruction, an anti-Genesis-3:15 figure. He is a wounded-victor, but he is deceived by his wife and suffers because of his own sins. The entire Samson narrative develops the “seed of the woman vs. snake” pattern from Genesis 3:15-16, which is anticipated here in riddle-like form.

Early Jewish Interpretations of Genesis 49:16-18

“16. From those of the house of Dan shall redemption arise, and a judge. Together, all the tribes of the sons of Israel shall obey him. 17. This shall be the redeemer who is to arise from the house of Dan; he will be strong, exalted above all nations. He will be compared to the serpent that lies on the ground, and to a venomous serpent that lies in wait at the crossroads, that bites the horses in the heels and out of fear of it the rider turns around and falls backward. He is Samson bar Manoah, the dread of whom is upon his enemies and the fear of whom is upon those who hate him. He goes out to war against those that hate him and kills kings together with rulers.” 18. Our father Jacob said: 'Not to the redemption of Gideon bar Joash does my soul look, which is the redemption of an hour; and not to the redemption of Samson bar Manoah does my soul look, which is a transient redemption. Rather to the redemption of him does my soul look that you have said to bring your people, the house of Israel. To you, to your redemption, do I look, O Lord.'”

McNamara, Martin, translator (1991). [*Targum Neofiti 1: Genesis \(The Aramaic Bible\)*](#). Liturgical Press.

“In blessing Dan, Jacob’s thoughts were occupied chiefly with his descendant Samson, who, like unto God, without any manner of assistance, conferred victory upon his people. Jacob even believed the strong, heroic man to be the Messiah, but when Samson’s death was revealed to him, he exclaimed, ‘I wait for Thy salvation, O Lord, for Thy help is unto all eternity, while Samson’s help is only for a time. The redemption,’ continued Jacob, ‘will not be accomplished by Samson the Danite, but by Elijah the Gadite, who will appear at the end of time.’”

Ginzberg, Louis (2003). [*Legends of the Jews \(2nd ed.\)*](#). Jewish Publication Society. 408.

The Cry for Deliverance

This line appears, somewhat surprisingly, as a first-person exclamation addressed not to the sons, but to Yahweh.

The phrase is a common liturgical one expressed in the Prophets and Psalms.

Psalms 25:5 NASB

Lead me in your truth and teach me,
for you are the God of my deliverance; for you I wait all the day.

Isaiah 25:9 NASB

And it will be said in that day,
“Behold, this is our God for whom we have waited that he might save us.
This is the LORD for whom we have waited;
let us rejoice and be glad in his deliverance.”

Isaiah 33:2 NASB

O LORD, be gracious to us; we have waited for you.
Be their strength every morning,
our deliverance also in the time of distress.

Notice that this line appears in the structural center of the entire chapter, in between two sets of poetic sayings about the brothers. But more specifically, it appears after the third poetic saying in the first two sets. Interestingly, those brothers feature Yehudah and Dan, both of whom are described as contrasting animals (lion vs. snake), and with imagery that recalls the Eden promise of [Genesis 3:15-16](#) about a future seed of the woman who will crush the snake and restore humanity's rule over the world.

If the above observations about the link between Yehudah and Dan are correct, that would place Yaaqov's cry for deliverance in a seventh position after the two sets of three poetic sayings. This is a common design strategy in biblical literature, to place a climactic seventh statement after a series of triads (like the seventh day after the six days of creation in [Genesis 1:1-2:3](#), or like the 10th Passover plague after the nine plagues of the Exodus in [Exodus 7-13](#)).

Triad #1	Triad #2
1. Reuven	4. Zevulun
2. Shimon and Levi	5. Yissakhar
3. Yehudah the lion !	6. Dan the snake !
7. "For your deliverance I wait, Yahweh!"	
<i>Two Triads of Jacob's Sons. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

The Word About Gad

This poem exploits the letters of Gad's name and their similarity with the Hebrew word *gedud*, which means "a unit of soldiers" (see this word in [1 Sam. 30:8, 15, 23](#); [2 Sam. 3:22](#); [2 Kgs. 6:23](#)), or the verb *gad*, "to raid."

This poem anticipates the role played by Gad (along with Reuven and half the tribe of Manasseh) in the conquest of the land: He will cross over and participate in the raid on Canaan ([Num. 32:16-32](#); [Deut. 3:18](#); [Josh. 1:12, 4:12](#)).

There is a translation challenge revolving around the meaning of "heel." Is it the (1) object of "raid" (i.e., Gad will be stomped by a raiding heel of an enemy army)? Or (2) an instrumental accusative, in which case this line joins with the poem about Dan—Gad also will produce one who "raids with the heel," which is another allusion to [Genesis 3:15](#).

The Word About Asher

The name "Asher" is formed from the Semitic root word "to declare someone is blessed with abundance" (see the word in other contexts in [Gen. 30:13](#); [Mal. 3:12](#); [Ps. 72:17](#)). And this "blessing" theme of Asher's name

evokes the Eden narrative, which will be drawn upon in this short poem.

This tribe settled west of Galilee in the fertile hills between Carmel and the coast where the Phoenicians were located (Josh. 19:24-31). The fertility of this region is reemphasized in Moses' blessing (Deut. 33:24).

The "delights" (מַעֲדֵן) are an allusion to Eden (עֵדֶן), but tragically this tribe will offer its Eden delights to the Canaanites, as recounted in Judges 1:13-21.

The Word About Naphtali

This tribe settled west of the lake of Galilee from its southern end up to Lake Huleh, north of the lake of Galilee (Josh. 19:32-39). They had to coexist with Canaanites they could not drive out, until they won a few cities for themselves (Judg. 1:33).

This tribe played an honorable role in the battle of Deborah because Barak, the Israelite general, was from Naphtali (Judg. 4:6, 5:18).

The final two words (lit. *'imrey shapher* / אִמְרֵי שֹׁפֵר) admit multiple interpretations.

1. "lovely words" = a herald of victory in the war of Deborah, see Judges 4:6, 10 and 5:18.
2. "lovely lambs/fawns" = tribute of animals to Canaanite overlords, just as "give" means offering tribute in the words spoken to Yissakhar (Gen. 49:15) and Asher (Gen. 49:20).
3. "lovely boughs" = metaphor of a spreading tree, an image of fruitfulness.

The Manifold Blessing on Yoseph

- ²² **Yoseph** is a son of a wild female donkey,
son of a wild donkey by a spring,
(sons of) wild donkeys by Shur.
- ²³ They were hostile to him, and they **fired**,
and they were opposed to him, those **possessing arrows**.
- ²⁴ But **his bow** remained perpetual,
and **the hands** of his arms were agile,

because of **the hands** of the **Strong One of Ya'akov**,
from there is the Shepherd, **the Rock of Yisra'el**,

- ²⁵ from **the Elohim of your father**, who will help you,
and **Shaddai**, who will **bless** you:
blessings from heaven above
blessings from the deep, lying beneath
blessings of breast and womb,

²⁶ the **blessings** of your father, they are mighty
 above the **blessings** of the **mountains**
 up to the desire of **eternal hills** .
 These will be upon **the head** of **Yoseph** ,
 on **the crown** of one set apart from his brothers.

Genesis 49:22-26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

The opening line of the poem about Yoseph is a riddle filled with Hebrew words capable of more than one meaning. This produces an “overabundance of possible meaning” that matches the theme of the poem, which is about a son given an overabundance of favor and abundance. Here are two possible translations alongside one another; both meanings are intended.

Possible Meaning 1

Genesis 49:22-24 Instructor's Translation

²² Yoseph is a son of a wild female donkey,
 son of a wild donkey by a spring,
 (sons of) wild donkeys by Shur.
²³ They were hostile to him, and they **fired,**
 and they were opposed to him, those **possessing arrows.**
²⁴ But **his bow remained perpetual,**
 and **the hands** of his arms were agile

Yoseph is compared to a young male donkey (a foal), born to a wild female donkey, which finds itself by a desert spring on the way to Shur, a desert oasis stop south of the land promised to Abraham (see [Gen. 16:7](#) and [20:7](#)).

This meaning uses the key words “wild female donkey” (פרת // פרא), “spring” (עין), and “Shur” (שור) to recall the stories of Hagar and Ishmael, comparing them to Rachel and Yoseph.

- Recall that in [Genesis 16:7](#), Hagar flees from Sarai to a spring (עין) on the way to Shur (שור), and she hears from an angel that her son will be a “wild donkey” (פרא) of a human.
- Recall that in [Genesis 20:7](#), Ishmael and Hagar live in the wilderness where he “is a shooter of the bow” (רבה קשת).

The reference to a hostile “they” in 49:23 would then refer to Yoseph’s jealous older brothers, activating the brothers // Esau analogy (see [Gen. 27:41](#), “And Esau was hostile (שטם) to Yaaqov”).

On this reading, Yoseph is the blessed and chosen younger brother who unlocks the divine blessings of Eden for others, but he was persecuted by his elder brothers and chased into the wilderness like Ishmael. But God kept Yoseph’s arms stable and blessed him with cosmic blessing (skies and abyss = [Gen. 1](#) vocabulary).

Possible Meaning 2

Genesis 49:22-24 Instructor's Translation

22 Yoseph is a son of a fruit-bearing (tree),
 a fruit-bearing (tree) by a spring,
 daughters striding over a wall.

23 They were hostile to him, and they **fired,**
 and they were opposed to him, those **possessing arrows.**

24 But **his bow** remained perpetual,
 and **the hands** of his arms were agile

Yoseph is compared to a branch from a fruit-bearing tree (literally “son of a fruit-bearer”) that is located by a spring, with tendril-runners (literally “daughters”) that climb over walls to spread their fruitfulness outside the garden.

- “Son of a fruit-bearer” is a possible way the images could be understood, and so Yoseph would be compared to a fruit-tree bearing much fruit (i.e., Yaaqov and Rachel).
- The “spring” would be the gift of Yahweh’s blessing on the chosen ones.
- The “wall” would represent the overabundance of God’s fruitful blessing, so that even a garden wall can’t contain the blessing as it spreads out of its original area of planting.
- These Eden images are so rooted in the narrative of [Genesis 2-3](#), as well as the Eden imagery activated by Yoseph’s rule over his family in the land of Goshen (which is an Eden place), it is unlikely that these possible meanings were not in the mind of the poet.

The Royal Blessing on Yoseph

The blessing given to Yoseph recalls the blessing given to Yaaqov by his father Isaac in [Genesis 27](#). This similarity makes it clear that Yoseph is being marked as the firstborn among all the sons.

Genesis 49:25-26 Yaaqov’s Blessing on Yoseph	from the Elohim of your father , who will help you, and Shaddai, who will bless you: blessings from the skies above blessings from the deep, lying beneath blessings of breast and womb, the blessings of your father , they are mighty above the blessings of the mountains up to the desire of eternal hills. These will be upon the head of Yoseph , on the crown of one set apart from his brothers .
Genesis 27:27-29 Isaac’s Blessing on Yaaqov	See, the smell of my son, like the smell of the field, which Yahweh has blessed. May Elohim give to you from the dew of the skies, and from the fat of the land,
<i>Symmetry in Blessing of Joseph and Jacob.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

and much grain and new wine.
May peoples serve you,
and may people groups **bow down to you** ,
be a mighty one to your brothers,
and may the **sons of your mother** bow down to you.
Cursed are those who curse you,
and those who blessed you are **blessed**.

Symmetry in Blessing of Joseph and Jacob. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

It's clear that Yoseph is inheriting the divine blessing of abundance that has marked the promised lineage from Abraham to Isaac to Yaaqov.

- Notice the echoes of Genesis 1:1-2 (“skies,” “the deep,” the land”) and also of the human image of Elohim who is “set apart” from the animals to a place of blessing and rule.
- Now that Yoseph and Yehudah have each received their blessings, notice that the two aspects of the image of Elohim from Genesis 1 have here been allotted to two special sons of Yaaqov.

Genesis 1:27-28

Elohim created human in his own image,
in the image of Elohim he created him;
male and female he created them.
And Elohim **blessed** them;
and Elohim said to them,
“**Be fruitful and multiply,**
and fill the land, and subdue it;
and rule over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the sky
and over every living thing that moves on the earth.”

Yehudah
Eden abundance
A ruler among the sons of Yisrael
A ruler among the nations

Yoseph
Eden abundance
Royal status among the sons of Yisrael

Comparing Judah and Joseph. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Both sons are given the Eden blessing of abundance and of royal rule among the brothers. Only Yehudah is assigned a place of rule outside of the family of Israel. This dual blessing sets up the reader for the long history of rivalry that will plague these two tribes, which will come to dominate Israel’s story in the land. It is the tribe of Yoseph’s son Ephrayim who will become the most powerful and numerous in the north, and the tribe of Yehudah will dominate in the south.

This division in the age of the patriarchs is a preview of the division that will take place after David and Solomon's death (1 Kings 1-2 and 11). The kingdom of "Yisrael and Yehudah" will split into north and south, and Rehoboam and Jeroboam will become the descendants who replay the rivalry of their ancestors (see 1 Kings 12-14).

The Word About Binyamin

27 **Binyamin**, a wolf who will tear.
In the morning he devours,
and in the evening he divides plunder.

28 All these are the twelve tribes of **Yisra'el**,
and this is what **their father** said to them,
and he **blessed** them,
each according to his **blessing**,
he **blessed** them.

Genesis 49:27-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Here the tribe of Binyamin is portrayed as aggressive and powerful, which is pretty much the opposite of his passive and powerless portrait in Genesis 42-46.

The aggressive nature of the sons of Binyamin are a core theme of Judges-Samuel.

- Ehud (Judg. 3:15)
- The warriors of Binyamin in the battle of Deborah (Judg. 5:14)
- The notoriously accurate slingshot warriors of Binyamin (Judg. 20:15-16) who fought savagely in the Israelite civil war described in Judges 20

The territory of this tribe occupied the central location between Yehudah in the south and Ephraim in the north (Josh. 18:11-20), as well as the main road from east of the Jordan to the western Mediterranean—i.e., it was the arena of many wars throughout Israel's history.

We can detect allusions to Saul in this poem. Israel's first king was from Binyamin, and his downfall was precisely in his aggressive "eating" of the "plunder" in 1 Samuel 14:30-32 and 15:19-21.

Notice that the sequence of sons corresponds to the symmetrical arrangement of the triads and to the distribution of animal imagery in the poems. Yehudah and Binyamin occupy matching positions as the conclusion to the first and last triad, pairing the imagery of lion versus wolf. Recall that David and Saul were from the tribes of Yehudah (lion) and Binyamin (wolf).

1. Reuven 2. Shimon and Levi 3. Yehudah the lion!	A
1. Zevulun 2. Yissakhar the donkey 3. Dan the snake	B
"For your deliverance I wait, Yahweh!"	
1. Gad 2. Asher 3. Naphtali the deer	B'
Yoseph the wild donkey 1. Ephrayim 2. Manasseh 3. Binyamin the wolf	A'
Judah and Benjamin the Animals. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Reflection Question

What are some implications of the links between Yoseph and Ishmael in Yaaqov's poem of blessing in Genesis 49:22-26?



Module 7: Going Up to Canaan

SESSIONS 26-29

As Jacob and Joseph reach the ends of their long lives, each looks forward with hope to a promise of God's faithfulness beyond the grave.

Session 26: Jacob's Last Request

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors highlight Yaaqov's request to be buried in the cave in the field of Makpelah where his parents and grandparents are buried.
- The Hebrew words for "cave" (*me'arah*) and "Makpelah," roughly translating to "naked" and "pair," link this burial site to the garden of Eden.

Section 3: Genesis 49:29-50:26

Genesis 49:29- 50:14

49:29-33

Ya'akov Commands His Sons To Bury Him in Canaan

- 49:29-30 "And he commanded them: 'Bury me in the cave in the field of Makpelah ... in the land of Canaan, that Avraham purchased from Ephron the Hittite.'"
- 49:33 "And Ya'akov died and was gathered to his people"

50:1-11

- a - 50:1-3 70 days of weeping over Ya'akov's death + 40 days of embalming his body
- b - 50:4-6 Yoseph requests to go up to Canaan to bury his father in Canaan
- b' - 50:7-9 Yoseph goes up with Pharaoh's house to bury his father in Canaan
- a' - 50:10-11 Seven days of weeping at the threshing floor of the thorn

50:12-14

Ya'akov's Sons Bury Their Father

- "And his sons did as they were commanded, they carried him to the land of Canaan and buried him in the cave of the field of Makpelah ... which Avraham purchased from Ephron the Hittite."

Genesis 50:15-21

50:15-17

The Brothers Deceive Yoseph To Gain Forgiveness

- **50:15** “He will return to us all **the evil we repaid him!**”
- **50:17** “Yoseph wept as they spoke to him”

50:18

- “His brothers fell before him and said, ‘We are your servants!’”

50:19-21

Yoseph Is Honest With His Brothers and Forgives Them

- **50:20** **“You planned evil against me,** but Elohim planned good ... to save many lives!”

Genesis 50:22-26

50:22-23

- **Yoseph stays in Egypt and lives for 110 years**

50:24-25

Yoseph Anticipates a “Going Up” for His Future Family and for His Bones

- **50:24** **“He will bring up you all from this land”**
- **50:25** **“You will bring up my bones from this place”**

50:26

- **Yoseph dies at 110 years, and is placed in a box in Egypt**

Genesis 49:29-50:26. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

We have come to the end of the final literary unit in the Genesis scroll. Notice that it has been given a symmetrical three-part design.

1. On the outer ends, we have the parallel deaths of a father and a son, Yaaqov and Yoseph. Yaaqov asks for a burial in Canaan. And after his death, the narrative focuses on the elaborate funeral procession. On the other end comes Yoseph’s request for a burial in Canaan, and the narrative focuses on the future “ascent” out of Egypt into Canaan, followed by his death.
 - This brings the themes of the Eden story in [Genesis 2-3](#) toward their resolution: The exile of Adam and Eve from Eden resulted in death for all their descendants. Here, the deaths of Yaaqov and Yoseph end with a hope for a “going up” of their bones and bodies to reside in the “cave of Makpelah.”
2. In the center is a story of Yoseph’s final act of reconciliation and forgiveness toward his brothers.

- This brings the themes of Genesis 1-4 to their resolution: The older snake was not chosen for rule, but the humans were. Parallel to this, the older Cain was not chosen for the blessing, but his younger brother Abel was. But in this story, instead of that chosen-status evoking anger and murder, Yoseph uses his special status to become an image of divine forgiveness.

Yaaqov's Second Request to be Buried in Canaan

29 And **he commanded** them,
and said to them,
"I am about **to be gathered to my people**."

A **Bury** me with **my fathers** ,
in the cave which is **in the field** of **Ephron the Hittite**,

B 30 **in the cave** which is **in the field of Makpelah** (= "doubling")
which is opposite the face of Mamre in the land of Canaan,
which field Avraham **purchased** from **Ephron the Hittite** for a **burial**-possession.

A 31 There they **buried** **Avraham and Sarah** his wife,
there they **buried** **Yitzhaq and Rivqah** his wife,
there I **buried** **Le'ah** .

B' 32 **The field** **purchased**,
along **with the cave** which is in it,
from the **sons of Heth**."

33 And Ya'akov **finished commanding** his sons,
and **he gathered** his feet into the bed,
and he expired, and **he was gathered to his people**.

50:1 And Yoseph fell upon the face of his father,
and he **wept** over him,
and he kissed him.

2 And Yoseph commanded his servants **the healers (הרפאים)** to **embalm** his father,

and **the healers (הרפאים)** **embalmed** Yisra'el.

³ And they fulfilled for him **forty days**,

because this is how the days of the **embalmers** were fulfilled.

Then **Egypt** **wept** for him for **seventy days**.

A ⁴ And the days of **weeping** for him passed on,
and Yoseph said to the house of Phar'oh, saying,

"If, **please**, I have found favor in your eyes,
speak, **please**, in to ears of Phar'oh, saying,

⁵ 'My father made me **swear an oath**, saying,

"Look, I am about to die.

B In my **burial-grave** which I dug for myself in the land of Cana'an,
bury me there."

And now, **may I go up**, **please**,
so I can **bury** my father,
and so I can return."

B A' ⁶ **And Phar'oh said**,
"**Go up** and **bury** your father,
just as he made you **swear an oath**."

⁷ And Yoseph **went up** to **bury** his father,
and they **went up** with him,

a **all the servants of Phar'oh**,

b **the elders** of his house,

a' and **all the elders of the land of Egypt**,

a ⁸ and **all the house** of Yoseph,

b and his brothers,

a' and **the house** of his father.

Only their children and their flocks and their herds did they leave in the land of Goshen.

⁹ And they **went up** with him, both chariots and horsemen,
and the camp was **heavy, very much**.

¹⁰ And they came to **the threshing floor of the thorn (= "Goren-Ha'atad")**,

and they **wept** there a **great and heavy weeping**, **very much**,

and they **performed grieving** for their father, for **seven days**.

¹¹ And **the inhabitant of the land, the Cana'anite**, saw the **grieving** at **the threshing floor of the thorn**,
and they said,

"This is a **heavy** **grieving** for Egypt!"
For this reason, its name is called,
"**Grief** of **Egypt**" [= "Evel-Mitsrayim"]
which is across the Jordan.

12 And his sons did for him just as **he commanded** them,

13 and his sons carried him to the land of Cana'an,
and they **buried** him **in the cave** of **the field of Makpelah** (= "doubling"),
which field Avraham **purchased** for a **burial**-possession,
from **Ephron the Hittite**, opposite the face of Mamre.

14 And Yoseph returned to Egypt,
he and his brothers
and all those who went up with him to **bury** his father,
after he **buried** his father.

Genesis 49:29-50:14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Gathered With the Ancestors in the Cave of Makpelah

In this story, Yaaqov approaches his own death and requests that he be buried in the land of his ancestors in a specific cave in the field of Makpelah. This refers back to the only piece of land that Abraham ever purchased and owned, as recounted in Genesis 23.

This story assumes a knowledge of the Eden hyperlinks in that story.

Death, Paradise, and the Passing of the Righteous

The story of Sarah's burial is a full-scale replay of the core themes at work in the garden of Eden story. Through wordplays, hyperlinks, and narrative analogies, Abraham's loss of Sarah is compared to both the loss of eternal life in Eden and to the hope of God's promise to restore life.

The Death of the Beloved by the Sacred Tree in Genesis 23

After Abraham's great act of faithfulness, we're told that his beloved wife dies near the sacred tree that Abraham had encamped by all the way back in chapter 14. The design of this story emphasizes the special importance of this location, by repeating the mention of Hebron in the opening and closing of the chapter.

Gen. 23:1-3

And Sarah died
in Qiryath-'Arba' (**this is Hebron**),
in the land of Canaan .

Gen. 23:4-16

Abraham negotiates the purchase of the burial plot

Gen. 23:17, 19

which was in **Makpelah**,
which was facing **Mamre**,
the field and the cave which is in it,
and all the trees which are in the field,
which are in all the surrounding border.

...

Now, after this, Abraham **buried** Sarah his wife,
in **the cave of the field of Makpelah**,
which was facing **Mamre** (**this is Hebron**),
in the land of Canaan .

Gen. 13:18

Then Abram moved his tent and
came and dwelt by **the oaks of Mamre**, **which are in Hebron** ,
and there he built an altar to the
Lord.

Gen. 14:13

Now he was living by **the oaks of Mamre** the Amorite, brother of
Eshcol and brother of Aner, and
these were allies with Abram.

Gen. 18:1

Now the Lord appeared to him
by **the oaks of Mamre**, while he
was sitting at the tent door in the
heat of the day.

Oaks of Mamre in Genesis 13-23. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

The narrative highlights that when Abraham was living near Hebron/Mamre, it is by trees that he lived, worshipped, and met with God. This is a clear Eden motif because Abraham and Sarah are presented as a new Adam and Eve living in the promised garden land and communing with God by the trees of Hebron.

Sadly, the wife of the new Adam eventually dies by the sacred trees of Mamre. This is a vivid and potent image that recalls the woman eating from the tree that leads to death.

But it is also by the sacred trees of Mamre/Hebron that Sarah is buried.

Ephron = "Dusty," and the Hope of Eternal Life

The name of Abraham's Hittite negotiating partner is Ephron, from the Hebrew word for "dust" (*'aphar* / עפר). This creates the ironic image of Abraham bartering with Dusty to ensure a place of rest for his beloved as she returns to the dust.

Recall that "death unto the dust" was a key image from the Eden narrative that's associated with death.

Genesis 3:19 NASB*

By the sweat of your face you will eat bread,
until you return to the ground,
because from it you were taken;
for you are **dust** (*'aphar*)
and to **dust** (*'aphar*) you shall return.

The Cave of Makpelah/"Naked Pair"

Each of the words "cave" and "Makpelah" have rich wordplay associations with the Eden story.

"Cave" (*me'arah* / מערה) in Hebrew literally means "place of exposure/nakedness". This Hebrew noun is related to two root words spelled with similar letters that both mean "to be exposed, naked"

1. ערר: 'arar, see [Isaiah 32:11](#).
2. עור: 'ur, see [Habakkuk 3:9](#), where it is spelled with the same letters as "nakedness" from [Genesis 2:25](#).

Genesis 2:25 Instructor's Translation

And they were **naked** ('arum, ערום) and they were not ashamed.

- [Genesis 23:9](#): "Cave", Heb. *me'arah* (מערה)

"Makpelah" is an odd place name that means "doubling" or "pair."

- The root is *kaphal* (כפל), which means "to be doubled" or "paired" (see examples of the verb in [Exod. 26:9](#); [Ezek. 21:19](#)).
- The meaning of Makpelah as "pair" or "double" is attested early in the history of Jewish interpretation, as the Greek Septuagint translators rendered this word with διπλούς, "twin" or "paired."

When these curious words are combined, the name of this place is "The Nakedness of the Pair." This is a clever reference back to the moment when Adam and Eve violate God's command, eat from the forbidden fruit, and then realize that "the two of them are naked" ([Gen. 2:24-25](#) and [3:6-7](#)).

The Burial Plot as Abraham's Mini-Eden

The description of the cave and the burial plot in [Genesis 23:17-18](#) is repetitious and unnecessarily wordy, as it repeats vocabulary from earlier in the chapter. Upon closer inspection, however, these repetitions seem intentional and create a series of hyperlinks back to earlier moments in the Abraham narrative where the promised land was set on analogy to Eden.

Genesis 23:17-18	Hyperlinks to Earlier Genesis Narratives
Gen. 23:17-18 And it was transferred, the field of Ephron (עפרון) which is by Makpelah, which is in front of Mamre (לפני ממרא)	Gen. 13:10-11 Lot lifted up his eyes and saw all the valley of the Jordan, all watered ... like the garden of God, before Yahweh destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah. And Lot chose for himself all the valley of the Jordan ... and they separated (פרד). Gen. 13:14-15, 18
<i>Genesis 23's Hyperlinks to Earlier Narratives. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

	Yahweh said to Abram after Lot separated (פרד) from him, “Lift up your eyes and see ... north, south, east, west ... I give it to you and your seed forever, and I will make your seed like the dust (עפר) of the earth.” And Abram tented and dwelt among the oaks of Mamre . *In Genesis 13, Lot’s choice of Sodom as a false-Eden was set in contrast to Avraham’s choice of the promised land, specifically “the oaks of Mamre” which is God’s gift of Eden to Avraham.
the field and the cave which is in it, and all the trees which are in (כל העץ אשר ב-) the field	Gen. 1:29 And God said to the human, “Behold I have given to you every plant bearing seed which is on the face of the land, and all the trees which are in it (כל העץ אשר ב).” Gen. 2:9 And Yahweh caused to sprout from the ground all the trees (כל עץ) that are desirable to look at
which is in all its border around (בכל ... סביב) to Avraham as a possession (למקנה) in the eyes of the sons of Heth, with all who enter the gate of his city.	Gen. 2:10-14 And a river went out from Eden to water (Hiph. שקה) the garden, and from there it separated (פרד) ... the Pishon it went all around (סבב) ... the Gihon it went all around (סבב) ... Gen. 10:15, 19 And Canaan bore Sidon his firstborn and Heth. ... And the border of the Canaanite was from Sidon as you go ... to Sodom and Gomorrah .

Genesis 23’s Hyperlinks to Earlier Narratives. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Abraham’s burial plot is described as a tiny refuge for the “naked pair” that is located in the middle of a field filled with trees, namely the sacred trees of Mamre. One couldn’t ask for a more rich and creative set of allusions back to the garden of Eden.

Reflection Question

How is the burial cave in the field of Makpelah connected to the garden of Eden and to the hope of resurrection?

Session 27: Jacob's Burial

Key Takeaways

- Yoseph goes up to Canaan, which contrasts with his going down to Egypt, highlighting the hope of a return to Eden threaded throughout the story of Genesis.
- The Egyptians embalm and mourn for Yaaqov, united with Yoseph's family in grief, showing how the blessed family of Abraham is sown among the nations.
- Yoseph imitates God as he comforts his brothers with the gift of reconciliation, demonstrating trust in God's faithfulness.
- In Genesis 50:19-21, Yoseph summarizes themes from the entire book of Genesis regarding God's plan to bring good out of evil and provide comfort to a world suffering under the consequences of sin.

Paragraph 2: Genesis 50:1-11

¹ And Yoseph fell upon the face of his father,
and he **wept** over him,
and he kissed him.

² And Yoseph commanded his servants **the healers (הרפאים)** to **embalm** his father,
and **the healers (הרפאים)** **embalmed** Yisra'el.

³ And they fulfilled for him **forty days**,
because this is how the days of the **embalmers** were fulfilled.
Then **Egypt** **wept** for him for **seventy days**.

A ⁴ And the days of **weeping** for him passed on,
and Yoseph said to the house of Phar'oh, saying,

"If, **please**, I have found favor in your eyes,
speak, **please**, in to ears of Phar'oh, saying,

⁵ 'My father made me **swear an oath**, saying,
"Look, I am about to die.

B In my **burial-grave** which I dug for myself in the land of Cana'an,
bury me there."

'And now, **may I go up**, **please**,
so I can **bury** my father,

and so I can return.”

⁶ And Phar’oh said,

A’ “Go up and bury your father,
just as he made you swear an oath.”

⁷ And Yoseph went up to bury his father,
and they went up with him,

a all the servants of Phar’oh,

b the elders of his house,

a’ and all the elders of the land of Egypt,

a ⁸ and all the house of Yoseph,

b and his brothers,

a’ and the house of his father.

Only their children and their flocks and their herds did they leave in the land of Goshen.

⁹ And they went up with him, both chariots and horsemen,
and the camp was heavy, very much.

¹⁰ And they came to the threshing floor of the thorn (= Goren-Ha’atad),
and they wept there a great and heavy weeping, very much,
and they performed grieving for their father, for seven days.

¹¹ And the inhabitant of the land, the Cana’anite, saw the grieving at the threshing floor of the thorn,
and they said,

“This is a heavy grieving for Egypt!”

For this reason, its name is called,

“Grief of Egypt” [= “Avel-Mitsrayim”]
which is across the Jordan.

Genesis 50:1-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

This central paragraph in 50:1-11 consists of three parts.

- A pair of matching outer sections that focus on the grief and weeping that took place at Yaaqov’s death (Gen. 50:1-3) and at his entry into the promised land (Gen. 50:10-11). Notice that both take place in matching periods of time that consists of a multiple of seven (70 days // 7 days).
- A pair of matching central sections that focus on Yoseph’s request for the burial procession (Gen. 50:4-6) and then on the narrative fulfillment of those requests (Gen. 50:7-9). The central unifying themes of these center units is the request to “go up” and “bury.”

Mummies and the Hope of the Afterlife

Egyptian mummies are well-known in our culture as a famous icon of ancient Near Eastern burial practices. In the final chapter of the Genesis scroll, which began with a story about humans losing access to eternal life, it

is no accident that we find ourselves focused on a contrast between Yaaqov's hope in the resurrection and the hope of the afterlife in Egyptian culture.

"It is well known that mummification, with all its elaborate ritual, played a crucial role in the Egyptian religion and was bound up with the cult of Osiris and conceptions of the afterlife. Survival of death was taken for granted by the Egyptians. Central to this notion was the belief in the importance of the physical preservation of the body. They took meticulous care to prevent the putrefaction of the corpse in order to ensure the right of the deceased to immortality. But the embalming of Jacob and Joseph is without any religious significance. In both cases the act is a purely practical measure, for Jacob is to be buried far from his place of death, and Joseph is to be reinterred many years later (v. 25). The text subtly underlines the disconnection of the embalming procedure from any pagan context by having Joseph entrust the task to 'physicians in his service.' It was not performed by professional mortuary priests. ... Detailed information on the embalming process is lacking for the ancient period, but is available from the 5th century B.C.E. and from the late Hellenistic period. Herodotus (Histories 2.86) reports that the body was placed in niter for seventy days. Diodorus of Sicily (Histories 1.91) describes a thirty-day dressing of the corpse with oils and spices and seventy-two days of public mourning for a king. Jacob is apparently being accorded royal honors."

Sarna, Nahum M. (2001). [*Genesis, The JPS Torah Commentary*](#). Jewish Publication Society. 347.

The Garden-Thorn Place

Notice how the outer sections both feature non-Israelites who participate in the mourning rituals or observe the intensity of grief.

- The scene in [Genesis 50:1-3](#) shows the Egyptians honoring Yaaqov with ritual mourning ("they wept") and with embalming, a custom that would ensure safe and honorable passage into the after life.
- The scene in [Genesis 50:10-11](#) takes place right after the procession crosses into the land of Canaan. Here, it's the Canaanites who observe the intensity of grief taking place among the Egyptians.

Notice the echoes of Eden in this story.

- Yaaqov dies (linking back to the exile from Eden and return to the dust).
- They stop at the "threshing floor of the thorn."
 - In Hebrew, "threshing floor" is *goren* (גרן), spelled with its first and last letters identical with the Hebrew word for "garden" (*gan* / גן).
 - The word "thorn" evokes the curse upon the ground from [Genesis 3:17-19](#), where the land of Adam and Eve's exile will become a land of "thorns and thistles."
- This short scene portrays Yaaqov's return to the Eden land promised to Yaaqov as a tragedy. The entire story so far creates a desire for humanity's return to Eden. And here is Yahweh's chosen one, finally returning after a long exile in Egypt, and he comes to the "Garden-Thorn" place deceased and unable to enjoy the blessings of Eden.
- Notice how the theme of "embalming" and "burial" highlights the ideas of the afterlife as Yaaqov is buried with his ancestors. While there is some comfort knowing that Yaaqov will be reunited with his ancestors upon his death, we are also at the same time disheartened. The hope was for the blessings of Eden to spread outside the garden, and all we have near the end of the Genesis scroll is a dead man returning to an Eden-like place at Makpelah.

Yoseph Reconciles With His Brothers

¹⁵ And the brothers of Yoseph saw that **their father was dead**, and they said,

“Surely, Yoseph will become one who opposes us, and he will certainly return to us all **the evil we repaid him**.”

¹⁶ And they commanded Yoseph, saying,

“**Your father** commanded **before his death**, saying,

¹⁷ ‘This is what you will say to Yoseph,

“Please **forgive the betrayal of your brothers**, and their failure, because of **the evil they repaid you**.””

So now, please **forgive the betrayal of the servants** of the **Elohim** of your fathers!”

And Yoseph wept as they spoke to him.

¹⁸ And also his brothers went and they fell before him and said,

“Look, we are **your servants**!”

¹⁹ And Yoseph said to them,

“**Do not be afraid**!

^a Indeed, am I in the place of Elohim?!

²⁰ As for you all, **you planned evil against me**.

^b **Elohim, he planned it for good**,

in order to accomplish what happened this day, **to preserve the lives** of a great many people.

^{a'} ²¹ So now, **do not be afraid**!

I will support you all and your children.”

And he brought them comfort,

and he spoke to their heart.

Genesis 50:15-21. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

The Satan, Esau, ... and Yoseph?

Yoseph's brothers are afraid Yoseph will enact vengeance on them now that their father is dead. Their speech cleverly activates the narrative pattern of sibling rivalry that began back in Genesis 3 and was carried forward through the pattern of Cain and Abel, as well as Yaaqov and Esau.

The brothers' speech among themselves uses the same rare word that was used of Esau's murderous anger against Yaaqov.

Perhaps he will hold become opposed to us (שטם) and repay us for all the evil we did to him.

Genesis 27:41 Instructor's Translation

And Esau **became opposed** (שטם) against Yaaqov for the blessing with which his father blessed him.

Additionally, this rare verb “satam” (שטם) is the verbal form of the Hebrew root “satan” (שטן), “to be opposed to, hostile against.” This scene links together all of the hostile siblings in Genesis and connects back to the original firstborn who became hostile to God’s younger chosen one: the humans on day six of creation.

The Reconciliation of the Family

The reconciliation of the brothers is a crucial theme in this scene.

“Abraham had two sons but they did not get on together. Isaac had two sons, but they parted forever. Not until Jacob’s twelve sons was the future firmly established. But precisely because they were a large number was there a danger of disunity and division. In the event there was dissension among them, so that they hated and persecuted the best of them. But eventually there was a complete reconciliation, not through the arbitration of a third party, but through the inner transformation of those who hated, for which the sufferer had waited and now in brotherly love acknowledges.”

Jacob, Benno (1974). [The Book of Genesis](#). Ktav Publishing House. 942.

In appealing to Yoseph for forgiveness, the brothers once again fulfill his dreams and activate the entire pattern of the older son serving the younger son.

Gen. 50:18 “And his brothers came and they **fell before him** and they said, ‘**Behold, we are your slaves** (עבד)”

Gen. 37:10 “Will I, your mother, and your brothers **bow down to you on the ground** ?”

Gen. 44:10 “Whoever is found to have your cup, he will die and **we will be your slaves** (עבד)”

Gen. 27:29 “May you be mighty for your brothers, and **your mothers sons will bow down to you** ”

Gen. 25:23 “Two nations are in your womb ... one people will be mightier than the other, **and the greater will serve** (עבד) the older.”

Genesis 50's Hyperlinks to Earlier Narratives. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph’s words to his brothers bring together all of the themes of the entire scroll up to this point. God keeps elevating surprising chosen ones to be the vehicle of his Eden-blessing to others. Humans, on the other hand,

keep twisting these Eden gifts toward self-advantage, hurting themselves and others in the process. Yoseph's summary is relevant not just for his brother's story, but for every generation of the Genesis scroll, which has been replaying the primal folly and evil of the first generations as told in [Genesis 1-6](#).

But God's purpose is to raise up a promised see who will endure through the hardships of life outside the garden, and whose surrender and suffering becomes a gateway of God's promise and Eden-blessing for others. Here we find an important forward hyperlink—Yoseph's "comfort" and "words for the heart" provide the poet of Isaiah 40 with the language to describe the return from Babylonian exile as a similar moment. What God's own people did for evil, Yahweh is able to counter and use to bring about something good.

Genesis 50:20-21

"You planned **evil** (רעה) against me, but God planned it for **good** (טבה), in order to do as on this day:

to save the lives (להחית) of **many people** (עם רב)." ...

"And he **comforted** **them** (נחם), **and he spoke to their heart** (דבר על לב)."

Genesis 1-11

Gen. 1-3 good (טוב) and **evil** (רע)

Gen. 6:5 "the heart of humanity was only **evil** (רעה) all the time"

Gen. 6:18-19 "and you will enter the ark ... and the animals ... **to save life** (להחית)"

Gen. 5:29 "He named him Noah for he said, 'This one will **comfort us** ...' (נחם)

Isaiah 40:1

" **Comfort, comfort** (נחם) **my people** , **speak to the heart** (דבר על לב) **of Jerusalem** ."

Genesis 50's Hyperlinks to Earlier Narratives and Isaiah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

"[Genesis 46-50](#) shows how Joseph relates to Genesis' larger story of creation and covenant. Covenantal ... themes emerge quite prominently in Joseph's story, but only after the reconciliation between Joseph and his brothers. This order is significant. Fraternal conflict has plagued the covenant family and endangered the seed promise as far back as Cain and Abel. Joseph's reconciliation with his brothers, however, triggers an advance in covenant history. ... In Joseph, God reverses the status quo of violence against the covenant line. The reconciliation of the family is a demonstration that God is reversing the curse, turning evil in on itself, and advancing his cause in the world."

Emadi, Samuel (2018). [Covenant, Typology, and the Story of Joseph](#). Tyndale Bulletin, Volume 69.1. 94.

Reflection Question

How do Yoseph's words and perspective in Genesis 50:19-21 relate to the themes in the rest of the book of Genesis?

Session 28: Joseph's Future Hope

Key Takeaways

- The pattern of migrations in Genesis, as Abraham and his descendants move up and down from Canaan, reflects the pattern of moving from blessing to exile to redemption woven throughout the Hebrew Bible.
- Yoseph's request for his bones to be taken up to Canaan is a prophetic declaration of hope and trust in God's promises to bring life and blessing to the world.

Yoseph's Request and Death

²² And Yoseph **dwelt in Egypt**, he and the house of his father,
and Yoseph lived one hundred and ten years,
²³ and Yoseph saw for **Ephraim** sons of three generations,
also the sons of Makir, son of **Manasseh** were born on the knees of Yoseph.

²⁴ And Yoseph said to his brothers,
"I am about to **die**,
and Elohim will most certainly visit you all,
and he will bring up you all from this land,
into the land which **he swore on oath** to Avraham, to Yitskhaq, and to Ya'akov."

²⁵ And Yoseph made the sons of Yisra'el **swear an oath**, saying,
"Elohim will most certainly visit you all,
and you all will bring up my bones from this place."

²⁶ **And Yoseph died**, **a son of one hundred and ten years**.
And they embalmed him,
and **they set him in a box in Egypt**.

Genesis 50:22-26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Like Father, Like Son, in Life and in Death

Yoseph's deathbed scene has been designed to parallel the deathbed scene of his father Yaaqov. The following chart makes the verbal similarities clear.

Yaaqov's Death Scene: Genesis 48:21-22	Yoseph's Death Scene: Genesis 50:24
And Israel said to Yoseph, " Behold I am about to die , and God will be with you and he will return you all to the land of your fathers."	And Yoseph said to his brothers, " I am about to die , and God will surely visit you all and he will make you all go up from this land to the land he swore to Abraham, Isaac, and Yaaqov."
Gen. 50:5 My father made me swear an oath ... you will bury me in the grave which I dug for myself in the land of Canaan .	Gen. 50:24 "God will surely visit you and he will make you go up from this land to the land which he swore on oath to Abraham, Isaac, and to Yaaqov."
Gen. 50:6 And Pharaoh said, " Go up and bury your father just as he made you swear an oath ."	Gen. 50:25 And Yoseph made the sons of Israel swear an oath saying, "God will surely visit you and you will make my bones go up from here ."
Gen. 50:7, 9 And Yoseph went up to bury his father and the servants of Pharaoh went up with him. ... And there went up with him chariots and horsemen."	
<i>Jacob and Joseph's Deaths. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Yaaqov makes Yoseph swear an oath to "go up" to the land with his corpse, to bury him with his forefathers. // Yoseph makes his brothers swear an oath to "go up" to the land with his bones when God visits them. This is all about the hope of resurrection (corpse and bones) linked to the end of exile and return to the promised land (Ezek. 36-37!!).

- Yaaqov's corpse "going up" by the son. // Yoseph's bones "going up" by the brothers.
- This is an inverted Aqedah scheme: The son who swears on oath (Gen. 22:16) to make his father's corpse "go up" (עלה, Gen. 22:3, 7-8, 13, 22) from exile to the promised land. // The son makes his brothers swear on oath to make his bones "go up" from exile to the promised land.

Yoseph's Bones and the Pre-Exodus

Yoseph's "pre-exodus" from Egypt in partnership with Pharaoh is portrayed as a strong contrast to the later exodus that will be resisted by Pharaoh.

Pharaoh and Yoseph in Genesis 50	Pharaoh and Moses
Gen. 50:9-10 Pharaoh generously provides “chariots” (רכב) and horsemen (פרשים) and “a very heavy camp” (מחנה כבד מאד)	Exod. 12:38 The Israelites leave Egypt “with flocks and herds, and very heavy flocks (מקנה כבד מאד)” Exod. 14:23-24 Pharaoh chases after Israel with his “chariots” (רכב) and horsemen (פרשים), as “the camp of Egypt” (מחנה מצרים)
Gen. 50:1-14 Yoseph carries the body of Yaaqov out of Egypt Gen. 50:24-25 Yoseph predicts that “God will surely visit you” (פקד יפקד), and he made them swear an oath “that you will take up my bones from there”	Exod. 13:19 Moses carries the bones of Yoseph out of Egypt “for he made the sons of Israel swear an oath saying, ‘God will surely visit you (פקד יפקד), and you will take my bones from there with you.’”
<i>Pharaoh Dealing with Joseph and Moses. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

This is part of a much larger strategy throughout [Genesis 40-50](#) and [Exodus 1-14](#) to portray the two pharaohs as contrasting opposites: The Pharaoh in Yoseph’s day recognizes the promised seed and “blessed” him and experiences blessing in return. The Pharaoh in Moses’ day plays the role of the snake and tries to destroy the promised seed, and he finds himself cursed and destroyed in the process.

Reflection Question

In what way does Yoseph’s burial request act as a prophetic image for the shape of the rest of the Hebrew Bible?

Session 29: Reflecting on the Joseph Story

Key Takeaways

- Every detail of the biblical text is thoughtfully crafted and divinely inspired. Taking time to consider why a certain story or narrative element has been included can reveal deep meaning and connection to the big picture of the whole Bible's message.
- The story of Yoseph illustrates how God is at work, often behind the scenes, to work *tov* ("good") in the world he created.
- The Bible is beautiful, artistic literature, but even more so, it points to the ultimate source of beauty.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

Take some time to reflect on the insights you learned in this class.